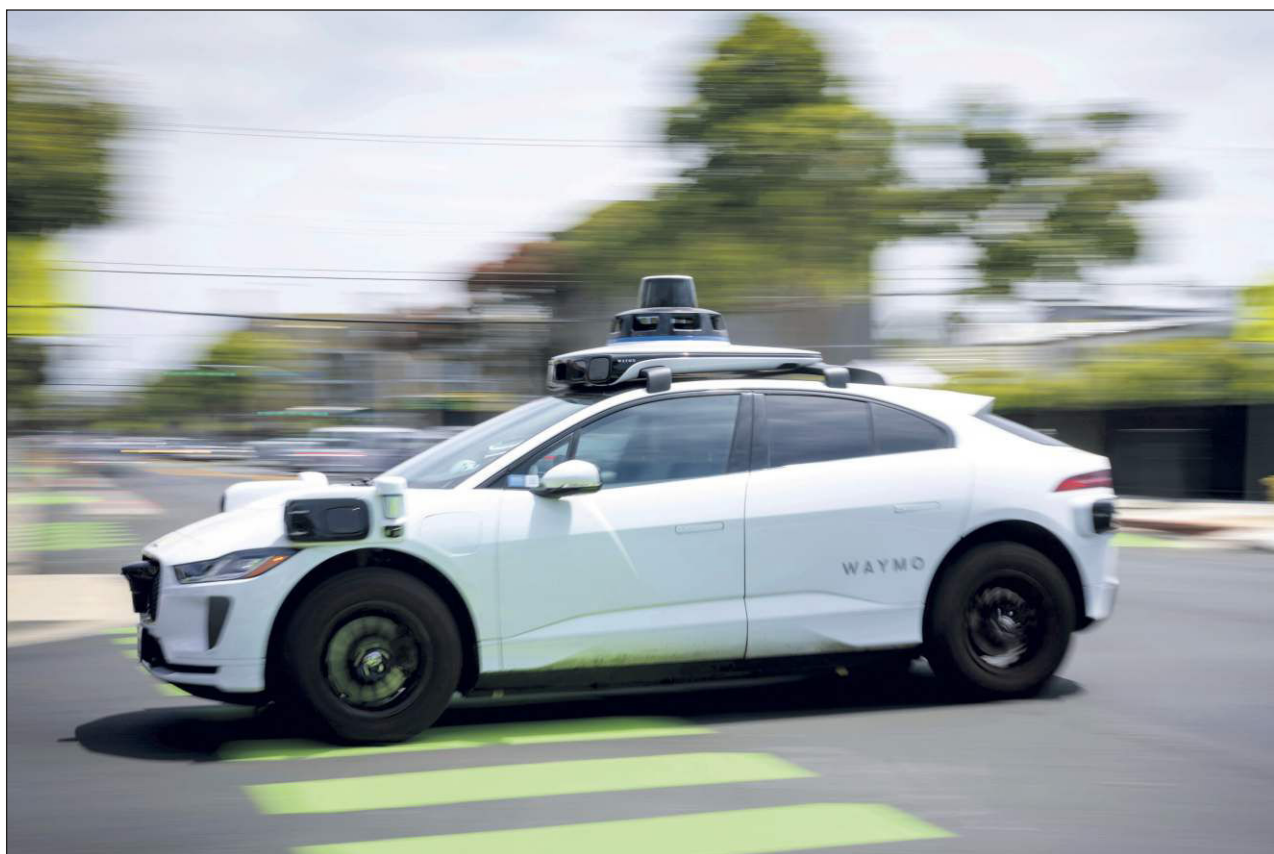




A WAYMO in Santa Monica in May. Accidents involving Waymo vehicles tripled last year in L.A. County. ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

Accuser joined by an army of ‘Jane Does’

Solidarity surges for woman suing Cornell and 7 men she says sexually assaulted her.

By DEEPTI HAJELA

NEW YORK — It was one woman, then another, and another, until a trickle became a flood.

Countless women, and some men, posting on social media that they were Jane Doe, in support of a young woman using that name to file a lawsuit against Cornell University and seven fraternity members she accuses of raping her.

For many, claiming the name came along with sharing personal accounts of being sexually abused and assaulted, joining the wave of solidarity that has surged since journalists at the college’s independent student newspaper reported on the lawsuit filing late last month.

The impetus for some of those claiming the name was a desire to offer the woman some protection in this digital age, in response to those wanting to identify her real name online. They hope the flood of “I am Jane Doe” posts will confuse online algorithms.

The posts have come in all formats — video, photo, text — across the landscape of social media platforms.

The outcry reminds many of the energy at the heights of the #MeToo movement, which exploded a decade ago. Back then women posted their stories of sexual harassment and assault, as allegations surfaced against movie producer Harvey Weinstein, using the hashtag phrase, which had been introduced in that context a decade earlier.

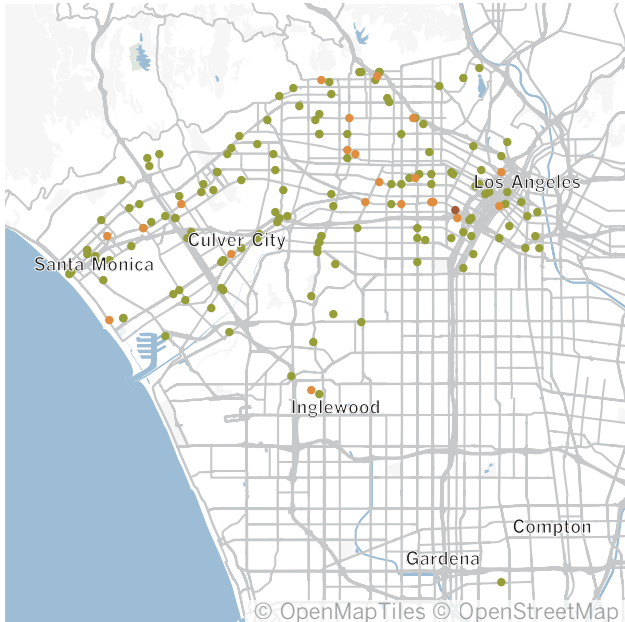
“These moments ... are encouraging more women to speak up and tell their stories,” said Emma Davidson Tribbs, founding director of the National Women’s Defense League. “They are giving people a level of bravery and comfort to come forward and speak their truth. And they can be incredibly catalyzing for change.”

Change is what Wendy Lea Brewer wants to see, and that inspired her to post [See Cornell, A6]

More robotaxis, more crashes: A dive into data

Most crashes involving Waymos resulted in no apparent injuries

- Suspected serious injury
- Suspected minor and possible injury
- No injury



Of 485 crashes from March 1, 2023, to Aug. 3, 2026, only 166 had specific location information. Seventy-eight percent of accidents without address information occurred in the city of Los Angeles. California Autonomous Vehicle Crash Dashboard HAILEY WANG Los Angeles Times

By CAROLINE PETROW-COHEN

As more driverless cars hit Los Angeles streets, accidents involving them have surged.

Accidents tied to Mountain View, Calif.-based Waymo tripled last year in L.A. County as it put more robotaxis on the road. The vehicles still had relatively few incidents, and most were fender benders, according to a Times review of autonomous vehicle crash data filed with the National Highway Traffic Safety Administration.

Amazon’s Zoox already is testing its driverless vehicles in L.A., and Tesla’s Cybercab and others are expected to follow suit.

Waymo, Zoox and Cybercab operate in many cities, but California still serves as a test site for robotaxi technology, said Matthew Raifman, who studies autonomous vehicles at UC Berkeley’s Safe Transportation Research and Education Center and compiled a dashboard of robotaxi accidents using government data.

“As a testing bed place in [See Waymo, A8]



CLUB founder George Jensen records audio of fowl at a wildlife reserve. KAYLA BARTKOWSKI Los Angeles Times

Float away on the city’s sounds

L.A.’s Field Recording Club explores and listens

By MICHELLE MADDEN

On an atypically muggy evening in Highland Park, several Angelenos sit beneath a shade sail in a parking lot behind the Bearded Beagle vintage shop on Figueroa. A pandemonium of parrots screeches by, a siren wails in the distance, a helicopter chops the air above. But these folks have their ears trained on something else. Coming from two high-performance speakers arranged before the group? The sounds of a fax machine.

The group is silent and still, reverently absorbing the mechanical chug of this nearly outmoded office machine like Hollywood Bowl-goers taking in Joshua Bell. When the recording ends, everyone claps enthusiastically.

This is a listening session hosted by the Los Angeles Field Recording Club.

Field recording is most simply defined as recording sounds outside a controlled [See Sounds, A5]

Trump visits to red states signal midterm worry

Polls show he’s a liability in close races, so he rallies his base on safer terrain.

By ANA CEBALLOS

DURANT, Okla. — David Coleman doesn’t know much about the Republican candidates who are running in November. But he knows President Trump, and he trusts that the president won’t steer him wrong.

The 54-year-old Oklahoman made his way to Trump’s midterm rally in Durant on Thursday planning to support whomever Trump brought onstage with him.

“I am going to ask ChatGPT what their name is and vote for them,” Coleman said as he and thousands of others waited for the president to appear.

Trump is focusing on voters such as Coleman — who are fiercely loyal to the president but only loosely attached to the rest of the Republican ticket — in the final stretch before the Nov. 3 election.

Rather than prioritizing visits to battleground dis-

tricts, which will decide which party controls Congress, Trump is rallying in Republican strongholds such as Texas, Oklahoma and Alabama, betting that his presence will be enough to energize a base that may be thinking about sitting out the election because his name isn’t on the ballot.

In Oklahoma, Trump told the crowd to imagine he is on the ballot because the future of his “America first” agenda depends on Republicans getting out to vote. He then urged them to vote for GOP candidates such as Senate candidates Ken Paxton of Texas and Kevin Hern of Oklahoma.

“You have to get out and vote,” Trump said. “You can’t assume they are going to win.”

The red-state itinerary is a departure from what Trump initially promised to do in the 30 days leading up to the midterms. At a Rose Garden dinner with Republican lawmakers last month, he pledged to campaign in the country’s 35 most competitive districts. But in many of those races, the president is proving to be a political liability as his approval dwindles, even [See Trump, A4]

Coal project may be bigger, dirtier

Oakland terminal would be larger and more polluting than planned, report says.

By HAYLEY SMITH

A controversial planned coal export facility in California backed by President Trump may be far dirtier than locals have been led to believe, new documents show.

Widespread opposition has prevented any new coal export facility on the West Coast until now.

If it is built, more than 13 million tons of coal will be shipped each year from interior states to the West Gateway terminal in Oakland and stored in enormous open-air piles before being sent overseas, according to a recent report prepared for potential investors. That’s despite previous promises

by project developers to build a modern, fully enclosed facility that will limit dangerous dust exposure to the surrounding community.

The site is the Oakland Bulk and Oversized Terminal, a decommissioned Army base near the Port of Oakland run by developer Phil Tagami, who has been trying for years to turn it into a marine shipping terminal. Tagami did not respond to requests for comment.

It would be the largest coal export site on the U.S. West Coast, transporting coal to Japan, South Korea, Taiwan, Vietnam and Malaysia, according to the Trump administration. The president announced a \$75-million investment in the project in June, about a third of its estimated cost, although some figures are much higher.

California spent decades moving away from coal, and [See Coal, A5]

Voices PATT MORRISON COLUMNIST

The winding history of our GLDN ST8 PL8S

Your answer, please — and no going out to the garage and peeking:

What are the colors of the California license plate?

Just hazard a guess. You must see them a gazillion times a day.

Fine. They’re blue on white. But you could have said gold on black, or even red on white, and you’d have been right.

Ever since California issued its first license plates, in 1914, it’s been trying to keep up with our passion for automobiles.

We now stand at a smidge over 39 million Californians and a smidge over 36 million registered vehicles. Even AI can’t speculate on how many cars have rolled over the roads here in the decades since 1914, but the state has been ever harder pressed to keep changing plate colors and numbers and letters to match those numbers and to dodge any duplication.

And now the DMV has made its latest switcheroo. Since 1980, regular plates have been constructed as number-letter-letter-number-number-number. That entire combination has now run out, so California license plates began this year using number-number-number-letter-letter-letter-number.

Oh for those simpler days — like 1905, when California first required “motor cars” to be registered, but didn’t issue license plates. Drivers sometimes made their own, carved from wood, stamped onto metal, the numbers mounted on screens, or painted onto boards.

In 1914, the state realized it had better get a handle on this, a way to distinguish all of those thousands of black Ford Model Ts from one another, and to put some dough in the state’s road repair kitty while they were at it.

Voila, universal regis- [See Morrison, A6]

Rams rally to stun Eagles

L.A. overcomes a host of miscues to outscore Philadelphia 14-0 in the 4th quarter for much-needed win. **SPORTS, D1**

Culver CityBus driver mourned

Community gathers to say goodbye to Bruce Rodriguez. A suspect in his fatal shooting is in custody. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Translating a mogul’s rebrand

After naming his new empire Skydance, David Ellison’s message is clear: Hollywood is his. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather Very hot. L.A. Basin: 103/79. **B6**



U.S. Marine, 20, held in killing of Japanese woman

It is latest criminal incident involving Americans stationed at a base on Okinawa.

By MARI YAMAGUCHI

TOKYO — Japanese police arrested a U.S. Marine in the robbery and killing of a woman on Okinawa, officials said Sunday, the latest criminal case on the southern island where the heavy American troop presence has remained a sensitive issue.

The Okinawa prefectural police said they arrested a 20-year-old stationed at the Marine Corps Air Station Futenma on suspicion of killing a 39-year-old local woman at a hotel in Naha, Okinawa's capital city, and taking her wallet and backpack early Saturday.

Kyodo News agency, citing the police, reported the woman's body was found in her hotel room and she appeared to have been strangled to death.

Police said security camera video showed the man believed to be the suspect entering the hotel with the victim and coming out alone. An officer arrested the suspect after spotting him walking alone on a street in Naha's entertainment district late Saturday, Kyodo said.

"The case deals a major shock and adds fear to the Okinawans who have already been forced to live next to U.S. bases," newly elected Okinawa Gov. Genta Koja told reporters. "It is absolutely unforgivable and we are outraged."

"I must say, discipline and troop education are not working at all," Koja added, referring to the U.S. military's measures taken in response to past criminal cases.

About 50,000 U.S. troops are deployed in Japan under a bilateral security pact, about half of them on Okinawa, whose strategic role is seen as increasingly important for the Japan-U.S. military alliance amid growing tensions with China. Japan's southwestern shift in its military focus centers heavily on Okinawa and its nearby islands.

Okinawans have long complained about noise, pollution and crime related to U.S. bases, with crimes involving American service members on Okinawa com-

plicating ties between Japan's central government and the Okinawa administration. The latest case comes as Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi's Cabinet pushes to further fortify its Japanese military presence on Okinawa and work more closely with the U.S. military.

"The occurrence of the heinous crime is extremely regrettable," Takaichi said in a message on X. She said her government has strongly protested to the U.S. side and demanded complete cooperation with the Japanese authorities in the investigation, as well as tougher discipline for U.S. service members and preventive measures.

Foreign Minister Toshimitsu Motegi summoned U.S. Ambassador to Japan George Glass to his office and conveyed "outrage," the ministry said in a statement.

Glass, on X, expressed condolences to the victim's family, adding that the United States is cooperating with the Japanese national and local governments.

The U.S. Marine Corps said in a statement that the suspect is assigned to the III Marine Expeditionary Force on Okinawa and that it is fully cooperating with Japanese authorities. "The Marine Corps takes these allegations very seriously and expects every Marine to adhere to the highest standards of behavior."

The Futenma base, located in a densely populated area in central Okinawa, has been a sore spot for many Okinawans for decades, who demanded its relocation. Despite protests, the central government green-lighted construction to relocate the base to Henoko on Okinawa's eastern coast, though the project has faced delays.

A high-profile 1995 rape of a 12-year-old girl by three American service members sparked massive protests against the heavy U.S. troop presence on Okinawa. The number of arrests related to U.S. service members and their families exceeded 100 last year, according to prefectural police. Repeated occurrence of sexual crimes and some of their delayed disclosures have also sparked outrage on Okinawa in recent years.

Yamaguchi writes for the Associated Press.

U.S. deports ex-political prisoner

Dissident allegedly tortured for opposing Ortega is swiftly jailed again in Nicaragua.

By KATE LINTHICUM AND ISMAEL LÓPEZ

A former political prisoner who said he was tortured for leading protests against Nicaragua's authoritarian government was arrested and jailed immediately after he was deported there from the United States last week, according to relatives and human rights advocates.

Jeffrey Jarquín, 35, was taken directly from the deportation flight to Nicaragua's notorious Modelo prison, where he had been held previously for participating in pro-democracy marches that were violently repressed by President Daniel Ortega.

Jarquín was among thousands of Nicaraguans who took to the streets in 2018 to demand Ortega's resignation and free elections.

He helped occupy two public universities and later took refuge inside a small Catholic church as it came under fire from pro-government militia forces — an incident that became emblematic of the country's embattled protest movement.

Jarquín, who was imprisoned for nine months, told journalists and human rights investigators afterward that guards burned his genitals with cigarette butts. Released in 2019, he spent a short period in Costa Rica and later sought political asylum in the United States.

The Trump administration has levied sanctions on Ortega and his family members and has repeatedly criticized his government, with Juan Pablo Segura, deputy assistant secretary of State for Western Hemisphere affairs, describing it recently as a "brutal dictatorship that is stealing, lying and murdering."

Yet journalists, human rights advocates and political dissidents who were per-



PROTESTERS at an anti-government march in Managua, Nicaragua, in 2019.

secuted for promoting democracy in Nicaragua are increasingly being targeted for deportation as the Trump administration narrows access to asylum and expands the pool of migrants eligible for removal.

U.S. immigration agents have recently begun arresting members of a high-profile group of Nicaraguan political prisoners who were freed in a 2023 State Department deal, flown to the U.S. and granted temporary humanitarian parole and the chance to apply for asylum.

The U.S. has sent some Nicaraguan migrants as far away as Africa under a Trump administration program that deports asylum seekers and others to "third countries" where they have no ties.

But other Nicaraguans are being sent home, despite warnings from human rights advocates that such deportations may violate the international ban on "refoulement" — returning someone to a country where they face persecution or torture.

"The United States sent him to the very prisons where he had already been tortured," said Muriel Sáenz, an activist who represented Jarquín during an immigration bond hearing.

Jarquín, she said, is a victim of political persecution

who has been sent "back into the hands of his tormentors."

Jarquín was arrested in Miami in February after being accused of assault. A judge dismissed the case, but while Jarquín was detained, immigration agents initiated deportation proceedings against him. An immigration judge denied him asylum, according to his advocates.

They said Jarquín agreed to be deported but asked to be sent to a third country. Instead he was put on a plane to Managua last week.

U.S. deportations to Nicaragua have risen sharply under Trump. An analysis of government data by Human Rights Watch found that the U.S. deported more than 6,300 Nicaraguans between January and July of this year, compared with 3,323 during the same period in 2025.

In Miami's Nicaraguan community, Jarquín was known as a vocal opponent of the Sandinista government, often carrying a megaphone to protests. He posted photos on social media of himself alongside U.S. Republican leaders who have also criticized Ortega, including U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio.

At 81, Ortega is the longest-serving leader in the

Americas. He rules the country with his co-president and wife, Rosario Murillo.

The pair, former revolutionaries who decades ago helped overthrow a brutal right-wing dictatorship, have tightened their grip on power in recent years, closing media outlets and non-governmental organizations and jailing or expelling virtually all of their political opponents.

Nicaragua's government did not respond to inquiries about the Jarquín case.

His friends and family members say they don't know when they will see him again.

"His life is in danger back in Nicaragua," said Ronnell López, a friend. "We demand that the dictatorship ... respect his life and safety."

"For Nicaraguan deportees, the risk of persecution is real," said Juan Pappier, deputy director of the Americas division at Human Rights Watch. "The United States government knows Nicaragua is one of the most authoritarian governments in the hemisphere and should take robust steps to ensure nobody is sent back to torture or abuse."

Linthicum reported from Mexico City and López from Jacksonville, Fla.

UAE had shared FlyDubai flight details

By MELANIE LIDMAN AND SAMY MAGDY

TEL AVIV — Authorities in the United Arab Emirates shared with Israel a list of passengers and crew ahead of the FlyDubai flight on which a pilot attempted to seize control of the Israel-bound aircraft and crash it, regional officials said Sunday, raising new questions over how the attacker evaded detection.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu later told the head of the National Security Council to appoint an examiner to review "all security aspects regarding foreign civil aviation to Israel."

With the investigation into the FlyDubai incident underway, preliminary details have highlighted several major security lapses. Officials already have said the Omani co-pilot had been barred from flying by his own country because of concerns about his extremist views.

It also remains unclear how a citizen of Oman, an Arab country that has no diplomatic relations with Israel, was allowed to help fly a planeload of Israelis to Tel Aviv.

The UAE, which is leading the investigation, said the co-pilot attacked the flight's captain with the cockpit's crash ax and tried to take control of the plummeting plane in a "terrorist attack" Wednesday. His actions nearly crashed the flight with 182 people on board before the wounded Indian captain managed to open the cockpit door, allowing passengers and others to rush in and subdue the attacker.



DUBAI'S crown prince, Sheikh Hamdan bin Mohammed al Maktoum, left, visits pilot Smit Machchhar.

Israel did not raise any concerns

The regional officials said Emirati authorities had shared information about the passengers and crew, including their nationalities. Israel hadn't raised red flags on any passenger or member of the crew, said the officials, who spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to speak to reporters about the inquiry.

The Shin Bet, Israel's domestic security agency, said the Transportation Ministry is responsible for vetting passenger lists from foreign flights. Transportation Minister Miri Regev said on X that the security agencies are responsible for flight security and that her ministry wasn't given a list of passengers or any warnings.

Sharing the list is standard aviation procedure. But the head of aviation security at the Transportation Ministry, Dvir Rubinstein, told

Army Radio that the ministry relies on local security checks and does not have the tools or the ability to run checks on each passenger on every flight.

Netanyahu said Thursday that Israel has longstanding agreements with foreign carriers to keep pilots from flying into the country if they are citizens of nations that don't maintain diplomatic relations with Israel.

Australian police said Sunday that counterterrorism investigators were looking into the attacker's possible connections to Australia.

The passengers who halted the attack and helped regain control of the aircraft have been hailed as heroes in Israel.

Questions about security failures

But as the initial euphoria of the rescue has subsided, officials have begun

to raise difficult questions and trade accusations about the security blunders that could have led to a major disaster.

Ahead of Israeli elections at the end of the month, some opposition candidates have seized on the security failures to highlight what they perceive as negligence on the part of Netanyahu and his supporters. Regev, the transportation minister, is a member of Netanyahu's Likud party and a staunch supporter.

"This is exactly what system collapse looks like," Yair Golan, head of the opposition Democrats party, wrote on X. "A transportation minister who completely abandons our skies, and a prime minister who abandons national security."

It also remains unclear how FlyDubai, a low-cost Emirati airline that operates flights between Israel and the UAE, had failed to identify the Omani pilot as a security risk.

Philip Baum, a visiting professor of aviation security at Coventry University in England who wrote a book about aircraft hijackings and bombings, said that background check systems differ from country to country and that there are limits on what types of information can be shared.

"In terms of aviation security itself, obviously we want to have as robust background checks as possible. But there are huge limitations on doing background checks in any case, especially in cross-border checks," he said.

Lidman and Magdy write for the Associated Press.

How to contact us

(800) LA TIMES

Home Delivery and Membership Program

For questions about delivery, billing and vacation holds, or for information about our Membership program, please contact us at (213) 283-2274 or customerservices@latimes.com. You can also manage your account at myaccount.latimes.com.

Letters to the Editor

Want to write a letter to be published in the paper and online? E-mail letters@latimes.com. For submission guidelines, see latimes.com/letters.

Readers' Representative

If you are calling to request a clarification or correction, or you have questions about a story, video or other content, please email readers.representative@latimes.com or leave a message at (877) 554-4000.

Advertising

For print and online advertising information, go to latimes.com/mediakit or call (213) 237-6176.

Reprint Requests

For the rights to use articles, photos, graphics and page reproductions, e-mail reprint@latimes.com or call (213) 237-4565.

Times In Education

To get the digital Los Angeles Times at no cost (along with our newspaper-based teaching materials), contact us at latimes.com/tie, or email monika.khare@latimes.com.

The Newsroom

Know something important we should cover? Send a secure tip at latimes.com/tips. To send a press release go to the newsroom directory at latimes.com/staff.

Media Relations

For outside media requests and inquiries, e-mail commsdept@latimes.com.

L.A. Times Store

Search archives, merchandise and front pages at latimes.com/store.

Los Angeles Times

A California Times Publication
Founded Dec. 4, 1881
Vol. CXLV No. 306

LOS ANGELES TIMES
(ISSN 0458-3035)
is published by the Los Angeles Times,
2300 E. Imperial Highway, El Segundo, CA
90245. Periodicals postage is paid at Los
Angeles, CA, and additional cities.
POSTMASTER: Send address changes to
the above address.

Home Delivery Subscription Rates (all rates
include applicable CA sales taxes and apply
to most areas)

Print + unlimited digital rates:
Seven-day \$42/week, \$2,184 annually.
Thursday-Sunday \$22/week, \$1,144
annually. Thursday & Sunday \$14/week,
\$728 annually. Saturday & Sunday
\$13/week, \$676 annually.
Sunday \$12/week, \$624 annually.
Monday-Saturday \$24/week, \$1,248
annually (also includes Sundays, except
3/29, 5/24, 9/6, 10/1). Monday-Friday
\$24/week, \$1,248 annually.



Claim your share of our future.

Invest now.



THE NATION

When is war not ‘war’? In Iran, according to U.S.

As the conflict drags on, his administration avoids the word, as does Trump, at times.

By Christopher Buchanan

WASHINGTON — Late September in the Oval Office, President Trump declared, “Iran will never have a nuclear weapon. We’re gonna win that war very soon.”

It wasn’t the first time he’s described the hostilities as “war.”

On Feb. 28, the day U.S. and Israeli began bombarding Iran, he warned that “the lives of courageous American heroes may be lost, and we may have casualties. That often happens in war, but we’re doing this not for now. We’re doing this for the future, and it is a noble mission.”

But throughout seven months of back-and-forth strikes with Iran, Trump administration officials, and sometimes Trump himself, have performed verbal acrobatics to avoid the “W” word.

Senior administration officials loosely tossed around “war” during the first stages of conflict, but with polls showing the war unpopular and congressional support waning, “war” and even “Operation Epic Fury” have become taboo among members of the Trump administration.

Trump has called attacks on Iran a “military operation,” “military decimation,” “excursion” and “skirmish.”

At a White House news briefing last month, Vice President JD Vance attempted to clear the air when a reporter asked about a potential end to what she called a “war in Iran.”

“I wouldn’t call it a war right now,” Vance said. “Major combat operations lasted for about six weeks.”

Defense Secretary Pete



VAHID SALEMI Associated Press

SMOKE rises after a U.S.-Israeli strike March 8 on a Tehran oil storage facility.

Hegseth tread carefully in front of the Senate Appropriations Committee in July, repeatedly referring to a “conflict” in Iran that needed additional funding to continue.

On May 5, during the first of two delicate ceasefires with Iran, Secretary of State Marco Rubio announced an end to the objectives laid out in Operation Epic Fury and the beginning of “Project Freedom” — an effort to escort merchant ships through the Strait of Hormuz.

In April, Trump announced the blockade of Iranian ports.

When asked whether the blockade constituted an act of war, Rubio replied, “That’s not an act of war, that’s a defensive measure. It’s a counter to what they have decided to do.”

Senior Trump officials have maintained that the conflict can no longer be viewed as war because the intensity of strikes between the two countries has been reduced.

The “end” of Operation Epic Fury, the name Trump

used when he announced hostilities on Feb. 28, was declared on May 5 — 60 days after the fighting began.

The timing was no coincidence. Under the War Powers Resolution of 1973, a president must cease all hostilities abroad after 60 days if there is no congressional declaration of war.

Legal and political considerations

Under the Constitution, only Congress declares war, but past presidents have routinely circumvented this rule by exercising their authority to direct the military and initiate strikes on targeted nations.

Nearly every modern president, from Dwight D. Eisenhower to Trump, has used this justification to undertake military action without the declaratory approval of Congress.

Congress can also choose to approve an Authorization for Use of Military Force, which grants the president legal authority to conduct military operations overseas.

Unless Congress sets a time limit on the authorization, authority to use the legal justification to launch military strikes can theoretically span multiple administrations.

Rep. Jamie Raskin (D-Md.), a former constitutional law professor at American University, said that presidents of both parties have avoided the term “war” when attempting to evade congressional approval of hostile action abroad.

“Trump has followed some of his predecessors in playing word games with the war power,” Raskin said. “What makes his case so extreme is that he proudly described it as a war and depicted it in glorified military terms.”

In March, seven days into the fighting, Trump said, “The war itself is going unbelievably. It’s as good as it can be.”

Congress has not officially declared war since World War II. The Vietnam War, the invasion of Afghanistan and both wars in Iraq were all approved by

Congress under the umbrella of an Authorization for the Use of Military Force.

This year Congress has not approved such an authorization for the action with Iran. Fourteen Senate votes for a War Powers Resolution to curb Trump’s war efforts have failed in the chamber so far.

According to a CNN/SSRS poll last month, only 26% of Americans approve of the Trump administration’s handling of the Iran war.

Raskin said that he believes Trump’s terminology has shifted with the public mood, adding that he hasn’t heard any of his Republican colleagues “play along with the semantic games.”

“When things have turned south in the fortunes of this war, he has tried to pretend it’s something else,” Raskin said. “I think that has just further enraged the population.”

Congressional war power over years

The administration’s declaration that Operation Epic Fury had concluded echoed May 2003, when then-President George W. Bush stood in front of a banner reading “Mission Accomplished” aboard the USS Abraham Lincoln, about six weeks after Operation Iraqi Freedom began.

“Major combat operations in Iraq have ended,” Bush said. “And now our coalition is engaged in securing and reconstructing that country.”

Despite the victory lap, combat operations in Iraq and across the Middle East continued through the aughts. The Iraq war wouldn’t officially end until 2011, with President Obama’s signature.

Obama himself relied heavily on the 2001 Authorization for the Use of Military Force — passed by Congress under Bush — in his military campaign against the extremist group Islamic State during his presidency.

According to Council on Foreign Relations data, Obama launched 542 drone strikes and killed 3,797 people in Yemen, Pakistan and Somalia without renewed approval from Congress.

A case more analogous to Trump’s comes in former President Truman’s unilateral decision to deploy U.S. troops to Korea in 1950. The Truman administration forwent congressional approval altogether and used United Nations Security Council resolutions to justify the intervention against communist forces in the north, according to a White House news release from the time.

There were many critics of this exercise of executive war powers, most notably Ohio Republican Sen. Robert A. Taft, who argued that Truman had usurped congressional war powers.

However, that Congress still provided monetary support, granting Truman military funds and extensions to the draft to raise additional troops for the Korean War effort. According to historical Gallup polls, 78% of Americans in 1950 approved of U.S. intervention in Korea.

Presidential slips in avoiding the word

Although Vance and other administration officials continue to avoid “war,” it does slip out now and then. Trump has been, perhaps, the most discordant messenger of the administration when discussing Iran.

After referring to the “war” on social media and public interviews more than a dozen times, Trump backed Vance’s comments about the Iran war no longer being active as he spoke to reporters in the Oval Office in September. He refuses to call the conflict a “war,” Trump said, because “you are supposed to get approval.”

“I call it a military conflict, because it’s small potatoes for us,” Trump said.

Christa Pike unconscious since failed execution

The inmate is on a ventilator in a Tennessee hospital, her lawyer says.

By Jeffrey Collins

Christa Pike has remained unconscious and on a ventilator at a hospital in the four days since her failed execution in Tennessee, and her prognosis might not be known for days more, one of her lawyers said Sunday.

Little has been released about Pike’s condition since Wednesday night’s execution attempt. She has since remained hospitalized under guard as doctors try to get the massive dose of the barbiturate pentobarbital out of her system.

When asked on CNN’s “State of the Union” whether Pike ever regained consciousness after the execution attempt, her lawyer Assistant Federal Defender Stephen Ferrell said, “Not that I am aware of.”

Medical decisions made by others

Pike, now 50, was 18 when she and her boyfriend tortured and killed a classmate, 19-year-old Colleen Slemmer, in a jealous rage in 1995. She became one of the youngest women to be sent to death row.

Tennessee prison officials gave Pike two doses of the lethal injection drug on Wednesday night. The pentobarbital didn’t kill her, but her lawyers said her arms were burned and blistered from the caustic drugs.

Pike gave someone her medical power of attorney, and that person is protecting her privacy, Ferrell said.

“I’m not sure what all they may have told that person,” Ferrell said.

Pike’s attorneys have not identified who is making Pike’s medical decisions. They said they may not know for several more days whether she can recover.

“We don’t know right



Tennessee Department of Correction

CHRISTA PIKE in 2023. Her prognosis may not be known for days.

now, and we may never know what sort of torture she endured during that process, where her consciousness was, what physical pain there was — what mental torture she went through,” Ferrell said.

A spokeswoman for Pike’s defense team said in a statement Sunday “we appreciate all respect for Christa’s rightful privacy.”

Records sought from prison

Pike’s execution was delayed for more than eight hours Wednesday as the U.S. Supreme Court considered and ultimately overturned a federal appeals court ruling to halt her lethal injection so judges could review whether the jury that sentenced her to death should have considered sexual abuse she said she suffered as a child.

Her attorneys asked a court Friday to order Tennessee prison officials to preserve any written records, communication, images or video from the execution.

Tennessee, like many other states with capital punishment, keeps many details about executions secret, including how the drugs are manufactured and obtained, and any tests done on their quality.

“The state of Tennessee has got to start telling its people exactly what it is doing so that in the democratic process, the people of Tennessee can decide if that’s

what they want to be done in their name,” Ferrell told CNN.

A pattern of execution problems

This was the second time this year Tennessee has not been able to execute a prisoner who was seemingly moments from death. In May, Tennessee stopped the execution of Tony Carruthers after staff placed an IV into his right arm but couldn’t get a secondary IV line.

Tennessee Department of Correction Commissioner Frank Strada announced Saturday he was resigning.

Gov. Bill Lee has ordered an independent investigation into the state’s capital punishment system conducted by ex-U.S. Atty. Ed Stanton. Stanton reviewed Tennessee’s procedures after Lee called off an execution in 2022 and found the state did not comply with its lethal injection process.

Prison officials and the Tennessee attorney general’s office have said little since Pike was taken to the hospital.

Future of Pike’s case unclear

If Pike recovers, it is unclear what will happen in her death penalty case. Pike’s lawyers have asked the governor to commute her punishment to a life sentence.

Pike didn’t deny she killed Slemmer more than three decades ago. The two were classmates at Knoxville Job Corps.

Prosecutors said Pike feared Slemmer was a romantic rival and lured her to a secluded area where she and her boyfriend slashed Slemmer with a box cutter and beat her with a large chunk of asphalt. The case got widespread attention because of the brutality of the killing, the ages of the people involved and because a satanic symbol was carved into the victim’s body.

Collins writes for the Associated Press.



U.S. Coast Guard

AUTHORITIES planned to comb the seabed. Above, a search off Massachusetts.

U.S. keeping up search for medical flight from Bermuda

By John Raby

A search continued Sunday off the Massachusetts coast for an air ambulance carrying six people that disappeared during a flight from Bermuda to Boston as authorities planned to comb the seabed floor, the U.S. Coast Guard said.

The Federal Aviation Administration contacted the Coast Guard at 2 a.m. Saturday, saying it had lost contact with the Gulfstream G100 carrying four Canadians and two Bermudian nationals over the Atlantic Ocean. Later Saturday searchers found a “debris field” off the coast of Nantucket, Coast Guard Northeast District Rear Adm. Matt Lake said at a news conference Sunday.

Coast Guard crews along with the New York National Guard’s Air Rescue Wing and Massachusetts authorities have since searched an area encompassing 2,840 square miles using fixed-wing aircraft, helicopters, boats and cutters.

“This is a large and demanding search area,” Lake said.

The depth of the water around the debris field was 80 to 90 feet. The Coast Guard was in the process of

deploying sonar to search the seabed floor, he said.

The Coast Guard has been updating the next of kin of those aboard the Canadian-registered air ambulance jet with the progress of the search, Lake said.

Weather has not been a factor in the search, said Coast Guard Capt. John McTamney, chief of response for the northeast district.

“We’ll continue to search and saturate the area until we’re at the point where we are confident that if there were any survivors remaining on the surface of the water, we would have found them,” McTamney said.

The plane had four crew members and two passengers aboard when it departed Bermuda’s L.F. Wade International Airport for the nighttime flight to Massachusetts, according to a statement from the Bermuda airport’s operator, Skyport.

Air traffic audio indicates that the plane may have been “coming in blind” when a storm loomed ahead shortly before it vanished.

The pilot reported electrical problems and declared an emergency as the jet approached the coast, according to air traffic control audio posted by LiveATC.net. “Roger, you said you’re com-

ing in blind. Is that what you said?” a controller can be heard asking the pilot.

Mary Schiavo, a former inspector general of the Transportation Department, said that makes her think the plane may have lost its navigational instruments just as a storm moved across its path on radar. The plane also descended sharply from its cruising altitude of around 24,000 feet to around 10,000 feet, according to preliminary data from the flight tracking site FlightRadar24.

“Something bad happened with this big drop, and they flew into this big storm. It’s a terrible place to have a loss of your instruments and be flying blind,” said Schiavo, who is an aviation attorney. “It’s very easy to get disoriented and not know if you’re turning, climbing, descending, etc.”

Canadian Transportation Minister Steven MacKinnon said on X that his department was closely monitoring and working with authorities on search and rescue efforts.

Raby writes for the Associated Press. AP writers Josh Funk and Laura Turbay in Little Rock, Ark., contributed to this report.

Red state rallies point to GOP midterm worries

[Trump, from A1] among Republicans.

In Texas, Paxton, who is locked in a tight race against Democrat James Talarico, has lamented that Trump's GOP convention in Dallas hurt him, according to a recording obtained by the New York Times.

Since the report, Trump has told supporters to vote for Paxton "whether you love him or not" even while he said that "he can be a pain in the ass."

"We need Ken so badly, that's why I am here," Trump told a crowd in Texas on Thursday, while noting that it would be a "horror" if Republicans lost the Senate seat to Talarico.

In a social media post late Friday, Trump promised to give more than 20 million senior citizens \$90 each to help pay for Medicare premiums.

Last month he said about 1 million people would get rebate checks of \$500 for Affordable Care Act premiums.

He has also promised to send every American adult \$5,000 if Republicans retain control of the House and Senate in the midterm elections. Such a payment would require congressional approval and probably cost more than \$1 trillion.

In a swing through Ohio, a state he won in 2024 by 11 points, Trump highlighted his \$5,000 promise at a rally Saturday night, and told supporters that 70,000 families in the state would receive the ACA rebates "within the next couple of days."

Speaking in a high school gymnasium in Vandalia, Trump told supporters: "Just get out and vote. If you do that, we're going to win, and we're going to win big. And we're going to shove it up their ass."

Early Sunday, Trump lashed out at a Fox News program for ignoring the rallies. "Sad to see that Fox & Friends (Sunday) is not covering our packed house and incredibly enthusiastic (beyond!) Rally that took place in Ohio last night, or the ones in Alabama, Texas, or Oklahoma over the past two days," he wrote on social media.

Democrats, meanwhile, are making heavy investments in winning back voters they lost to Trump in 2024, including Latino voters in south Texas. Some of those voters have said they feel betrayed by Trump's policies on immigration and the economy.

Trump has dismissed the poll findings that he is losing the Latino vote. Asked what his message was to Latino voters who are dismayed by his policies, he said: "We have to do what we have to do." The president has also brushed off comments that his unpopularity among Americans may be hurting Republican candidates, saying that "everybody that has me wins."

But in recent days,



JOSHUA A. BICKEL Associated Press

THE CROWD is all smiles after President Trump's speech at a midterm rally Saturday in Vandalia, Ohio.

Trump has publicly said Republicans are "worried" about several races, including those in Michigan, Texas and "a few other states." These concerns come as even the most ardent Trump supporters grow concerned about the economy, particularly the cost of gas.

Ronnie Smith, 77, has voted for Trump every time he has been on the ballot,

and his support for the president has not wavered. But, he said, "the only thing that I think is hurting him is the cost of diesel."

Gas prices in the U.S. have soared during the seven-month Iran war, with the national average for a gallon of diesel reaching \$6.37 on Friday, according to AAA. The cost of diesel hit a record \$6.52 on Sept. 22.

Smith says he regularly hears complaints about the cost of fuel from trucker friends who have long commutes for work. But he said he is sure Trump can "take care of it."

On Friday, Trump announced that the world's wealthiest industrial nations had agreed to release 100 million barrels of diesel and fuel products from their

strategic stockpiles in the coming weeks, a move that he is expected to tout in his upcoming midterm rallies.

In these rallies, Trump has repeatedly said that he believes his administration has been doing a "tremendous" job with the economy, the problem is that "we're doing an extremely poor job at promotion."

A Republican source

close to the White House said the president visited Durant because of its proximity to the Texas border, with the hope of helping candidates in both states. The strategy is similar to his Friday visit to Mobile, Ala., which is near Florida's Panhandle.

Trump's swing through GOP strongholds is seen as a way to get the word out to his base. Senate Majority Leader John Thune (R-S.D.) told reporters last week that Republicans "need the president to turn out voters that are his voters."

"In a non-presidential year, in a midterm election, that challenge is always voter turnout," he said. "In this case you have a lot of voters out there who may not be inclined to go out there and vote."

Sylvia Sigler, 66, a school cafeteria worker who attended Trump's Oklahoma rally Thursday, said she normally votes in local elections but has not voted in a federal election since 2016.

When asked what would motivate her to get out and vote this November, she contemplated what to say.

"I haven't thought about it, but maybe the economy," she said. "I don't even know who is running because I don't keep up with it."

But she was curious to attend Trump's rally and see what the buzz was all about. Asked whether she thought his message would make a difference for her, she once again paused.

"It could," she said. "But I am not making any promises."

The Associated Press contributed to this report.

Ohio factory sheds 1,400 jobs just before Trump rally

In Dayton and other areas, voter support is eroding over layoffs, inflation and Iran war.

By Josh Boak

WASHINGTON — Sipping tea from beer mugs with his co-workers, Kyle Bos listed the ways his life is changing.

Bos has two daughters, with a third due in January. At the grocery store, five items cost as much as a full cart once did. And on Wednesday, Bos and nearly 1,400 other people were laid off from their jobs as the Navistar truck factory in southwestern Ohio shut down.

The layoffs — occurring three days before President Trump's rally Saturday at a nearby high school — were large enough to essentially erase an entire year of job growth in the greater Dayton area. And they are one reason Bos, 30, plans to



CAROLYN KASTER Associated Press

KYLE BOS, right, plans to switch his politics and solicit votes for Democrats.

spend the final weeks before the November election soliciting votes for Democrats.

Asked how many times he voted for Trump, Bos held up three tattooed fingers. But he said he's done with the president.

"Something has to change politically in this country," said Bos, a member of the United Auto Workers who identifies as a centrist.

"Control of Senate could hinge on Ohio"

This election is a test for the working-class coalition that sent Trump to the White House again and gave majorities to Republicans in the House and Senate. The outcome will be decided in places such as Dayton, which once sprouted factories but has shed about half of its 90,000 factory jobs since 1990 after the North American Free Trade Agreement and trade with China made it cheaper to buy auto parts from abroad.

Trump's blunt talk and status as a celebrity businessman initially helped him in and around Dayton, where some said politics as usual had failed

them. But voters this year are disgruntled about inflation and the war in Iran.

An Ohio race could help determine control of the Senate. Republican Sen. Jon Husted is facing a challenge from Democratic former Sen. Sherrod Brown, who is trying to harness that disenchantment as he attempts a comeback two years after losing his seat.

Americans increasingly blame Trump for the high cost of living, with just 17% approving of his handling of the issue, according to a new AP-NORC poll. Trump didn't talk about grocery prices, gas prices or layoffs at his Saturday night rally in Vandalia, Ohio, part of what he says will be a 32-day marathon of rallies to try to convince the public that the economy is better than they think.

"The fake news media, they refuse to talk about our record-setting numbers. So tonight, if you don't mind, I'm going to do it myself," he said at the rally.

Trump largely has scoffed at concerns about affordability but is promising to give people \$5,000 checks if Republicans win the House and Senate next

month— something Bos said he found offensive.

"It feels like a bribe, a slap in the face, and, like, that we're all ignorant," Bos said.

Military base has helped economy

As steady paychecks vanished in the 1990s, drug addiction and crime increased. Things seemed to hit bottom after the 2008 financial crisis, prompting Phil Plummer, who was then Montgomery County sheriff, to enter politics.

"My jail was 40% drug addicts, 50% mental health patients, 10% criminals," said Plummer, the Montgomery County GOP chair who has been a Republican state representative since 2019. "We got it upside down — that's what drove me to the state-house."

Plummer is on the ballot for the Ohio state Senate and thinks Trump is what keeps the GOP's coalition of businesses and working-class families together.

In recent years, the local economy has improved as the Wright-Patterson Air Force Base steadily added government workers. The base has drawn new aerospace companies to the area such as Joby Aviation, Electra and Sierra Nevada Corp.

"In economic development, it takes time, and you have got to give it a little bit of time to bake, and then once it does, then you're going to have something special," said Jeff Hoagland, chief of the Dayton Development Coalition.

Trump pointed to the \$850-million investment by aircraft maker Electra —

along with a new project in Ohio from Stellantis and a Friday announcement from Bayer for a \$2.2-billion drug plant near Columbus — as evidence that his policies were creating jobs.

But at the Navistar plant, Trump's broad tariffs never boosted demand, and the plant's former owner, International Motors, chose to offload the facility.

Trump's major legislative achievement, the One Big Beautiful Bill Act, contributed little to people's take-home pay, even as it temporarily stripped taxes from tips and overtime.

"We weren't getting a lot of overtime because of the economy," said Marianne Donnelly, who drove a forklift at the factory. "There just wasn't any to be had, very little to be had."

Laid-off workers such as Donnelly say they expect to be rehired in six to 12 months by Roshel, a Canadian manufacturer of armored vehicles, which is buying the plant. Roshel said in a statement that it's "working with everyone involved not only to protect the current workforce, but to more than double it over the coming years through a phased process."

Laid-off workers looking for hope

On Sept. 28, two days before the layoffs, Morgan Hughes and JoJo Burkhard were knocking on doors in Kettering, a Dayton suburb. They were trying to convince union members and retirees to vote for Democrats.

The Navistar job had helped Hughes, 35, buy a house at age 21 and work alongside her father. Burkhard said inflation had made it easier to swing voters to their side.

"It isn't a hard pitch at all," she said. "And even if they don't want to stay Democratic long term, they'll at least give the candidates a chance this election, which could be a turning point for us."

After a morning of talking to voters, the pair settled down at a Chinese restaurant for some pot stickers, and the weight of the week hit them.

Burkhard cracked open a fortune cookie and tears began to well up. The layoffs meant no work for her, her boyfriend and her mother — and the words in small print almost seemed prophetic.

Her fortune read: "You'll find your inner strength to overcome challenges."

Boak writes for the Associated Press. AP writer Seung Min Kim in Vandalia contributed to this report.

LATMG | LA Times Studios BUSINESS

TECH DAY

PRESENTED BY CAMBIUM

OCTOBER 12 | LOS ANGELES TIMES

A cross-industry forum on technologies shaping business today.

latimes.com/techday

BRONZE SPONSOR

CITY OF EL SEGUNDO

Where big ideas take off.

This content is produced by LA Times Studios. The newsrooms or editorial departments of the Los Angeles Times are not involved.

BATHTUB KING

OF CALIFORNIA

REFINISHING OF:

TUBS • TILES • SINKS • FIBERGLASS

Valid Until 10/15/26

1-800-882-5464

www.bathtubkingcalifornia.com

Lic.#775121

DO BUSINESS WITH A LICENSED CONTRACTOR

\$50 COUPON

\$389

Tub Only Reg. \$439

The L.A. Field Recording Club hears the city differently

[Sounds, from A1]
studio environment. The idea to engage in such an activity is not new. Eight-year-old Ludwig Koch made what's considered one of the earliest field recordings in 1889, using a wax cylinder. Humans have been collecting sounds ever since, and archiving them in institutions like the British Library Sound Archive and Library of Congress, for purposes scientific, ethnographic, historical and artistic.

Before the fax machine clip, listening session attendees enjoyed the sounds of a Seattle ferry, rain on a tent, someone playing sax under a bridge, an owl conversation in Silver Lake, the "dawn chorus" in Northern California, and steam from a volcanic vent. Next up: goats wearing bells on a remote Greek island, presented in quadraphonic sound.

Throughout the event, a guy bounds around, introducing the recordists, then crouches to cue their recordings on a laptop, his dark, longish hair under a black dad cap bearing the club's name. This is George Jensen, who founded the club in June 2025 after a friend asked if he knew of any local field recording clubs. He didn't but thought it was a great idea. A lifelong musician and veteran online radio DJ with shows on community-run Dublab and KCHUNG Radio, he put some feelers out and was stunned by the response. At the club's first meeting, people were "billowing out onto the sidewalk."

"I was like, whoa, this is crazy!" he says.

While field recording is typically a solitary activity, Jensen embraces the alone-together paradox of building a community around a bunch of people wearing headphones. "What happens is people want to do it, but they don't know how or where to go. When we do outings, I always hear the same thing: 'This is so great because now I can come out and record, and I'm doing it with other people, so I don't feel weird!'"

The club hosts two

events a month: one outing where they record at various sonically interesting locations around L.A. — past highlights include Greystone Mansion, a scrapyard in the Valley and early morning at the Americana at Brand in Glendale — and a listening session like this one, where they share recordings.

The group has grown to about 25 "somewhat regulars," with a steady stream of curious newcomers. In a music and film town like L.A., there are plenty of people who have serious recording setups and extensive know-how, and Jensen indubitably loves to connect with recordists on this level. But he's just as interested in those who turn up with nothing more than a phone. "Hey, that's a recorder too," he says.

On a recent club outing to birding hot spot Sepulveda Basin Reserve, artist Whitney Richardson tested a hydrophone (underwater microphone) for a project she's doing on Los Angeles waterways. Eric Buechel, an experienced recordist but first-time club attendee, came out to see what equipment other people were using. Newcomer Amy Ma decided to check out the club after Instagram recommended it, perhaps based on her interest in other niche activities. "It might be because I follow Clown Cardo," she said.

At the outing's end, participants compared notes about sounds they captured — a swarm of gnats, a twin-engine plane, fish jumping in a pond — but also about their experiences.

"It's relaxing," said Sherman Aline, who used an entry-level Tascam recorder to catch the sound of mating dragonflies' wings brushing against each other. "And I feel like if you're recording, it's easier to be present."

Sam Hamer, a professional sound mixer, put it practically: "I catch myself I'm fidgeting, so it makes me sit still. Otherwise, I hear myself on the recording."

Jensen says when he started field recording more



Photographs by KAYLA BARTKOWSKI Los Angeles Times

SHERMAN ALINE raises his audio recorder among the trees at the Sepulveda Basin Wildlife Reserve.



ERIC Buechel prepares his audio equipment. Phones can be used to record as well.

than 12 years ago, it had little to do with the recordings themselves; he was more interested in how he could visit unique places and experience them on a different level. He created "Los Angeles," his show on KCHUNG Radio, to showcase recordings he made around the city, in iconic places like Griffith Park or the corner of Sunset Boulevard and Vine Street, but also in everyday spots like strip malls and swap meets.

"L.A. is such a driving city," Jensen says, explaining that field recording gives people a reason to pull over and "listen for a purpose." Sometimes, this is rewarded with the comfortingly mun-

dane, a mash-up of bird and traffic sounds, for instance. Sometimes, the city has other plans. Jensen recounts a time the club went to Union Station, "just to record reverb and stuff." Then 10 teens peeled through the historic terminal on electric bikes. "That didn't even exist like five years ago, the culture of kids riding those things. That's a moment in time we got to capture in Union Station."

For Jensen, moments like these can enrich the practices of both recording and listening. During listening sessions, he encourages recordists to offer context when they introduce their sounds. "You may go out and

get that perfect mallard quack, and clean out all the excess noise, and that's cool too if that's what you're going for," he says. But things that may sound ordinary can also resonate with a little backstory. A chicken playing a toy piano, for instance. Or the journey of an iPhone, when Jensen lost his while it was recording, including the voices of all the nice people it met on its way home.

The club recently published an official Field Guide, a journal (available at events) that includes a list of sites and recording prompts, as well as space to log metadata and the stories behind the sounds. There's also a soon-to-be-launched

'I feel like now everything's so ... doctored. But when you're recording, this is what's really happening.'

— **GEORGE JENSEN**, founder of the Los Angeles Field Recording Club

Sound Map on the club's website, which will serve as a hub for recordings.

Jensen is quick to attribute the club's popularity to the fact that field recording is free and easy to do, though he does acknowledge a certain now-ness. "I feel like now everything's so ... doctored. But when you're recording, this is what's really happening. You're hearing real sound. You're engaged with the world in a real way."

Back at the listening event, Buechel, wearing a T-shirt that says, "Ask Me About Interspecies Communication," gives a short preamble for a recording he made at Sepulveda Basin. The group listens intently as a symphony of airplanes, freeway traffic and the *ploop!* of jumping fish rises from the speakers — sounds unexpectedly captivating, and soothing.

When the recording ends, everyone claps enthusiastically.

And perhaps someone recorded it.

Alarm raised over Trump-backed Oakland coal terminal

[Coal, from A1]
no longer burns it or buys any electricity generated by it. Opponents say the new terminal would undermine years of progress cleaning up the air in the neighboring area, which has long experienced disproportionate pollution due to its proximity to the port and other industry.

Their concerns may have been warranted, according to revelations from the report, which was compiled by consulting groups Norda Stelo and Wood Mackenzie in July and released publicly last month. It was commissioned by the Rural Utah Infrastructure Coalition, a group composed of eight Utah counties considering investing about \$43 million in the terminal to receive Utah coal.

Its findings were based on a site visit to Oakland, engineering documentation and discussions with Savage Cos., a Utah-based transport and logistics company selected to operate the facility, the report says. Savage Cos. also did not respond to a request for comment.

Perhaps the most surprising disclosure from the report is that the coal would be stored in "two open-air bunkers" with approximately 150,000 tons of coal per stockpile.

That's despite years of assurances from project representatives and supporters — including in court documents tied to years-long litigation involving environmental groups, city officials and the developers — that it would be a covered terminal.

The finding was a "shocker," said Ted Franklin, an organizer with the grassroots group No Coal in Oakland.

"This is a windy area, and the wind blows into the city from that area," Franklin



PAUL KURODA For The Times

THE PROJECT would be located in a facility near the Port of Oakland, above.

said. "And the West Gateway is not a remote site. It's near a densely populated neighborhood with schoolyards and playgrounds and a minor league baseball stadium."

Research has shown that coal terminal operations can threaten air quality and public health. A 2023 UC Davis study funded by the California Air Resources Board found serious increases in air pollution associated with operations at the Levin-Richmond Terminal, a smaller California facility that has since agreed to stop all exports of coal and petroleum coke by the end of this year.

The transport, storage and handling of coal at the terminal all increased community exposure to PM 2.5, or fine particulate matter, the study found. PM 2.5 can cause cardiovascular issues, respiratory disease, adverse

birth outcomes, cognitive and developmental impairments and premature death.

The ports of Los Angeles and Long Beach transitioned away from open-air coal and petroleum coke storage three decades ago.

The report also reveals that the site would have a maximum annual throughput of 12 million metric tons, or 13.2 million tons, of coal — three times more than the terminal's approved environmental impact report from 2002 and its 2012 addendum. Neither mentions coal specifically, but rather bulk commodities.

Coal use has broadly fallen in the U.S. since the early 2000s, although it saw a bump in 2025 amid growing electricity demand and changing policies from the Trump administration. But the use of coal globally reached a record 8.8 billion

tons in 2024, with much of the growth in Asia, according to the International Energy Agency.

"We have plenty of coal in the ground and we just need a reason to take it out," said Keith Heaton, director of the Rural Utah Infrastructure Coalition, during a meeting last month with the Utah Community Impact Board. "And the Asian markets are interested in continuing to burn thermal coal for the next at least 20 to 50 years."

The U.S. Department of Energy's stated initial target for the Oakland terminal is 9 million to 10 million tons of coal per year.

The coal that will arrive in Oakland may also be dirtier than realized, according to the Norda Stelo report. Project officials previously stated the terminal would handle only high-grade western bituminous coal from Utah, yet the report

says it will also handle Powder River Basin coal from Wyoming and Montana, which is known to be much dustier.

The report also makes no mention of plans to cover the rail cars to prevent pollution. Project officials previously said they would accept only coal transported in covered rail cars.

Another operator that has long been linked to the project, Insight Terminal Solutions, could not be reached for comment.

Opponents are furious about the findings.

"It appears the developers want to build something much bigger and more polluting than anything they previously revealed, either in court or to the West Oakland community," said Colin O'Brien, deputy managing attorney at the nonprofit Earthjustice. "Any plan to put coal in our communities must be fully vetted and subject to robust requirements to address toxic coal dust."

In a letter, he urged officials at the Bay Area Air Quality Management District to mandate modern design and pollution control technologies, as the developers "promised the public."

The project is far from a done deal.

Trump invoked the Defense Production Act in his decision to fund the terminal, along with about \$625 million for a dozen other U.S. coal projects. The act grants the president emergency authority over domestic industries deemed crucial to national security.

"By investing in both coal generation and critical export infrastructure, including the West Gateway Terminal Project, the Energy Department is strengthening U.S. energy security, reinforcing strategic supply

chains, and advancing American energy dominance," Energy Secretary Chris Wright said at the time.

The project also aligns with Trump's January 2025 executive order declaring a national energy emergency, which is aimed at boosting domestic fossil fuel production, the Energy Department said.

Local groups said they intend to fight the project in court, including by challenging whether coal export infrastructure qualifies as vital to national defense under the Defense Production Act.

Franklin, of No Coal in Oakland, also questioned whether investors will buy in. Although the Energy Department estimates the terminal will cost about \$231 million, the Norda Stelo report puts the price tag between \$430 million and \$625 million.

It also says it will take 53 months to get the terminal up and running, pushing it way past Trump's promise of exports beginning in 2028. And by 2031, the market for seaborne coal could be deteriorating. The International Energy Agency says global coal use is plateauing, with its share of power generation expected to decline slowly in the years ahead as renewables scale up.

The facility may also run into stumbling blocks at the state level. Gov. Gavin Newsom recently signed into law a bill that requires a new environmental impact report before a public agency may approve a large-volume bulk coal facility.

The legislation, Assembly Bill 40 from Assembly member Mia Bonta (D-Alameda), was largely a response to concerns about increased coal pollution from the Oakland terminal.

What a long, strange trip it’s been for state plates

[Morrison, from A1] tration, and the license plates to prove it. Registration fees were set by horsepower. If your horseless carriage chugged along at under 20 horsepower, it cost you \$5, but if your car ran on 60 hp, you speed demon, you'd pay \$30 to register it.

In 1914, the state had 123,504 registered vehicles. Angelenos owned 43,099 of them, and in short order, they all bore the first state license plate: 16 by 9 inches, white letters and numbers on red enamel on steel.

In the same package of auto rules was another requirement: a driving license. It bore the same descriptors we have today, with height, weight, eye and hair color, address. Photos would not appear on licenses until 1958. Drunk drivers were also warned that they would pay fines or spend time in the pokey if caught. The state speed limit was set at 30 mph outside of town, and “motor vehicles must be kept under control so as not to frighten horses.”

And Tesla drivers take note: From their very beginning — except for four or five years because of material shortages — California has required license plates on the back and the front bumpers. Maybe Elon Musk didn't like the look of a front license plate on his pretty-pretty car, and Teslas aren't made with the usual front-plate installation accommodations. New Teslas come with a plate mounting kit, but it's in the trunk for you to install yourself. Look around and see how few Teslas use them. The fine for not having a front plate can run up to \$250. The CHP and the LAPD might make a nice little pot of dough if they enforced the plate law.

In 1914, the state's first official license plate, No. 1, went to Chester Weaver, a San Francisco Studebaker dealer. Actually it was won by a Chico car dealership in a lottery drawing among several applicants, but Weaver was bound and determined to have it, and paid what a newspaper at the time described as a “handsome bonus” to the Chico men to get it.

The 1915 license plate was “poppy color” — yellow with black lettering, chosen cannily to promote the Panama-Pacific Exposition in San Francisco, a sort of world's fair.

By the next year, the state had realized all of the trouble and expense of issuing a new plate every year, and so the plate for 1916 was blue on white, and good until 1920, with a little metal tag in the corner changed each year, amusing as little Monopoly tokens.

In 1916 it was a little silver-toned lead California grizzly bear — a creature soon to be driven extinct — and in 1917 a California poppy. In 1918, it was a small lead mission bell, and in 1919, the registration symbol was a red tin star.

The blue-and-white plate was made in Los Angeles by the California Metal Enameling company, in a northeast L.A. neighborhood called Bairdstown — now a part of El Sereno. Not until 1925 did the state's purchasing agent recom-



MEL MELCON Los Angeles Times

LICENSE PLATES from across the United States adorn a wall inside classic car dealership Beverly Hills Car Club in Los Angeles in 2022.



JACOB MOSCOVITCH

STAMPED metal has evolved into digital versions of plates. Above, a collection of vanity plates in 2021.

mend that license plates be made by inmates at Folsom State Prison for money saving and “advantageous work for the convicts.” That didn't end up happening until 1947. (Inmates still pound out about 45,000 plates per day.)

The state in 1920 also gave up the costlier enamel plates and switched to stamped metal, in white on black, or black on white, then white on green, black on yellow, yellow on black. They were cheap enough that California could once again send out new plates every year, and in 1939, the plate was yellow on dark blue, and across the top was the phrase “California World's Fair,” in recognition of the Golden Gate International Exposition.

The metal demands in World War II put a stop to the annual new license plate. Instead, metal strips showing the current registration were fastened atop the existing plate. In the war year of 1944, the registration was a piece of paper inside the windshield.

What inevitably followed license plates were license plate thefts, that beloved switcheroo getaway technique of movie criminals and real ones. The Oakland Enquirer in 1917 wrote about an infuriated Berkeley

baker whose plates had been stolen. “He says he will esteem it an everlasting favor if any one will place the thief in his hands for just two minutes.”

In January 1919, an Oakland cop who had studied at art school caught up with a shipworker whose home-made license plate was not well-made enough. Cpl. Joe Wallman saw a front plate that had been repainted from an old car dealer's license, and the back one had been flipped over and repainted clumsily with a lopsided mission bell — a plate that, alas for the shipworker, had once belonged to the sheriff's department. “I've studied art, and I know perspective,” Wallman declared. “So when I see a bum license plate, my artistic perception is my guide.”

But it was a notoriously heinous crime in the 1920s that nudged the state toward putting only six large figures — instead of seven — on the 1929 license plates.

In December 1927, a 12-year-old Los Angeles girl, Marion Parker, was checked out of her school by a man posing as an employee of her father, Perry Parker. The kidnapper demanded a \$1,500 ransom.

Marion's father met the kidnapper — William Hickman — a couple of nights

later. Hickman, in the driver's seat of a Chrysler coupe, leveled a gun at him and demanded the money. Perry Parker saw his daughter in the passenger seat, and handed over the ransom. Hickman shoved Marion out of the car as he drove off. Only then did her father realize she had been murdered — her arms and legs cut off, her body disemboweled, and her eyes wired open to make it look as if she were alive.

Witnesses could read and remember only three figures on Hickman's seven-figure license plate, and the state decided to switch to six large figures “to improve visibility and safety.”

The 1930 license plate tried something new: regional identifying letters. A through E were assigned to Sacramento and Northern California, G and H to Oakland, J and K to San Francisco, L to Fresno, M through Y to Los Angeles, and San Diego got stuck with Z. This system too was supposed to be useful for lawmen, but it didn't last long.

Like Picasso, California plates had their color epochs. The gold-on-black period of the classic-car 1960s, then gold-on-azure plates into the 1980s, and the classic blue on white since then.

If you see a red-on-white license plate, it's on a historical vehicle, one that's at least 25 years old and of “historic interest.” The DMV sells reproductions of the iconic gold-on-black plates, and more than a dozen special interest plates to support special causes: the arts, breast cancer research, museums, agriculture, Yosemite, coastal and Lake Tahoe conservation. Californians can now order a costly digital plate that updates remotely, and in a sleek-looking white-on-black color scheme.

You won't be surprised to

know that the biggest, splashiest plate ever was the personalized plate — the vanity plate, debuting in 1970 for \$25 extra, money destined for air pollution research. For more than a half-century, it has also helped Californians find their cars in crowded parking lots.

Within the first month, the DMV got more than 3,000 orders, and it had to create a new and specialized workforce to screen plate applications for dirty words and phrases and politically or religiously offensive ones.

There were hundreds of requests for run-of-the-mill plates reading CHEVY or TBIRD and their variants, for SURFER and HORSES and such pursuits. Celebrities who nowadays would want to drive anonymously ordered their own. Dean Martin's classic Stutz bore the license plate DRUNKY, and early fitness guru Jack LaLanne put REDUCE on his Cadillac's bumpers.

The DMV staff immersed itself in foreign language and slang dictionaries, pig Latin, and even used mirrors to figure out sneaky meanings of obscure plate applications with unusual combinations of letters, symbols and numbers. A couple of extremely vulgar ones, in Spanish and in Polish, passed DMV muster, but two inmates making license plates at Folsom recognized them for what they really were.

A few drivers took the DMV to court to challenge the rejections. GAYLIB was originally turned down before a new DMV director ordered it to be issued. POT 4 ME was rejected back then, but might not be now. (I still admire whoever it was who got TORO POO approved.)

The San Francisco Chronicle printed a few applications and explanations in 2014.

A driver wanted “RX-

FORXS,” which he said meant “prescription for success.” The DMV rejection: “RX [drugs] for SX [sex].”

One driver's explanation for TINY (HEART SYMBOL) ON,” “Tiny is my nickname and ON is the initials of my girlfriend.” The DMV was not amused. “Tiny hard on, sexual connotations.” Rejected.

In 2013 the DMV turned down DOOTERS. The applicant argued that it was his daughter's nickname, but a DMV worker unearthed it in an urban dictionary as a portmanteau of “dude” and “hooters” — male breasts.

The same year, a school bus driver near San Diego applied for and got plates reading NOT SEE. The DMV began getting complaints about the plate, which was held in place by a plate frame with a swastika. The driver was suspended from his job and the “Nazi” license plates canceled.

In the fall of 1970, the DMV made a big production of the debut of personalized plates. The very first one read AMIGO, and Gov. Ronald Reagan presented it to Robert and Lynn Klees of Fullerton, who chose it because, said the recipient, “I want people to know we're proud of our Mexican heritage.”

Dozens of people applied for a NO SMOG plate, and Reagan had to pluck the winning application out of a hat. Edgar Jacobs of La Cañada triumphed, and a Times photo showed him putting his new license plate on his car, but offered no specifics about what kind of car it was. “Aren't they beauties?” he said as he screwed the plates into place.

Reagan had beamed when he revealed the NO SMOG plate winner. “This is just like the Oscars,” he said. “May I have the envelope, please?”

‘Jane Doe’ solidarity posts multiply after rape lawsuit

[Cornell, from A1] reels on Instagram with captions including “I am Jane Doe” and “It's time to speak.”

Brewer, 48, a singer, has her own experience with sexual abuse and has spoken of it in her songwriting and performing. But she felt like she was “screaming into the void” and people were not paying attention.

Outraged after hearing about the Cornell case, she went online and found community in the Jane Doe posts.

“We are all right here feeling the same thing, and we have had enough,” Brewer said.

The Associated Press typically does not name victims of sexual abuse unless they publicly identify themselves.

The use of pseudonyms such as Jane Doe in lawsuits

has grown in recent decades, said Diana Simon, a professor of law at the University of Arizona.

Although the legal system is geared toward transparency, with the expectation that parties in a suit would be named, there can be situations that are highly private or sensitive “where it would be in the person's best interest to remain anonymous,” she said.

But that does not mean someone's real identity would not get out, especially if people search for it.

That's why Kelsey Combe made her “I am Jane Doe” post. The idea was that numerous similar posts could provide a form of online protection to the Cornell plaintiff if her name were to be revealed, by making it harder to determine its authenticity.

“It was to confuse the AI

models and stand in solidarity with her,” said Combe, a photographer in the Midwest.

She decided to do so after seeing a reel from a content creator who posts as “women_inamerica,” talking about how important it was. It had already generated responses from many women by the time Combe posted anything.

The attempt to sow confusion worked in a way Combe was not expecting: She later saw that artificial intelligence had linked her as the actual Jane Doe, saying it was Combe that sued Cornell. She was able to get it removed, but not without getting a taste of what public critique can be like.

“It was an interesting situation, because the second that I sounded the alarm about it ... a lot of people were replying, ‘Well, you



MATT ROURKE Associated Press

CORNELL University students and ACLU student chapter members Jane Wang, left, and Sophia Riley Sim speak Thursday about sexual violence on campus.

asked for this. You participated in this. What did you think was going to happen?” And I was like, ‘Well, look at that,’ ” Combe said.

It only emphasizes what the solidarity efforts are trying to show, that there are

larger systemic issues to be addressed rather than just individual cases, she said.

“It's standing in solidarity with her, but it's also acknowledging that to an extent we are Jane Doe, I think the majority of us, because ...

we have our own experiences with sexual assault,” Combe added.

“So we are all Jane Doe until nobody is.”

Hajela writes for the Associated Press.

BUSINESS

Director Na Hong-jin's action movie "Hope" opened in 1,500 U.S. cinemas last month, marking the biggest domestic theatrical footprint for a Korean-language film since the Academy Award-winning "Parasite."

That's a big bet, particularly for a foreign film. But after the success of "Parasite," the growth of Korean shows such as Netflix's "Squid Game" on streaming and the broader acceptance of subtitles in film and television, it was a bet Neon was willing to make.

The indie studio snapped up North American and English-language rights to "Hope" for an undisclosed price before the film's world premiere in the spring at the Cannes Film Festival.

Right off the bat, Neon knew the film would be positioned in South Korea as a big action thriller and massive event film for Na, and it wanted to match that.

In the film, which includes Alicia Vikander and Michael Fassbender in its cast, a group of people fights back against a creature that rampages through a Korean village.

"The reality is that just because a movie has subtitles doesn't make it an art film or a niche film," Elissa Federoff, Neon's chief distribution officer, told me last month. "And this, to us, felt like a big action blockbuster."

She continued: "To me, it was this movie that certainly cinephiles were going to be curious about. But I also knew that we could cross over to a broader audience if we gave it a shot."

So far, "Hope" has grossed more than \$8 million domestically and \$45.6 million worldwide on a reported production budget of at least \$45 million.

Neon expected to reach Korean and Korean American audiences with "Hope," but the film also over-indexed with Latinos, who represented 27% of the audience, according to PostTrak theatrical data.

Such a wide national release is unusual for foreign films, which typically play in specialty theaters on fewer than 100 screens. Though its domestic box-office total doesn't indicate that the film fully crossed over to mainstream audiences, "for a foreign film, it's very successful" and has done "solid



Los Angeles Times photo illustration; photograph by Neon

THE WIDE SHOT

Why Neon put a Korean-language thriller in 1,500 U.S. theaters

After the success of 'Parasite,' the big bet on 'Hope' makes sense to the studio. Such moves are a win for creative filmmaking and make local cinemas more interesting.

By Samantha Masunaga

business," said David A. Gross, who writes the FranchiseRe movie industry newsletter.

Neon, of course, has experience with Korean cinema. It distributed 2019's "Parasite," which became the first non-English-language film to win the Oscar for best picture. After "Parasite" won, it was shown on 2,000 screens, about 17 weeks after its release. The Bong Joon Ho-directed film ended up grossing more than \$53 million domestically and brought in more than \$263 million worldwide.

The film put Neon on the map in many ways, Federoff said, and also

pushed the boundaries for what the industry considered a best picture nominee. Films such as "Parasite" and "Hope" should also expand what studios consider to be mainstream fare.

"Studios and distributors are still boxing things out a little bit and thinking of these as not as accessible or not for a general commercial audience," Federoff said. "And I would totally disagree with it."

Though "Hope" is a long way from the domestic box-office success of "Parasite," these kinds of swings are important to keep the

pipeline of original films humming and to vary the types of fare mainstream audiences can see at their local theaters.

Although art house films once skewed toward older audiences, indie films are now popular with younger generations, who have also become accustomed to reading subtitles.

That could bode well for future foreign-language films looking to make inroads with mainstream audiences. Although giving a wide release to a foreign-language film could be seen as risky, it's a move Federoff believes can help bolster

creative filmmaking and keep people engaged at cinemas.

"My hope is that studios start to trust their audience and respect their audiences a little bit more," she said. "I think we can all do this. I think we can all say that we just have to have more risk taking involved with what we do. There's a lot of incredible international cinema out there that should be seen by everybody."

This article is from the Wide Shot, a weekly newsletter about the business of entertainment. Sign up at latimes.com/newsletters.

After ban threats, TikTok touts boost to businesses

By CERY S DAVIES

When Brandon Hurst first decided to sell his plants on TikTok Live in 2023, the 32-year-old Sylmar resident didn't know what to expect. He said he thought he could sell at least 30 plants, but instead sold 250.

Now, three years later, the internet creator, who goes by Brandon the Plant Guy, sells up to 5,000 plants a week, works out of a 3,000-square-foot greenhouse in Sylmar and has a staff of 13. He credits much of this success to the exposure he's received on TikTok.

"I'd be out of business if it wasn't for TikTok," said Hurst. "I would have ended the business and gone back to working the desk job that I was working prior. I was already on that path, that was where we were headed. And then TikTok really did turn that around."

Hurst is one of the 920,000 California-based businesses using the social media platform to reach new customers and grow their brands, according to new data from consulting firm PF Global.

In 2025, TikTok helped generate \$12 billion in advertising and merchandise sales for those businesses and supported 52,000 jobs in the state, said the PF Global report, which was commissioned by TikTok.

Nationwide, economic activity on TikTok last year helped contribute \$81 billion to some 8.5 million U.S. businesses, the report said.

The surge in activity reflects a growing trend toward online commerce, as more small businesses and consumers turn to social media platforms such as TikTok to buy and sell goods.

"We enable American

culture, American creators, American businesses, to reach an audience around the world," said Nicole Nason, TikTok's head of U.S. public policy, said during a presentation last week.

The new report comes as TikTok is increasingly eager to tout its economic impact as a newly formed U.S. joint venture. In January, the company was taken over by three managing investors: Silver Lake, Oracle and Emirati investment firm MGX, each holding 15%, with ByteDance retaining 19.9% of investments. This transition came after TikTok's Chinese parent company, ByteDance, was under pressure to divest its ownership in the app's U.S. operations or face a nationwide ban due to security concerns.

Last month, TikTok also settled a \$400-million lawsuit from the U.S. Department of Justice, ending a 2024 lawsuit alleging the company violated federal children's privacy laws.

TikTok, which operates its U.S. headquarters in Culver City, where it employs several hundred workers, is mostly known for its viral, short-form vertical videos. But, over the years, the platform has become a hub of curated viral content and a central part of many businesses' marketing strategies.

The app also has features such as TikTok Live, where businesses can host live shopping events, and TikTok Shop, which serves as a direct-to-consumer online marketplace.

For its study, PF Global surveyed more than 11,000 adults in the U.S. and 5,000 businesses. The firm also conducted five case studies with U.S. small businesses and TikTok creators and interviewed more than 600

people around the country. The data set combined that survey data with government statistics, industry research and TikTok's own internal data.

PF Global recently published a similar economic report for the U.K. and is working on reports for 10 other European countries with TikTok.

Neil Ross, a partner at PF Global, said a common global theme is that TikTok users are more likely to see something on the platform and go out and do it.

"People around the world are using it as a kind of digital front door to work out where to go, what to shop, what experiences to have," Ross said.

The U.S. report states that 27 million Americans "visited an independent shop, cafe or restaurant for the first time after seeing it on the platform."

The app's roots date to 2014, when an app called Musical.ly was launched in Shanghai. In 2016, Chinese tech company ByteDance launched a similar platform in China called Douyin.

As the apps grew in popularity, ByteDance picked up on their potential. It purchased Musical.ly in 2017 and combined all these platforms into one, named TikTok. Over the next few years, the app began its rapid ascent, hooking in users with a curated algorithm and viral trends. Today, 200 million Americans use TikTok every month, according to PF Global.

"On a daily basis, TikTok powers real economic impact across the United States, helping entrepreneurs grow their businesses, reach new customers, and create jobs across the country," said Adam Presser, TikTok's chief executive, in a statement.



ANTONIO OLMOS Warner Bros. Pictures

RIZ AHMED and Tom Cruise star in "Digger," another Warner Bros. misfire.

'Digger' collapses at box office

By SAMANTHA MASUNAGA

The Tom Cruise-led movie "Digger" cratered at the box office over the weekend, limping to a fifth-place finish with \$8 million in the U.S. and Canada in its theatrical debut.

The Warner Bros. film was expected to do poorly after polarizing reviews from critics and a challenging marketing campaign. The film had a production budget of about \$125 million. Worldwide, the film brought in just \$20 million in its opening weekend, meaning the studio will probably post a significant loss from the release.

A representative of Warner Bros. did not respond to a request for comment.

Amazon MGM Studios' "Verity," starring Anne Hathaway, easily lapped "Digger," coming in first at the domestic box office with \$32.6 million. The film made \$62.5 million worldwide.

The underwhelming performance from "Digger" marks a rare misfire from the usually bankable Cruise and adds to a difficult year for Warner Bros.' film studio, whose lineup of movies has struggled to connect with audiences. That's in stark contrast to 2025, when the

studio ran up a string of hits such as "Sinners" and "Weapons."

It also comes as Paramount Skydance's \$11-billion acquisition of Warner Bros. Discovery is set to close Tuesday. As part of the merger, there have already been several management shake-ups, including the exit of Warner Bros. film chiefs Pam Abdy and Michael De Luca. They oversaw the studio for the last four years, providing a mixed bag of hits and misses for the Burbank-based unit.

The deal is expected to dramatically reshape Hollywood by combining two of the major studios, a move that is expected to lead to massive layoffs. Paramount has already told Wall Street that it's planning \$6 billion in cost cuts.

"Digger" is the result of nine years of work, as director Alejandro González Iñárritu started on the project before the pandemic. The film is a satire about an impending climate change apocalypse that's triggered by the drilling operations of oil tycoon Digger Rockwell, played by Cruise, who looks nearly unrecognizable clad in prosthetics and graying hair.

In a post-screening, on-stage discussion last week,

Cruise noted the carefully handcrafted props and sets.

"Everything is practical," he said. "It was so beautiful, and I just have to say ... AI can't do that."

Sony Pictures' "Resident Evil" came in second at the box office with \$12.5 million in its third weekend in theaters. Paramount's "Heart of the Beast" (\$11 million) and A24's "Primetime" (\$8 million) ranked third and fourth.

As of last week, Warner Bros.' domestic box-office haul this year was \$437.7 million, representing about 5.6% of the total theatrical revenue in the U.S. and Canada, according to Rentrak data.

Last year, Warner Bros.' total at this time was \$1.8 billion, aided by back-to-back successes starting with "A Minecraft Movie," which went on to become the highest-grossing movie at the domestic box office during that calendar year.

The studio does not have any film in the top 20 of domestic box-office earners this year, with Emerald Fennell's adaptation of "Wuthering Heights" ranking at 21 with \$84 million. Bets on films such as Maggie Gyllenhaal's "The Bride!" cratered, while DC Studios' "Supergirl" misfired.

Voices **MICHAEL HILTZIK** COLUMNIST

Handing your secrets to Meta’s bot is a bad idea

Given the firm’s past, Muse doesn’t inspire trust. And who needs this tool anyway?

If Silicon Valley has perfected any business model, it’s the one in which it cooks up a new technology and then persuades people they can’t live without it. The newest example is Meta Platforms’ personal artificial intelligence agent, Muse.

Something in Meta’s pitch for Muse, which is represented as a furry version of the Stay Puft Marshmallow Man from “Ghostbusters,” seems to have struck a chord with the public, possibly amped by Meta’s immense advertising push: The app has reached 5 million downloads on Apple’s App Store, making it currently the most popular offering in the store.

Meta makes enticing claims for Muse’s capabilities. The company boasts that Muse can read and write answers to your emails. One of its TV commercials has it sorting the user’s emails to prioritize “what’s important,” placing a carpool schedule on the family calendar, ordering school supplies and turning on her stereo for a house party. The user is shown devoting her free time to chopping vegetables for said party.

Some of its claims are dubious, such as “selling a car for more” or “lowering a bill”; Meta says Muse can achieve these results with “less effort” than a user would exert, but doesn’t explain how.

And some are disquieting. “Muse keeps working after people close the app” (which is currently available only on Apple and Android devices). Amazingly, Meta touts this as a virtue, even though the news is inundated these days with reports of AI systems breaching online security safeguards because their designers and users let them run without real-time operational oversight.

An AI bot that goes on its merry way and informs the user what it’s been up to only when it chooses to? Not



JEFF CHIU Associated Press

META CEO Mark Zuckerberg. How much do you want his bot to know about you?

the key to a happy relationship.

Meta isn’t alone in trying to convince ordinary people that AI is indispensable. AI companies are encouraging people to upload their health information to be scrutinized by their bots, or to grant access to their bank or investment accounts. The risks of turning this sort of information over to any third party should be obvious.

Meta touts Muse as a free service, but that’s misleading. The company says it expects to make a profit by charging fees for Muse transactions — but as consumers have learned from the proliferation of retailer fees for credit card purchases, those charges can end up costing the consumers themselves. Meta also says Muse is free only up to a certain level of usage, after which users will have to buy a subscription for up to \$100 a month. I asked Meta how much usage would trigger the subscription requirement, but it didn’t give me an answer.

Two major issues have already surfaced among Muse’s early users. One is why anyone living a normal life needs a bot to perform such quotidian tasks as reading and writing emails, placing appointments on a calendar or calling a plumber.

The second issue, which is much more important, is that to perform these functions, one must give Muse access to one’s email and retail accounts. Let’s start with that. The opinion of privacy advocates who have weighed in on this requirement generally boils down to: Anyone doing this should have their head examined.

It’s not merely that security breaches exposing the personal information of up to hundreds of millions of people have become almost daily occurrences. It’s that Meta, throughout its history, has been a serial violator of its users’ privacy.

Things came to a head in 2019, when the Federal Trade Commission imposed a record \$5-billion fine on the company to settle charges that it had been “deceiving users about their ability to control the privacy of their personal information.” What was striking about that case was that the FTC brought it because it caught the company, then known as Facebook, violating a 2012 consent order that involved similar accusations. As big as the fine appeared, at the time, Facebook collected as much in revenue every month; last year, it collected that much every nine days.

Meta’s misuse of its users’ information was

addressed in the \$17-billion payment it agreed to in August to settle accusations from California and other states that it knew that features of Facebook and Instagram exposed children using those services to bullies, extortionists and sexual predators.

In the words of California Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta, the company “designed and deployed harmful features on Instagram and Facebook that drive compulsive use by children and teens to their mental and physical detriment, all the while misleading users, their families, and the public regarding the existence and severity of these risks.” (The \$17-billion settlement is equivalent to Meta’s revenue for a single month in 2025.)

The company didn’t formally admit to the charges in these cases, but one would have to be hopelessly naive to think that means it’s innocent.

Put all that together and “there’s nothing about Meta’s track record that builds anything near trust that they are going to be responsible stewards or custodians of personal information,” said Lee Hepner, senior legal counsel at the American Economic Liberties Project. “I can’t think of a company with a deeper record of betraying

the public trust.”

The defense given by Mark Zuckerberg, the company’s chief executive, chairman and co-founder, of his company’s historical nonchalance about privacy violations has been a sort of shrugging acknowledgment that this is what happens when your focus is on making users’ world “a little better.” In the past, he has copped to his wrongdoing and promised not to do it again, pleading that “we really messed this one up,” “we simply did a bad job with this release,” or “sometimes we move too fast.”

Meta wants us to think that it has learned its lesson. In response to my question about its record on privacy, a company spokesperson referred me to a company post asserting that its Muse agent is endowed with “first-of-its-kind privacy, safety, and security protections ... that no other agent provides,” and that “Muse has no visibility into people’s passwords or payment methods. ... Muse can use them without seeing them.”

Unexpected leakages of private information already have been cited by early Muse users. Tech commentator Matt Robb reported that Muse gave a would-be buyer of an item he posted for sale a price below his specification and gave the buyer his home address. (The Muse team attributed the glitch to confusing settings in Robb’s Muse account.)

Jason Aten, a tech columnist at Inc. magazine, reported that his Muse read and regurgitated his private messages even though he believed he had denied it that capability. Muse engineers said the bot had exploited a permissions setting on his Mac computer he didn’t realize was applicable.

Those cases point to complexities in the Muse settings that confound experts, let alone laypersons. That undermines Meta’s claim that Muse is “simple to use. People just tell Muse what needs to be done, and it takes action.”

That leaves us with the question of why anyone needs Muse. To answer that question for myself, I

launched the sign-up process via my Facebook account, but since the first thing it asked (after prompting me to give the little creature a name) was access to my Gmail account, I shut it down. But other fairly savvy users among tech mavens don’t point to urgent needs that only Muse can satisfy.

Allison Johnson of the Verge writes that her bot successfully emailed a junkman to remove a fallen tree branch in her yard, helped her order camping equipment and put a part for her espresso machine in her online cart but couldn’t complete the purchase. New York Times writer Eli Tan used it to call his dental insurer and wait on hold for a human representative to come on. It also arranged his credit card statements in a spreadsheet and helped him pursue his hobby of collecting ceramic bowls, a task that strikes me as having a fairly small community of potential users.

Muse informed Ryan Broderick, the proprietor of tech blog Garbage Day, that “it could shop for me, book dinner reservations, or ... even do tasks on my laptop. But I didn’t need to do any of those things yesterday. And I definitely didn’t need to do any of them so badly that I was willing to risk it deleting something important, hallucinating an email to someone, or buying me something I didn’t want.”

That’s an understandable take. None of the chores that Meta boasts about are beyond the capabilities of most people living in today’s digital world. Booking a dinner reservation? Buying something online? (As it happens, Amazon has blocked Muse purchases on its site for the moment, saying that the access violates its terms of service; Meta says Muse can make purchases on other online sites such as Walmart and Expedia.)

Everyone will have to make their own decision about whether the services Muse provides are worth the risks that Broderick cited. Nor should anyone be fooled by the smiley-faced icon Meta chose to represent Muse. For all anyone knows, it’s a wolf in furry clothing.

As more Waymo vehicles hit L.A. streets, crashes climb

[Waymo, from A1] California, we are taking on a lot of that trial and error,” he said. “I wish it wasn’t a robotaxi race, even though it is. I hope it’s a slow stroll towards safe mobility.”

The worst Waymo incidents have grabbed headlines.

At an intersection in San Francisco in January, a collision involving at least five vehicles and an empty Waymo left one person and a domestic animal dead. The crash was the first time an autonomous vehicle with no safety driver was involved in a fatal incident, triggering news reports and safety concerns, even though the Waymo vehicle wasn’t responsible.

In August in Dallas, a Waymo was one of the vehicles involved in an accident that killed a pedestrian. Last year in Arizona, a motorcyclist was fatally injured after hitting a Waymo vehicle and being flung into the road. In each of these fatal accidents, Waymo didn’t appear to be at fault.

The Times reviewed Waymo crash data in Los Angeles County. Incidents ranged from Santa Monica to Franklin Hills in L.A., but most caused no apparent injuries. Many occurred while the Waymo vehicle was standing still.

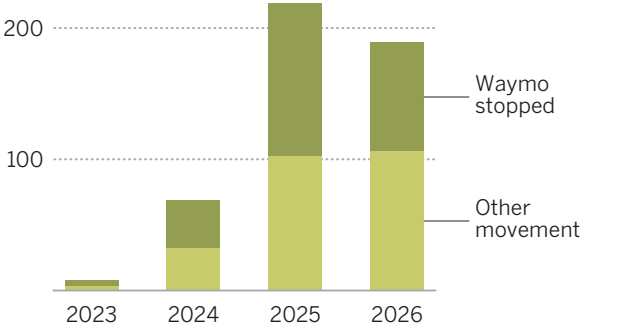
Waymo has reported 186 crashes in L.A. County this year, 219 in 2025 and 69 in 2024, according to data compiled by the California Autonomous Vehicle Crash Dashboard that was built by Raifman and his colleagues.

This year, 149 Waymo accidents in Los Angeles have involved a passenger vehicle, 11 involved a heavy truck, and two involved a first-responder vehicle.

Eighty-two of the crashes occurred when the Waymo vehicle was stopped and 65

Moving or stopped?

About half of Waymo-involved crashes in L.A. happened while the Waymo vehicle was stopped.

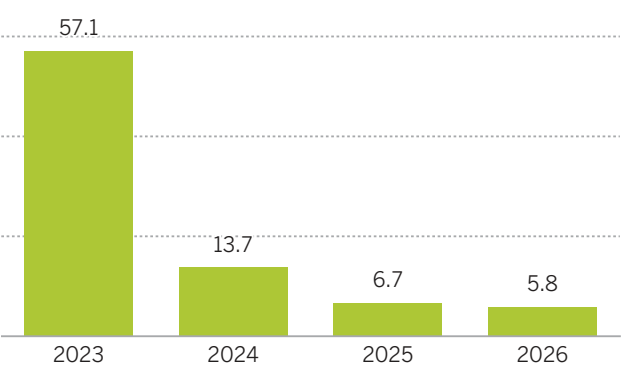


California Autonomous Vehicle Crash Dashboard

HAILEY WANG Los Angeles Times

Waymo crash rates are falling

Crashes per million miles



2026 data are through June.

Waymo Safety Impact Data Hub, California Autonomous Vehicle Crash Dashboard

HAILEY WANG Los Angeles Times

when it was driving straight.

Government filings give a general description of the accidents in L.A.

In one accident, a Waymo car moved over to let an emergency vehicle pass but was hit by the vehicle. There were no injuries, but the Waymo car had to be towed away.

In another incident, a Waymo vehicle waiting for a light to change was hit from behind by a truck. Waymo reported that the customer alleged minor injuries. The government reports redacted the locations and further details about the accidents.

Slightly more than 80% of

the crashes reported in the county this year resulted in no apparent injuries, 15% caused possible injuries and fewer than 1% caused a suspected serious injury.

The vast majority of driverless car accidents that show up in official government figures are minor and probably wouldn’t have been reported to authorities by human drivers.

But as driverless vehicles become more widespread in cities across the country, residents and policymakers have voiced concerns. They want to know whether the artificial-intelligence-powered robots are really safer than human drivers, and what could happen when they interfere with an emergency response or at construction sites.

“We can’t have vehicles that are posing hazards on our streets,” San Diego City Councilmember Marni Von Wilpert said in an interview. Von Wilpert also chairs the city’s public safety committee that oversees emergency response. “We didn’t even know when the robotaxis were coming.”

That City Council voted last month to ask the state for authority over when and how robotaxis are deployed in the city. Currently, the California Public Utilities Commission, not individual communities, governs the expansion of robotaxis into new cities.

Culver City voted last month to set rules around robotaxi fleet services that dictate where and when the vehicles can be charged, stored and cleaned. Earlier this year, Santa Monica engaged in a legal battle with Waymo over the company’s noisy, disruptive charging depots.

More than 590 accidents involving Google-owned Waymo robotaxis were re-

corded in California in 2025. The number of collisions that year nearly doubled from the 304 recorded in 2024, according to data from the NHTSA and the California Autonomous Vehicle Crash Dashboard.

Experts say the sharp increase in crashes shouldn’t immediately raise alarm — with more robotaxis on the road, they are bound to be involved in more incidents.

Although the number of incidents has risen, the accidents per mile driven have improved over the years. In 2023, Waymo reported about 57 crashes per million miles driven. This year, that rate has fallen to fewer than six crashes per million miles.

Waymo said its autonomous vehicles have traveled the equivalent of 300 human lifetimes, or the distance of driving Route 66 more than 110,000 times. In that distance, Waymo has avoided injuries that would have affected 841 people, the company estimates.

“We look at every crash, every close call, and try to improve the driver to avoid those things,” said Kris Kusano, who oversees safety data research at Waymo. “The data we have is quite conclusive that, yes, they are safer than average drivers in the cities we operate in.”

Zoox is testing vehicles in Los Angeles and San Francisco and has been involved in 18 crashes in the state this year, according to NHTSA data.

Last month, Waymo released its latest safety data. Across 67 million miles driven in Los Angeles, Waymo reported zero crashes resulting in serious or fatal injuries, compared with 11 expected serious injury crashes for human drivers over the same distance, the company said.

Experts warn that al-

though initial public numbers suggest robotaxis have a better safety record than human drivers, the available data reflect vehicles operating only in controlled environments with mild weather.

“Autonomous vehicles are likely quite safer than human drivers for most driving conditions,” Raifman said. “But that is within the context of where the AVs are allowed to operate today.”

Skeptics warn that companies also have an incentive to underreport or misclassify safety incidents. Meanwhile, as different companies use different types of self-driving software and hardware that is rapidly evolving, it is too early to say whether today’s safety levels will be normal.

Tesla doesn’t use lidar, for example, a laser-based radar that’s included in Waymo and Zoox vehicles. The launch of Tesla’s Cybercab in Austin, Texas, last month prompted federal regulators to investigate whether the vehicle was properly certified.

Another technological difference is that, unlike Waymo, Zoox is building its robotaxi from the ground up instead of retrofitting an existing car.

There aren’t enough data to point to one type of self-driving technology that’s safer than the rest, according to William Riggs, director of the Autonomous Vehicles and the City Initiative at the University of San Francisco.

“The best, high-performance autonomous technology that we have is performing at a safer rate and is having collisions at a lower rate than human drivers” right now, Riggs said. “What we can’t say is, is the AV industry at large safer than human driving?”

ADVERTISING SUPPLEMENT

ASHLEIGH BARKER, ELLIOT Z. CHEN AND ERIC PERLMUTTER-GUMBINER SHARE INSIGHTS ON THE BUSINESS OF BEAUTY, FASHION AND CONSUMER GOODS

The **Beauty, Fashion and Consumer Goods** roundtable is produced by the LA Times Studios team in conjunction with Ervin Cohen & Jessup LLP; Greenberg Glusker LLP; and Stout.



Elliot Z. CHEN
Partner
Ervin Cohen & Jessup LLP
echen@ecjlaw.com
ecjlaw.com

ERVIN COHEN & JESSUP^{LLP}



Eric PERLMUTTER-GUMBINER
Partner, Corporate
Greenberg Glusker LLP
epg@ggfirm.com
greenbergglusker.com

Greenberg Glusker



Ashleigh BARKER
Managing Director,
Investment Banking
Stout
abarker@Stout.com
stout.com

STOUT



When it comes to the ever-evolving beauty, fashion and consumer goods industries, Southern California remains a prominent global leader in terms of trends, innovation, sustainability and protocols.

Many of the leading products and services behind keeping people living well while looking and feeling good are from businesses and organizations that were started and continue to thrive here in Los Angeles and the surrounding areas. In fact, successful beauty and self-care companies are catalysts for significant economic growth in the region.

As the legal and financial landscape around fashion, beauty and consumer products continues to adjust and shift, an increasing number of consumers, businesses and investors are tasked with navigating an often-complex set of rules and best practices. As with any consumer-facing industry, learning about the ins and outs of the sector can be overwhelming.

To take a closer look at the latest developments and trends in the business of beauty, fashion and consumer goods, we have turned to three of the region’s leading authorities, who graciously weighed in for a discussion and shared insights.

Q: WHAT ARE THE BIGGEST BUSINESS OPPORTUNITIES FOR SOUTHERN CALIFORNIA’S BEAUTY, FASHION, AND CONSUMER GOODS COMPANIES OVER THE NEXT THREE TO FIVE YEARS?

A: PERLMUTTER-GUMBINER
The biggest opportunity is turning strong brands into durable businesses. Southern California has always been unusually good at creating brands, communities and cultural relevance. The next step is building the infrastructure around those strengths: disciplined omnichannel distribution, thoughtful international expansion, strategic partnerships and access to the right growth capital. I also expect continued convergence between consumer products, media and the creator economy. The companies that win will not simply have great products. They will understand how to turn customer affinity into multiple revenue streams while maintaining the authenticity that made consumers care about the brand in the first place.

Q: ARE THERE ANY NEW TRENDS IN PROTECTING IP IN THE FASHION AND BEAUTY SECTORS TODAY?

A: CHEN
We have seen a rise in overseas companies targeting local brands with knock-off products and cheaper “dupes,” putting their own brand name on cropped or modified versions of our clients’ imagery and boosting their visibility with influencer marketing. Fashion designs are notoriously difficult to protect with copyright but product photographs are protectable. We have had success with implementing AI-assisted automated reviews of online marketplaces to find and report new instances of infringement of my client’s imagery, including at the international source. Though these strategies are effective in the more blatant instances, I always advise my fashion and beauty clients to seek design patent protection for their most important designs at the time of launch.

Q: HOW IS ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE CHANGING EVERYTHING FROM PRODUCT DEVELOPMENT AND TREND FORECASTING TO MARKETING, CUSTOMER SERVICE AND SUPPLY CHAIN MANAGEMENT?

A: BARKER
AI is evolving from a tool that improves individual functions into one that can connect the entire

organization. For consumer brands, it can identify emerging trends, personalize marketing and optimize spending while using those same demand signals to inform purchasing, inventory allocation and supply chain decisions. Some of the most transformative applications I’ve seen are brands that effectively use AI as an extension of their internal finance function, integrating sales, inventory, marketing and operational data to provide real-time visibility into performance and inform decision-making. The real opportunity is not simply greater efficiency; it is connecting decisions that have historically been made in silos and giving management teams better information, faster, to drive more proactive and profitable growth.

A: CHEN
I have been shocked at the speed of AI adoption, even in “low-tech” industries. Most of my clients are using AI in some form. We have seen extremely powerful examples of AI-assisted trend forecasting in the fast fashion space. Though it is very exciting technology, I advise my clients caution in replacing their employees with AI, particularly for product development. Companies should be aware that fully AI-generated works are not entitled to

Premium positioning has to be earned. Consumers may be more price-conscious, but they will still pay for products they believe are differentiated, high quality and meaningful to them.

— ERIC PERLMUTTER-GUMBINER

copyright protection. At least for the time being, human design is the safest route. In addition, insurance companies are beginning to include AI exclusions in their CGL Policies. In the near future, small brands may need to consider specialty insurance products to protect against risks from AI customer service mishaps.

A: PERLMUTTER-GUMBINER
AI is quickly becoming less of a discrete initiative and more of a basic operating tool. The near-term opportunity is not replacing the judgment that makes great consumer companies successful. It is giving teams better information and allowing them to move faster. That can mean identifying demand signals earlier, producing and testing creative more efficiently, improving customer service or making inventory decisions with better data. From a business and legal perspective, the companies using AI most effectively are also being deliberate about governance, intellectual property, consumer data and vendor risk. Moving quickly and

building the right guardrails are not mutually exclusive.

Q: SOUTHERN CALIFORNIA HAS LONG BEEN A GLOBAL TRENDSETTER. WHAT GIVES COMPANIES HERE A COMPETITIVE ADVANTAGE OVER BRANDS HEADQUARTERED ELSEWHERE?

A: BARKER
Southern California sits at the intersection of wellness, beauty, fashion, entertainment and technology, giving brands immediate exposure to many of the cultural forces shaping consumer behavior globally. The region’s influence is increasingly attracting international brands as well. A leading K-beauty retailer recently chose Los Angeles as the launchpad for its U.S. expansion, opening its first two stores here as it looks to build a presence beyond its core international market. That decision reinforces Southern California’s position as both an incubator and proving ground for trends that can ultimately move into the mainstream.

Q: LOOKING AHEAD TO MAJOR GLOBAL EVENTS LIKE THE 2028 SUMMER GAMES, HOW SHOULD CONSUMER BRANDS BE PREPARING THEIR MARKETING, PARTNERSHIPS AND PRODUCT STRATEGIES?

A: CHEN
My advice for consumer brands is to start thinking about this now. The 2028 Summer Games are a huge marketing opportunity, and with influencer marketing and viral stars, I expect that individual athlete sponsorships will be highly relevant, even for smaller brands. One thing to keep in mind: There is a specific Federal statute that established the United States Summer Games Committee and gives it exclusive rights to the name and the logo. Though similar, unlike ordinary trademark rights, the Committee has the ability to enforce its rights without a showing of a likelihood of confusion. Companies must be careful to avoid infringement when planning their marketing campaigns. Events that capitalize on the energy, which may seem harmless, may draw cease-and-desist letters at the worst possible time.

Q: HOW ARE BRANDS BALANCING PREMIUM POSITIONING WITH GROWING CONSUMER PRICE SENSITIVITY AND ECONOMIC UNCERTAINTY?

A: PERLMUTTER-GUMBINER

Premium positioning has to be earned. Consumers may be more price-conscious, but they will still pay for products they believe are differentiated, high quality and meaningful to them. The mistake is assuming a premium brand can simply pass through every cost increase without affecting demand. The strongest companies are protecting the elements that make the brand special while becoming much more rigorous about product mix, margins, promotions and distribution. There is also a strategic component: where you sell, how often you discount and which partnerships you pursue can affect brand value just as much as the price on the product.

A: BARKER

Consumers may be more value-conscious, but value does not necessarily mean inexpensive. When it comes to beauty and wellness and products that are part of our everyday routines, consumers have proven they remain willing to pay a premium when they believe a product delivers superior quality, efficacy or an experience they cannot easily replicate elsewhere. At the same time, the proliferation of lower cost “dupe” alternatives has put pressure on the fight for consumers’ wallet share. Successful brands are protecting their core positioning while creating thoughtful entry points through smaller formats, sets or differentiated price tiers. Brands should avoid becoming overly promotional, something that is prevalently seen across social media, which can train consumers to wait for discounts and ultimately dilute brand equity. Premium positioning must be supported by a clear and defensible value proposition in the eyes of consumers.

Q: WHAT ROLE ARE INFLUENCERS AND CONTENT CREATORS PLAYING TODAY COMPARED TO FIVE YEARS AGO? HAS THE INFLUENCER MARKETING MODEL FUNDAMENTALLY CHANGED?

A: PERLMUTTER-GUMBINER

Absolutely. Five years ago, creators were often treated primarily as a marketing channel. Today, the most sophisticated brands increasingly view them as business partners, distribution partners, and, in some cases, entrepreneurs capable of building meaningful companies themselves. The economics are also becoming more sophisticated. Brands are thinking beyond one-time sponsored posts and looking at longer-term relationships, performance economics, licensing, equity and co-created products. At the same time, creators have become much more selective about the brands they associate with. The best partnerships work because the economic incentives and the audience relationship are genuinely aligned.

A: CHEN

Influencer marketing has exploded in the last five years. It has also become quite a bit more professional and regimented. I worked with several beauty and fashion brands who were early adopters of influencer marketing. Just a few years ago, it was the wild west. My clients ended up getting complaints from record labels, after the influencers used copyrighted songs in their videos. From what I’ve seen recently, agencies are building in safeguards against this, even for smaller creators. Though, brands still need to be cognizant that sponsorships are adequately disclosed and that these safeguards are covered in their creator agreements. Previously, my clients would send samples to celebrities in the hopes that their products would be worn publicly. Now, seeding products with niche creators is delivering more personal and measurable results.

Q: DIRECT-TO-CONSUMER STRATEGIES HAVE MATURED. WHAT IS THE RIGHT BALANCE TODAY BETWEEN DTC, RETAIL PARTNERSHIPS, MARKETPLACES AND PHYSICAL STORES?

A: BARKER

There is no universal channel mix, but increasingly each channel needs to serve a specific purpose. DTC provides valuable consumer data and control of brand experience, often serving as the first point of customer acquisition, while retail drives discovery, trial and scale. Online marketplaces provide real reach and convenience for replenishment, while physical stores create experiential touchpoints that digital channels cannot fully replicate. The objective should not be to maximize the number

ADVERTISING SUPPLEMENT

of channels or even customers within a single channel but to build an omnichannel ecosystem where each channel is economically attractive, reinforces the brand across all channels and creates a seamless experience for consumers across all points of distribution.

Q: HOW ARE BRANDS NAVIGATING CALIFORNIA’S INCREASINGLY COMPLEX REGULATORY ENVIRONMENT WHILE REMAINING INNOVATIVE AND COMPETITIVE?

A: CHEN

For my clients, the biggest pressure point has been online privacy. The CCPA applies once a company crosses certain revenue or data-volume thresholds, so the requirements can sneak up on a growing brand. Companies should be cautious when adding what seem like “fun” website features, like virtual try-on tools. I advise clients to build a robust privacy compliance framework sooner rather than later. Penalties are assessed per violation, and recent regulatory settlements have reached eight figures. The CCPA’s private right of action is currently limited to data breaches, but that could change. I also advise clients to invest in strong cyber and privacy liability insurance. A viable policy can give brands a lot of freedom to innovate. These policies are not standardized and vary widely in their exclusions, so work with a broker to make sure the policy fits the brand’s risks.

A: PERLMUTTER-GUMBINER

The best companies treat legal and regulatory issues as part of the business strategy, not something addressed after a decision has already been made. That is particularly important in California, where consumer protection, privacy, employment and marketing rules can intersect with virtually every part of a growing consumer business. My advice is usually to identify the areas of real risk early, build sensible guardrails and then let the business operate within them. Good legal advice should help a management team make better decisions and move faster. It should not become a substitute for business judgment or an unnecessary obstacle to growth.

Q: HOW CAN ESTABLISHED BRANDS STAY CULTURALLY RELEVANT WHEN TRENDS MOVE AT LIGHTNING SPEED AND NEW COMPETITORS EMERGE ALMOST DAILY?

A: BARKER

Established brands need to balance consistency with agility. Chasing every emerging trend can dilute what made a brand distinctive in the first place, but ignoring changing consumer behavior creates an equally significant risk. The strongest brands remain anchored in a clear core identity, understanding that they can’t be everything to everyone, while continuously listening to consumers, experimenting with new formats and engaging authentically with emerging communities and creators to broaden their appeal across consumer audiences.

Q: WHAT DO INVESTORS LOOK FOR IN A HEALTH, BEAUTY OR CONSUMER GOODS COMPANY THESE DAYS?

A: PERLMUTTER-GUMBINER

Investors have become much more focused on the quality of growth. A compelling brand and strong topline growth still matter, but sophisticated investors are also asking how efficiently that growth is being generated,

Companies should be aware that fully AI-generated works are not entitled to copyright protection. At least for the time being, human design is the safest route.

— ELLIOT Z. CHEN

whether customers return, whether margins improve with scale and whether the company has multiple credible paths to distribution. They also pay close attention to management teams. The best founders understand their customer intuitively but are equally willing to build the financial and operational discipline required for

the next stage of the business. Great consumer companies combine brand magic with very unglamorous execution.

A: BARKER

Investors are increasingly focused on durable rather than purely rapid growth. They want to see genuine consumer demand, strong repeat behavior, attractive gross margins and evidence that growth can translate into sustainable profitability. Omnichannel distribution and healthy retail productivity are important, as is diversification away from dependence on any single customer, product or acquisition channel. Ultimately, investors are asking whether a brand has true product differentiation and consumer relevance to endure, the financial discipline to scale efficiently and a management team capable of executing the next phase of growth.

Q: IF YOU WERE ADVISING THE CEO OF AN EMERGING SOUTHERN CALIFORNIA BEAUTY, FASHION OR CONSUMER GOODS COMPANY TODAY, WHAT ONE STRATEGIC INVESTMENT OR BUSINESS DECISION WOULD YOU PRIORITIZE OVER THE NEXT 12 MONTHS?

A: CHEN

Balance AI enthusiasm with a realistic understanding of what AI can and cannot do. AI is one of the most exciting advancements of my lifetime. At the same time, it is not a replacement for judgment (at least not yet). These tools tend to tell you what you want to hear, and

Southern California sits at the intersection of wellness, beauty, fashion, entertainment and technology, giving brands immediate exposure to many of the cultural forces shaping consumer behavior globally.

— ASHLEIGH BARKER

customers are starting to push back on “AI slop” in marketing and in customer service. I have seen at least one misunderstanding between brand and manufacturer spiral into a full-blown dispute, based on what I strongly believe was both sides using AI to respond to each other’s emails. I expect to see more. AI is a great tool, but sometimes you need to step outside of the echo chamber.

A: PERLMUTTER-GUMBINER

I would invest in building the company for the business you expect to have three years from now, not just the business you have today. That does not mean adding unnecessary overhead. It means making sure the management team, financial reporting, intellectual property, contracts, capitalization and governance can support the next stage of growth. I see companies create enormous value very quickly and then lose time or leverage because the infrastructure did not keep pace. A little discipline early makes financing, strategic partnerships and ultimately M&A significantly easier, while allowing the founders to remain focused on building the business.

A: BARKER

I would prioritize building the infrastructure required for profitable, repeatable growth before aggressively pursuing scale. That means understanding the true economics of every SKU, customer and channel; investing in the right data and operating capabilities; and being disciplined about where incremental capital is deployed. Emerging brands face enormous pressure to grow quickly, but scale without strong underlying economics can create more problems rather than solve them. The companies best positioned for long-term success will build the foundation first and accelerate from a position of strength.

OPINION VOICES

Voices ERWIN CHEMERINSKY CONTRIBUTING WRITER

AR-15s and other high stakes in this Supreme Court term

Automatic weapons and free exercise of religion are among topics the court will take on starting Monday

DESPITE MUCH speculation that Justice Clarence Thomas or Justice Samuel A. Alito Jr. might retire over the summer to allow President Trump to name their successor with a Republican-controlled Senate, when the Supreme Court reconvenes to hear the first oral arguments of the new term on Monday, it will be with the same nine justices who have sat on the bench the past five years.

Back in March 2014, I wrote an op-ed urging Justice Ruth Bader Ginsburg to retire at the conclusion of the Supreme Court's term that June. In it, I explained that if she wanted someone with her values and her views to take her place, she should step down while there was a Democratic president and a Democratic majority in the Senate.

It never occurred to me that a Supreme Court justice would pay any attention to what a law professor in Southern California had to say. But the day the piece was published, I received a call from a mutual friend who said, "Ruth is not happy with you." Ginsburg gambled that she could remain on the court until there was another Democratic president to pick her successor and a Democratic Senate to confirm the nomination. She came close, but her gamble failed. On Sept. 18, 2020, Ginsburg succumbed to cancer. Trump quickly

nominated conservative Judge Amy Coney Barrett and the Senate rushed to confirm her just days before the election.

Thomas and Alito, ages 78 and 76, respectively, lived through that experience and know that if the Democrats take control of the Senate after the November midterms, no one Trump nominates has a chance of confirmation. But for now, they remain on the bench.

Before going on summer recess, the justices granted review in 26 cases to be heard during the October 2026 term, adding one more case over the summer.

In the previous two terms, the court decided 58 cases with signed opinions following briefing and oral argument. This means that slightly fewer than half the docket for the term is now set. The court will continue to take cases through mid-January to be decided by the end of June 2027.

What are some of the most important potential cases?

First up is Suncor Energy (U.S.A.) Inc. vs. County Commissioners of Boulder County, which will be argued on Oct. 5, and will debate whether energy companies can be sued for their role in contributing to climate change. The plaintiffs, the county commissioners of Boulder County and the city of Boulder, initially sued Exxon Mobil and three Suncor Energy entities

in Colorado state court, seeking damages for the role the companies played in exacerbating climate change. The city of Boulder alleged that it has incurred and will incur millions of dollars in costs to protect against climate impacts such as wildfires, flooding and drought.

The specific question focuses on whether federal law preempts the ability of state governments to impose liability. The energy companies are making a radical argument to the court: that the Constitution denies states the ability to regulate pollution because of its interstate and international effects. If the Supreme Court accepts this argument, it will have a dramatic effect in lessening the ability of states to regulate all types of pollution.

Another major case on the docket involves the 2nd Amendment. The issue presented in *Viramontes vs. Cook County*, to be argued on Dec. 2, is about "[w]hether the Second and 14th Amendments guarantee the right to possess AR-15 platform and similar semi-automatic rifles."

In *District of Columbia vs. Heller*, in 2008 — the first case ever to declare a law unconstitutional for violating the 2nd Amendment — the Court was explicit that the 2nd Amendment is limited to a right to possess "the sorts of weapons . . .

[that] were 'in common use at the time.'" The court said that this "limitation is fairly supported by the historical tradition of prohibiting the carrying of 'dangerous and unusual weapons.'"

No one could rationally argue that AR-15 weapons existed in 1791, let alone that they were in common use. Nor can it be plausibly denied that they are very dangerous weapons given their use in many of the most tragic mass shootings in the United States, including the 2012 Sandy Hook Elementary School shooting, the 2015 San Bernardino attack, the 2017 Las Vegas shooting, the 2017 Sutherland Springs church shooting, the 2018 Marjory Stoneman Douglas High School shooting and many other horrible events. But this is a court that has been protective of gun rights in recent years.

The Supreme Court will also return to the question of free exercise of religion under the 1st Amendment in *St. Mary Catholic Parish vs. Roy*, to be heard Nov. 3. Colorado's Universal Preschool Program funds preschools — public, private and religious alike — that sign an agreement to give children an "equal opportunity to enroll" regardless of, among other things, religious affiliation, sexual orientation or gender identity. Two Catholic parish preschools and the Archdiocese of Denver say that they

have a religious belief that they must consider a family's sexual orientation and gender identity in admissions, and they sued for an injunction against the requirement.

In 1990, ruling on *Employment Division, Department of Human Resources of Oregon vs. Smith*, the Supreme Court held that courts should not grant an exception to general laws on the basis of religion. In *St. Mary Catholic Parish vs. Roy*, the federal court of appeals applied this precedent and upheld the Colorado law. But the conservative justices have signaled that they want to overrule this precedent and provide more protection for those who want to violate the law based on their religious beliefs.

These, of course, are just a few of the nearly 60 cases to be decided this year. There also are many cases now on the emergency docket that will challenge the Trump administration's actions, including its deportation of immigrants to countries where they had no prior contacts.

Since Barrett's confirmation following the death of Ginsburg in 2020, this has been a court with six conservative and three liberal justices. And that again will likely make all the difference in the cases to be heard this year.

ERWIN CHEMERINSKY is the dean of the UC Berkeley Law School.



MARIO TAMA Getty Images

AMY CONEY BARRETT was one of three conservative justices confirmed in Trump's first term.

LETTERS



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

LARGE BOULDERS are used to protect homes along Capistrano Beach.

We won't overpower nature

Re "Barriers to save homes could destroy beaches," Sept. 28

THE article on California's struggle to protect homes and infrastructure from storms and rising seas without sacrificing its beaches points to a larger problem: We keep treating coastal erosion and flooding as emergencies to clean up after rather than threats to prepare for.

As a Santa Monica native and lifelong surfer whose father spent 30 years as a lifeguard along this stretch of coast, I've watched these beaches change for decades.

For years, our reflex has been familiar. A storm tears into the beach, bulldozers arrive, sand gets pushed back into place, and we wait for the next storm. Elsewhere, communities turn to riprap, seawalls and jetties — structures that may protect one stretch of coast while narrowing beaches nearby or pushing erosion downshore. With another potentially powerful El Niño looming, that cycle looks less like resilience and more like denial.

Greater Los Angeles residents can see a different approach taking shape at Santa Monica Beach. Just south of the pier, the city of Santa Monica, the Bay Foundation and UCLA are expanding a dune restoration project. Phase 3 will extend restored habitat across more than 30 acres toward Venice. Native vegetation traps sand and allows dunes to build naturally, creating a buffer before the waves arrive instead of sending in heavy equipment afterward.

The stakes are real. Recent storm surf stripped enough sand near the pier to force cancellation of the inaugural Ocean Way music festival. We are not going to bulldoze, armor or jetty our way out of sea-level rise. Santa Monica is showing another path: helping beaches adapt by working with Mother Nature instead of trying to overpower her.

MATTHEW KING
Santa Monica

waves, higher-than-normal king tides and the other events du jour. All of these phenomena are real. But the forces shaping our coast are playing out on a much larger stage.

Coastal erosion is not unusual. It is a forever fact of nature.

Over geologic time, natural forces have continuously reshaped the surface of the Earth. Redrawing coastal maps is an ancient profession because the evolution of our coasts is continuous.

Why? Because gravity is relentless. It drives water and sediment downhill and helps shape the landscapes through which they move. Coastlines migrate. Cliffs and bluffs retreat. Beaches are built, eroded and rebuilt. Today's beaches, bluffs, hillsides, canyons and floodplains are temporary features of a constantly changing planet.

We ignore this reality when we build too close to the ocean, in a canyon, below an unstable hillside or on a floodplain. These are not necessarily dangerous places at every moment — but they are places where natural forces are already at work. Building there does not stop those forces; it simply puts people and property in their path.

History teaches us that resisting every change in the coastline is futile. The lesson is simpler: We should take the long view when deciding where and how to build. Understand the landscape. Plan for change. Understand that gravity will always win.

Simply put: Don't build your castles in the sand.

BILL PATZERT
Sierra Madre

Focus on L.A., not Israel

Re "Bass and Raman split on Gaza and 'genocide,'" Oct. 1

Neither Mayor Karen Bass nor City Councilmember Nithya Raman has the power to do anything in Israel.

They can't legislate there, they aren't Israeli citizens, and they can't vote there.

So I have one question for both of them: Why are you wasting your breath even attempting to articulate something over which you have absolutely no jurisdiction or influence?

We, the citizens of Los Angeles, are voting or not voting for one of you based on what we believe you can do for us and for our city. Again, that city is Los Angeles, not Jerusalem, Tel Aviv, Haifa or anywhere else in Israel — which, last I checked, happens to be approximately 7,572 miles away from L.A. City Hall.

Los Angeles Jews, of which I am proudly and unabashedly one, have every reason and right to know how you plan to protect and care for us, as well as for every other citizen in this wildly diverse city of ours.

For either of you to pontificate on whether or not Israel is committing a genocide in Gaza is none of your business. And it's a waste of all our time, Jew and non-Jew alike.

Please stay in your lane and tell us how you will make Los Angeles better for us here.

MITZI SCHWARZ
Los Angeles

::

While the problems in Gaza are serious and far-reaching, I am vastly more concerned about how Bass and Raman plan to tackle the problems right here in Los Angeles!

They are running to be the mayor of America's second-largest city. What will the winner do about our intractable homelessness, funding for our fire and police departments, traffic

congestion, air quality, safety at schools and parks, etc.?

Our next mayor must have a clear focus on local issues, not Gaza.

MONA GERECHT
Los Angeles

City should bring in experts

Re "L.A. council OKs \$466 million in affordable housing spending," Sept. 28

Before the city of Los Angeles distributes the fresh round of funding for new housing, a specific oversight committee needs to be created to monitor and audit the bids from developers constructing these projects. It seems quite doubtful that any city council member and their staff and offices have deep experience with and knowledge of the construction industry.

Those on this potential committee, along with other qualifications, would need to have experience in construction plans, construction bidding, procurement of building materials and building techniques.

They should be able to show a history of finished projects and conduct cost analyses of the bids. The funding must be audited frequently to protect the city's funds.

The new units should not be luxury nor, of course, slum buildings. They should be honorable and welcoming living spaces so the tenants are taken care of decently, and the city's funds are spent wisely and not wasted.

MATTHEW HETZ
Los Angeles

HOW TO WRITE TO US

Please send letters to letters@latimes.com. For submission guidelines, see latimes.com/letters.



Los Angeles Times
FOUNDED DECEMBER 4, 1881
A California Times Publication

Executive Chairman Dr. Patriek Soon-Shiong

News: Executive Editor Terry Tang • Managing Editor Hector Becerra • Editor at Large Scott Kraft • Deputy Managing Editors Shelby Grad, Amy King, Monte Morin • Assistant Managing Editors John Canalis, Steve Clow, Angel Jennings, Iliana Limón Romero, Ruthanne Salido • General Manager, Food Laurie Ochoa • Opinion: Op-Ed Editor Philip Gray • Business: President and Chief Operating Officer Chris Argentieri • Chief Human Resources Officer Nancy V. Antoniou • President of L.A. Times Studios Anna Magzanyan • General Counsel Jeff Glasser

NantGames, the LA Times, LA Times Studios and NantStudios power the Los Angeles Times Media Group (LATMG).



LATMG

Powering the New Media Revolution

NantGames

Shaping the future of esports and digital games.

NantGames, an LATMG company, is a **cutting-edge video game studio and esports arena**. Driven by groundbreaking new technology and mobile engagement tools, NantGames bridges digital and physical worlds with innovative original IP and immersive esports environments.

Through LATMG, 157 nations and 23 international sports federations unite millions in global esports competition and experiences, where national pride meets global play. The studio combines real-world geolocation with role-playing game mechanics to create deeply engaging, scalable gaming experiences.

NANTGAMES IS REDEFINING GAMING

Out ahead of a rapidly growing gaming and esports market
Powered by innovation and next-gen technology
Creating word and idle games at scale

EPIC DIGITAL ENGAGEMENT

46MM game page views in 12 months¹
1MM unique players per month²

1) Ensighten; 2) Ensighten

2026 GLOBAL ESPORTS WORLD FINALS
HOST PARTNER

641MM Est. Global Esports Audience¹
High-engagement digital gaming meets the thrill of live sports

1) SQ Magazine

LATMG: The Next-Gen Media Platform

Own a piece of the new media revolution.

Invest now and get a **7% annual dividend** until the planned public offering and convert at a **25% discount** to the public offering price.

LEARN MORE
invest.latimes.com



LA Times Media Group Inc. is currently undertaking a private placement offering Preferred shares pursuant to Section 4(a)(2) of the Securities Act of 1933, as amended (the "Act"), and/or Rule 506 of Regulation D promulgated thereunder. Digital Offering, member FINRA/SIPC is the broker-dealer of record for this offering. Investors should consider the investment objectives, risks, and investment time horizon of LA Times Media Group Inc. carefully before investing. The Offering Documents relating to each offering of equity interests by LA Times Media Group Inc. will contain this and other information and should be read carefully before investing. Securities of LA Times Media Group Inc. are being offered and sold in reliance on the exemption from registration set forth in Section 506(c) under the Securities Act of 1933, as amended, or the "Securities Act". In accordance therewith, you should be aware that (i) the securities may be sold only to "accredited investors," which for natural persons are investors who meet certain minimum annual income or net worth thresholds; (ii) the securities will only be offered in reliance on an exemption from the registration requirements of the Securities Act and will not be required to comply with specific disclosure requirements that apply to registration under the Securities Act; (iii) the Securities and Exchange Commission will not pass upon the merits of or give its approval to the securities, the terms of the offering, or the accuracy or completeness of any offering materials; (iv) the securities will be subject to legal restrictions on transfer and resale and investors should not assume they will be able to resell their securities; investing in securities involves risk, and investors should be able to bear the loss of their investment.

The advertisement may include "forward-looking statements" with the meaning of Section 27A of the Securities Act of 1933 and Section 21E of the Exchange Act of 1934 and are intended to be covered by the safe harbor provisions for forward looking statements. This information is supplied from sources we believe to be reliable but we cannot guarantee accuracy. Although we believe our expectations expressed in such forward looking statements are reasonable, we cannot assure you that they will be realized. Investors are cautioned that such forward-looking statements involve risks and uncertainties that could cause actual results to differ materially from the anticipated results. LA Times Media Group Inc. may, in the future, undertake a public offering pursuant to Regulation A under the Act. No money or other consideration is being solicited at this time with respect to such an offering, and if sent in response to these materials for such an offering, it will not be accepted. No offer to buy securities can be accepted and no part of the purchase price can be received for an offering under Regulation A until an offering statement is qualified by the U. S. Securities and Exchange Commission, and any such offer may be withdrawn or revoked, without obligation or commitment of any kind, at any time before notice of its acceptance given after the qualification date. An indication of interest made by a prospective investor in a Regulation A offering is non-binding and involves no obligation or commitment of any kind.

The Company is "Testing the Waters" under Regulation A under the Securities Act of 1933. The Company is not under any obligation to make an offering under Regulation A. No money or other consideration is being solicited in connection with the information provided, and if sent in response, will not be accepted. No offer to buy the securities can be accepted and no part of the purchase price can be received until an offering statement on Form 1-A has been filed and until the offering statement is qualified pursuant to Regulation A of the Securities Act of 1933, as amended, and any such offer may be withdrawn or revoked, without obligation or commitment of any kind, at any time before notice of its acceptance given after the qualification date. Any person's indication of interest involves no obligation or commitment of any kind. No offer to sell the securities or solicitation of an offer to buy the securities is being made in any state where such offer or sale is not permitted under the "blue sky" or securities laws thereof. No offering is being made to individual investors in any state unless and until the offering has been registered in that state or an exemption from registration exists therein.

CALIFORNIA

MONDAY, OCTOBER 5, 2026 :: LATIMES.COM/CALIFORNIA



Photographs by GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

GREEN and white balloons are launched in memory of Bruce Rodriguez in Mar Vista on Saturday. A suspect in his killing is in custody.

A tribute to slain Culver CityBus driver

Memorial comes as more details emerge, including the ID of the suspect arrested.

BY ALEXANDRA DEL ROSARIO AND GENARO MOLINA

Dozens of friends, family members, co-workers and civic leaders gathered outside Wildwood Elementary School in Culver City on an unusually warm Saturday night to say goodbye to Bruce Rodriguez, a beloved father of two who was shot and killed while driving his bus.

Rodriguez's wife, Sandy Sanchez, was among the attendees who released green and white balloons to honor her husband. Sanchez said she hopes her husband's death would spark a fresh

examination of bus driver safety in the hopes that the tragedy won't be repeated.

"No wife should lose her husband this way, and no child should lose a father because he went to work," she said.

Additional details in the fatal Culver CityBus shooting have emerged, including the identity of the man accused of killing Rodriguez, who is now in custody.

The shooting occurred Thursday evening in Mar Vista and claimed the life of Rodriguez, a 42-year-old man whose family remembered his dedication to his loved ones, including his parents and his two sons, a 3-year-old and a 6-month-old.

"Bruce served his community from behind the wheel. The role he loved most was at home, where he

[See CityBus, B4]



SANDY SANCHEZ, right, the wife of Bruce Rodriguez, is embraced Saturday.

State leads lawsuit against easing of fuel-economy rules

BY HAYLEY SMITH

California is leading a coalition of states and local governments in suing the Trump administration over its rollback of federal vehicle mileage standards, alleging the new rules illegally weaken fuel-economy requirements for cars and light trucks.

The lawsuit, filed Friday by California Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta and a group of 26 states, counties and cities, is one of at least three legal challenges last week to new rules from the U.S. Department of Transportation and National Highway Traffic Safety Administration.

The change lowers the fuel-economy requirement for 2031 model-year vehicles to 34.9 miles per gallon, when it would have been 50.4 mpg under rules from the Biden administration. Federal officials said the change will boost the domestic auto industry and lower consumer costs.

It comes as fuel prices remain elevated amid President Trump's war with Iran, which has disrupted the global oil supply since February.

In California, gasoline averaged \$6.40 a gallon on Fri-

day, compared with \$4.65 a gallon one year ago, according to AAA.

In the lawsuit, California and its allies argue that NHTSA failed to meet a congressional mandate to set corporate average fuel economy standards, or CAFE standards, at the "maximum feasible" level — a reflection of available technology, economic practicability, the effect of other motor vehicle standards and the need to conserve energy.

Instead, the new standards governing the next five years require fewer miles per gallon than the U.S. fleet achieved in 2021, Bonta told reporters Friday. The lawsuit was filed in the U.S. Court of Appeals for the 1st Circuit in Massachusetts.

"The benefits of helping Americans drive on less gas should be obvious by now," Bonta said. "Using less gas means less dependence on oil, less exposure to global oil shocks, and less pollution from vehicles and oil production. And it means drivers spend less money at the pump."

Congress established the "maximum feasible" rule in 1975 when it began regulating vehicle fuel efficiency in response to a global oil crisis

[See Fuel, B4]

BOILING POINT

Strange visitors and starving pups: What El Niño brings to the coast

BY LILA SEIDMAN

The fierce El Niño forecast for this winter may well be hard on the flippered and scaled creatures that share our beaches and waters.

Yet some headlines are hopeful, even awe-inspiring. Take the account of a giant, gentle whale shark gliding through the blue waters off the Southern California coast.

I wondered if these dots could be connected, so I turned to experts and The Times' extensive coverage to try to break down what El Niño means for local ecosystems. Here's what I found



CHRISTINA HOUSE Los Angeles Times

AN ELEPHANT seal is released at Cabrillo Beach as Marine Mammal Care Center volunteers look on.

out.

El Niño is a climate pattern triggered by unusually warm waters in the tropical Pacific, which in turn affects weather around the world in different ways. Long, planetary waves push the warm water to our coast and also raise the sea level, according to Clarissa Anderson, director of the Southern California Coastal Ocean Observing System at UC San Diego's Scripps Institution of Oceanography.

"We can always say that waters will be warmer and that they will be higher," she said. But predicting how ocean life will respond is

[See El Niño, B5]

Voices **GEORGE SKELTON** COLUMNIST **CAPITOL JOURNAL**

Becerra cruises, Hilton veers

The gubernatorial candidates' debate showed their places in the race

SACRAMENTO
Look, Xavier Becerra could cruise to a South Pacific island and bask on the beach until election day and Californians would still choose him as their next governor.

So, last week's televised CNN debate between Becerra and Republican Steve Hilton really had no elec-

tion significance, although it was important for the Democratic front-runner in other ways.

Who won the debate? Becerra, because he came across as calm, collected and capable of governing this troubled state — certainly very few voters' ideal candidate, but the only real choice for most Californians.

There's simply no way Becerra can

lose on Nov. 3 because his only opponent is a Republican. Californians will not elect a Republican governor in this polarized era, particularly one endorsed by the reviled President Trump.

Moreover, Hilton's only previous political experience was as an advisor to a British prime minister and his

[See Skelton, B6]

L.A. ON THE RECORD

Bass and Raman campaigns trading charges

BY NOAH GOLDBERG, JAMES RAINEY AND DAVID ZAHNISER

Hours before Nithya Raman took the stage at Jewish Federation L.A.'s mayoral forum last week, Mayor Karen Bass' campaign blasted out a press release accusing the council member of skipping a City Council Jewish Heritage Month event to appear on Hasan Piker's livestream.

The Raman camp's response: "The Mayor is deliberately spreading misinformation that the public record directly contradicts," said Liz Garcia, a campaign spokesperson.

Piker is a left-wing streamer on the platform Twitch and a fierce critic of Israel. Raman appeared on his stream on May 15, where he asked her if she thought Israel was committing genocide in Palestine. She said she did.

That same day, Raman missed a Jewish Heritage Month event at City Hall. Debbie Paperman, who is on the executive board of Democrats for Israel Los Angeles, said Raman told her that she had not been feeling well.

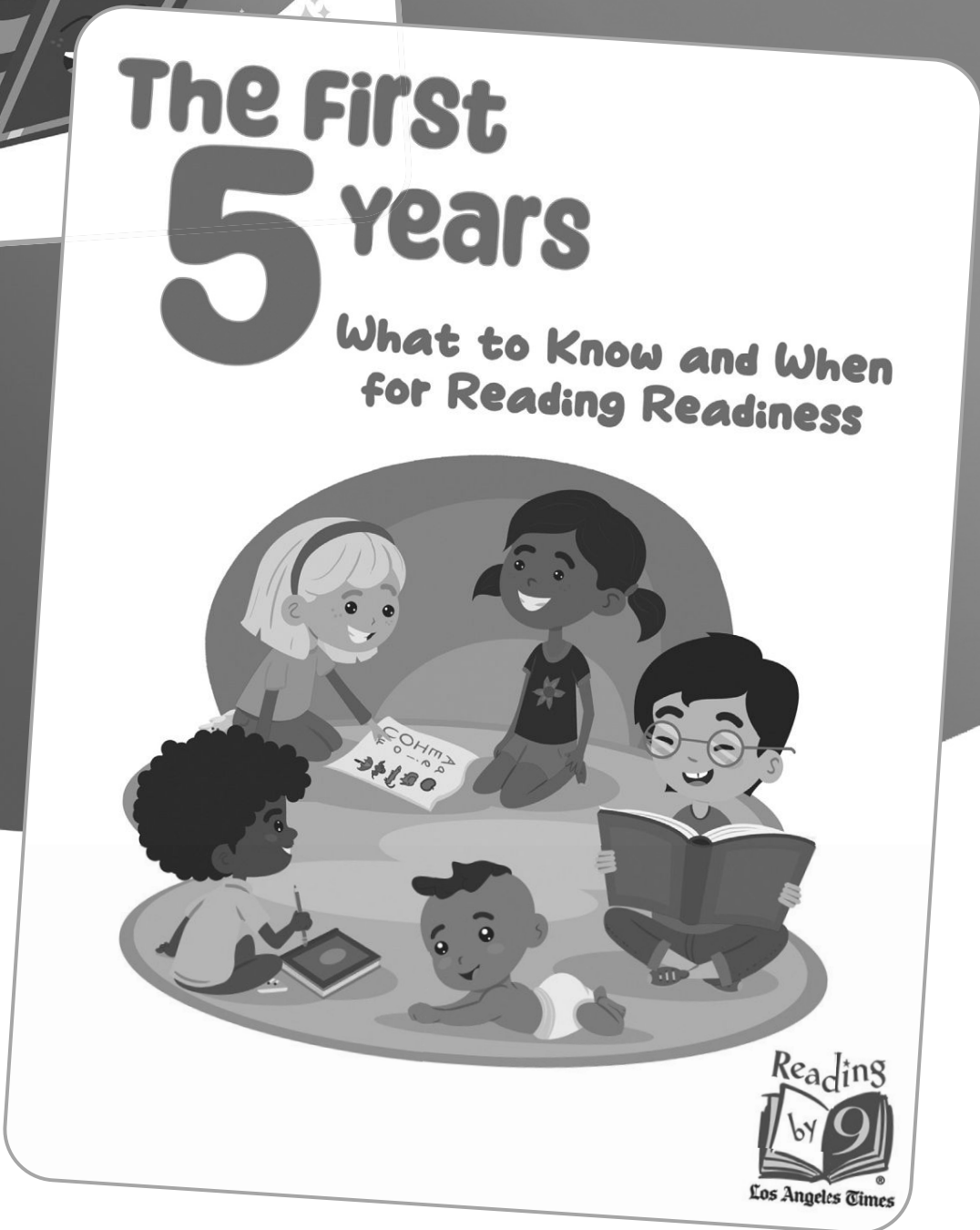
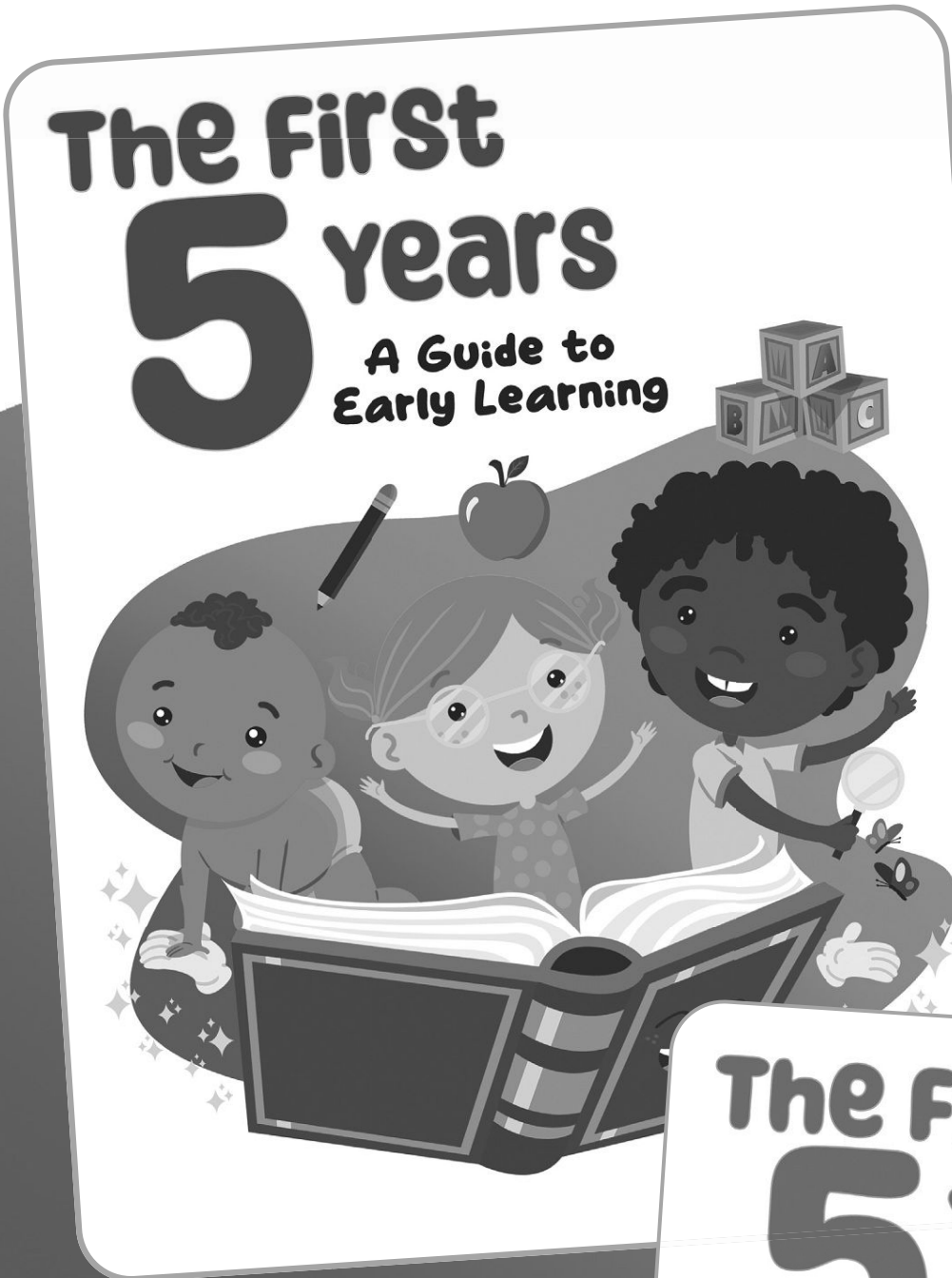
The Bass campaign, citing the fact that Raman appeared on Piker's stream the same day, fired off an email to reporters claiming the council member had lied about her reasons for missing the Jewish heritage event.

The Raman campaign said that Raman *was*, in fact, ill.

Video from the May 15 council meeting shows Raman was present at the start of the meeting, but no longer at her seat during the heritage event, in which Councilmember Bob Blumenfield celebrated Jewish athletes.

More than an hour later, Raman was back in council to make a speech and introduce other speakers for Hapa Day, celebrating peo-

[See Campaigns, B5]



Foster children’s vocabulary, confidence and imagination with **“The First 5 Years”** — a series of research-backed guides filled with expert advice, activities and more to help build literacy skills in children ages 0-5.

Scan the code to download the FREE guides.

The guides were created through the generous support of the Ballmer Group and features contributions from the Los Angeles Public Library, First 5 LA, Zero to Three, QSLA and others.



CITY & STATE

Football team told to delete photos at In-N-Out

Images of Lincoln High players at burger joint draw corporate trademark warning.

By CLARA HARTER

A behind-the-scenes video of a Northern California high school football team staging a fun-filled photo shoot at their local In-N-Out quickly racked up nearly a million views on Instagram. Brentwood-based photographer Glenn Silva was thrilled to see that the photos he was hired to take at the Lincoln High School football players' favorite hangout in their Sacramento suburb were resonating with a wide audience online.

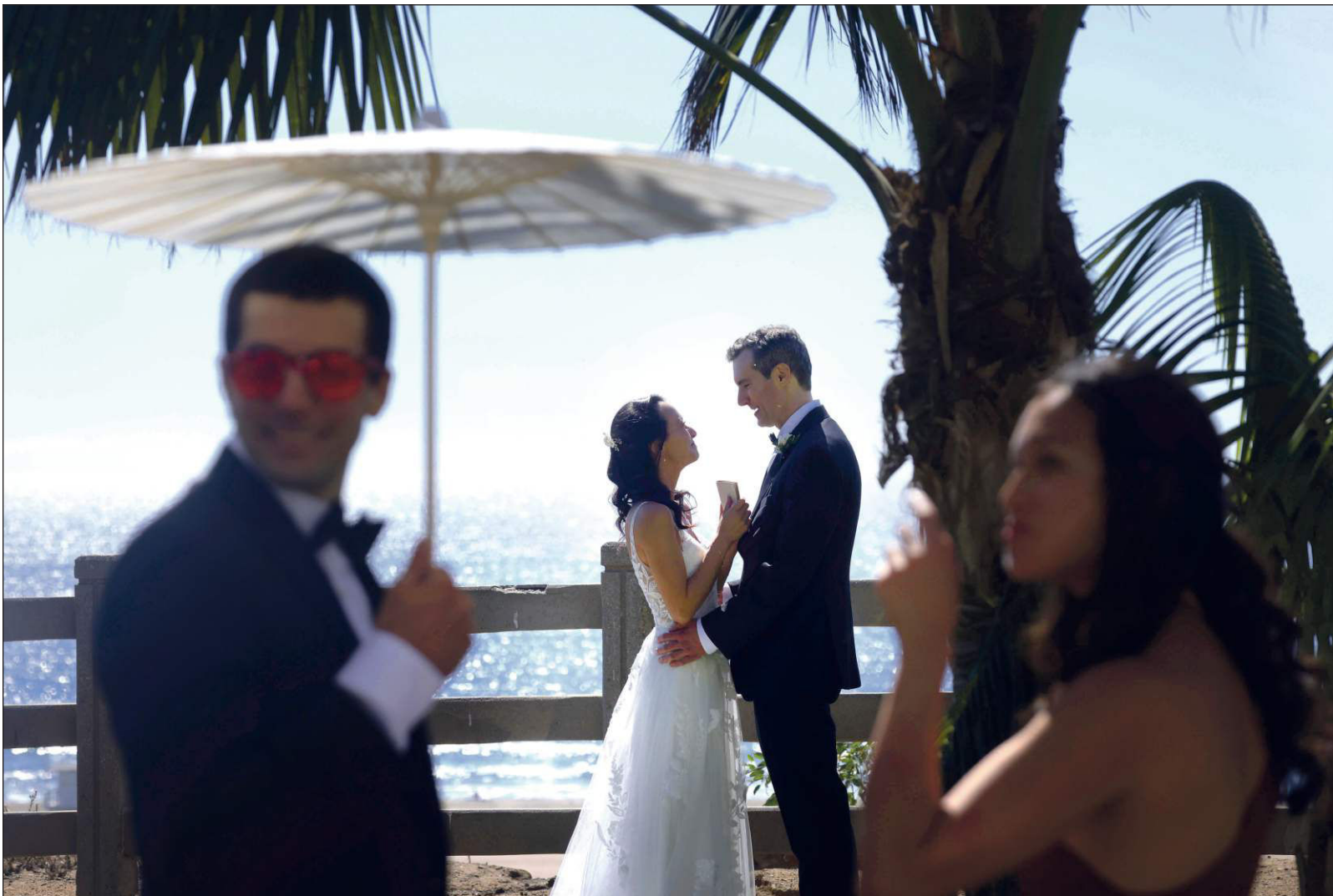
In-N-Out's trademark team was less enthused.

Last month, representatives for the fast-food chain emailed Silva and the team demanding that all content from the shoot be taken down. The photos showed the Lincoln football players posing behind the counter and drive-through window dressed in their football uniforms and helmets. SF Gate was first to report on the company's response.

"In-N-Out Burger takes the protection of its brand, trademarks, and trade dress very seriously," the Sept. 23 email, reviewed by The Times, reads. "The unauthorized use of our restaurant premises, signage, logos, or any other proprietary elements in your content may constitute a violation of our intellectual property rights."

UCLA law professor Mark McKenna and UC Berkeley law expert Vincent Joralemon independently said they were doubtful the fast-food chain would win a trademark case against the high school team if it were to take it to court. However, they both noted that In-N-Out's response was not surprising given the company's record of fiercely protecting its trademark.

In-N-Out did not respond to The Times' request for comment last week. The Lincoln High School athletic director referred questions to the Western Placer Unified School District, which



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

A VERY WARM MOMENT

The excessive heat didn't stop Trisha and Steve Grosserode from practicing their marriage vows in Santa Monica on Friday.



Google Maps

LINCOLN High School's football team staged a photo shoot at their local In-N-Out Burger that went viral.

did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

Team mom and booster club member Chelsey Vanderschrier said she came up with the idea after seeing a trend on social media of high school teams staging creative media day photos at fast-food restaurants.

"That kind of birthed in me the idea of how special it would be to get some pictures of our team at our local In-N-Out because it's such a special place for them," she said. "They just love celebrating there on Friday nights after their game."

Silva said he was shocked to receive the email from In-

N-Out corporate as he had obtained permission to carry out the photo shoot from the manager of the local In-N-Out in Lincoln. The manager had even let the team enter the restaurant an hour before opening. Silva was hired by the team booster club to take the photos, which were intended to be enjoyed by the players and their families.

He explained to the restaurant's corporate lawyer that he believed he had received the necessary approval and asked if corporate could grant a one-time exception to keep the photos online given how much the eatery and the experience

means to the teens.

Silva offered to modify captions, remove tags or take any other steps that could preserve the special moment for the athletes, noting that the photos were not intended as part of a broader social media campaign.

"What began as a fun photo session for a small-town high school football team unexpectedly became something that thousands of people connected with," he wrote in an email to the trademark team. "For the players and their families, however, it is still fundamentally what it was intended to be — a record of the kids, their teammates and a tradition that is part of their high school years."

In the email exchange, a company representative said that anyone wishing to carry out commercial or promotional photography at an In-N-Out location must obtain "express written consent" from the company's corporate office in advance — and that store managers are not authorized to provide this permission.

A lawyer for the fast-food chain wrote in a Sept. 24 email to Silva that he had passed along the request for retroactive approval, but the company declined it.

"We understand this is not the answer you were hoping for, and we want you to know that your request was given careful consideration," the attorney wrote. "Please confirm once the content has been taken down."

Silva and the team, which had shared the photos and videos as collaborative posts on Instagram, complied with the demand and took down the content that afternoon.

In-N-Out has an extensive record of defending its trademark and has frequently taken or threatened legal action against entities accused of copying its menu or branding.

For example, the company sued a Utah burger joint in 2007 for using trademarked menu names and a similar interior color scheme, sued Puma in 2019 over a pair of sneakers that mimicked employee apparel and sent a cease-and-desist letter in 2024 to a San Diego sports bar that offered "animal-style" fries.

McKenna, co-director of the UCLA Institute for Technology Law and Policy, said that the high school photo shoot doesn't strike him as an especially strong trademark legal claim.

"It's not like a business that's running its own Instagram account where people viewing the thing might think, 'Oh, this is a collaboration between In-N-Out and something else,'" he said. "It's a high school football team; they're not really commercial users."

Joralemon, senior fellow at UC Berkeley School of

Law, noted that when In-N-Out does go to court in a larger trademark case, it is beneficial for the company to be able to point to a strong track record of defending its brand.

"If [a court] can get evidence to say, 'Hey, you just let all these high schools use this, it almost looks like you're doing a co-sponsorship with these high schools,' then that would point to [In-N-Out] being a relatively weak brand, which might hurt them in the future," he said.

But, when it comes to the specific case of demanding the Lincoln Fighting Zebras to take down team photos at their beloved drive-through, the public response could be a net negative for the brand, he continued.

"It's always a calculation to say what's the PR cost going to be," he said. "Here, I don't know if In-N-Out made the right decision, because it doesn't really diminish [the brand] that much with just a high school team doing a photo shoot."

Vanderschrier said football team members were happy to comply with In-N-Out's demands as they did not want any further legal problems, but were nonetheless disappointed to delete the content after it received such a positive reception online.

"It's a bummer because the photos were so unique and it was really cool to see them go viral," she said. "The attention that they were getting is sort of exciting because that's not something that happens to us very often."

New law requires diaper disclosure

By KATE SEQUEIRA

Parents will soon be able to find out what their baby's diaper is made of under a new law signed by Gov. Gavin Newsom last week that requires companies to disclose ingredients both on packaging and online.

Babies can go through about 3,000 disposable diapers a year, a basic-need product that has increasingly drawn concern from child health, environmental and consumer advocates. Multiple studies link the chemicals, plastics and other ingredients often used in diapers with potential health and environmental risks.

Supporters of Assembly Bill 1901 say the law will give parents more information for decision-making and pressure manufacturers to avoid using ingredients they wouldn't want to disclose.

Companies will be required to provide disclosure online beginning in January 2029 and on packaging the following July. In its final form, the new law gives manufacturers more time to comply and sell the diapers currently on the market.

"Increasing transparency about the ingredients used in diapers is not a partisan issue; it is a pro-parent issue," Assemblymember Marc Berman (D-Menlo Park) said. Berman, who is a first-time father, believes it should be easier to access information regarding a product that touches his son's



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

BEGINNING in 2029, companies will need to disclose ingredients in diapers, which touch babies' skin 24/7.

skin "every hour of every day for the first few years of his life."

Both packaging and online product detail pages are permitted to provide an outbound link to a dedicated webpage on the manufacturer's website to display the full list of ingredients.

Companies that do not comply will be fined up to \$5,000 for the first nondisclosure violation and up to \$10,000 for any subsequent violation.

In a signing message, Newsom said he supported the mission to increase ingredient transparency for families, but voiced concern over the lack of protections for businesses, which may be forced to divulge confidential information through this disclosure requirement.

"An absence of flexibility around proprietary information could put manufacturers in a difficult position

with their suppliers or lead to public disclosure of legitimate confidential business information," he wrote. "I encourage the Department of Toxic Substances Control to initiate its rule-making authority under this bill to clarify these issues."

A spokesperson for the Center for Baby and Adult Hygiene Products, the trade association representing diaper manufacturers, said it is looking forward to collaborating with state officials to create guidance that will "ensure that the law provides meaningful transparency for consumers while appropriately safeguarding confidential business information."

The trade association originally opposed the bill, saying that manufacturers already followed rigorous internal safety standards that ensured safety for infants and children.

Infant skin is thinner and more absorbent, making babies more vulnerable to chemicals in disposable diapers, said Kelly Hardy, the senior managing director of health and research at the nonprofit Children Now, among the bill's sponsors.

Some diapers use synthetic musks to create fragrances and plastics that contain chemicals such as phthalates and volatile organic compounds, which studies have linked to developmental delays, reproductive harm, endocrine system disruption and cancer, according to Susan Little, the California legislative director for Environmental Working Group, a bill sponsor. Chemicals can also cause severe rashes and asthma.

"It's really important to many parents to understand what exactly is in the diapers, especially if their babies have sensitive skin or special needs," Hardy said.

Children Now, along with more than 300 organizations, signed a letter in August urging Newsom to sign the bill.

The California law builds off of a similar one passed in New York last year.

This article is part of The Times' early childhood education initiative, focusing on the learning and development of California children from birth to age 5. For more information about the initiative and its philanthropic funders, go to latimes.com/earlyed.

Malibu restaurant employee is killed in crash on PCH

By CHRISTOPHER GOFFARD

A 51-year-old employee of Nobu Malibu restaurant was fatally injured in a parked car Saturday morning when a Range Rover slammed into it on Pacific Coast Highway, authorities said.

The Los Angeles County Sheriff's Department identified the victim as Ryo Uchimiya and said he had arrived at work early Saturday and was waiting in his car outside the restaurant, a high-end Japanese eatery known for celebrity sightings.

The Range Rover, driven by a 16-year-old boy, struck Uchimiya's car around 6:50 a.m., said Los Angeles County Sheriff's Department Sgt. John Addington.

He said it appeared the boy had been speeding. No charges had been filed but an investigation was underway.

There were no other injuries reported.

The 21-mile stretch of Pacific Coast Highway that runs through Malibu is one of the state's deadliest and most notorious roads, with an average of about four crash-related fatalities per year over the last decade.

In October 2023, authorities say, a 24-year-old Malibu man driving a BMW at an estimated 104 miles per hour in a 45-mph zone struck three parked cars, which hit and fatally injured four Alpha Phi sorority sisters from Pepperdine University.

The driver, Fraser Bohm, has been charged with murder, and the incident prompted plans for increased safety measures, such as cameras and increased fines for speeding.

Construction zones proliferated in the area after the January 2025 fires that destroyed local homes and businesses, resulting in reduced speed limits.

Rollback of fuel economy rules is challenged

[Fuel, from B1] after a war in the Middle East. At the time, cars averaged about 13 mpg.

The new change also removes existing electric vehicles from the baseline used to determine how much additional fuel economy automakers can feasibly achieve, which “wildly distorts the starting point for NHTSA’s analysis and leads to dramatically weaker standards,” Bonta said.

It also ends a credit trading program that allowed EV companies such as Tesla, Rivian and Lucid to sell credits to other manufacturers to help them comply with the standards, which brought them considerable revenue.

It is California’s 97th lawsuit against the Trump administration in 88 weeks, Bonta said.

When asked to comment on the suit, officials with NHTSA pointed to U.S. Transportation Secretary Sean Duffy’s earlier statement about the rule change.

“Joe Biden and [former Transportation Secretary] Pete Buttigieg illegally twisted mileage standards to create an electric vehicle mandate — jacking up car prices for American families and forcing manufacturers to produce vehicles no one wanted,” Duffy said. “I’m proud to stand with President Trump to say that those days are over.”

Other suits brought by nonprofit environmental groups last week similarly challenged the agency for failing to meet the “maximum feasible” levels requirement set by Congress.

The nonprofit Natural Resources Defense Council,



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

ATTY. GEN. Rob Bonta and a group of 26 states, counties and cities filed the suit.

which filed in the U.S. Court of Appeals for the 2nd Circuit in New York, noted that NHTSA itself predicts the change will force the average driver of a new car to pay about \$1,600 more in fuel costs over the lifetime of the vehicle.

The new standards also will lead to billions of gallons of additional gasoline consumption, resulting in a “windfall for oil companies at the expense of the American public,” the group said.

They pointed to a 2020 study from researchers at Princeton which found that in the 50 years since the CAFE standards were established, they have saved more than 2 trillion gallons of gasoline, saved drivers a combined \$5 trillion in fuel costs and avoided 14 billion metric tons of planet-warming carbon dioxide emissions. Burning gasoline causes climate change.

Not everyone was opposed to the rule change, which Trump first proposed in December alongside auto industry executives from Ford, General Motors and Stellantis.

Officials with Stellantis told The Times the company “welcome[s] the administration’s efforts to reset the CAFE regulations to more achievable targets that are better aligned with market realities.”

In a press release, NHTSA administrator Jonathan Morrison said the rule “restores integrity to the national fuel economy program, balancing vehicle affordability and energy conservation goals while improving safety on our roadways.”

But Ann Carlson, a professor of environmental law at UCLA who helped set the previous rules as acting administrator of NHTSA under President Biden, described the new standards as “audaciously, aggressively awful.”

She had anticipated swift legal challenges based on the interpretation of maximum feasible standards. While Congress previously mandated at least 35 mpg by 2020, “they’re not even professing to reach that by 2030,” she said by phone last week.

Environmental groups said they’re confident their legal challenges will prevail. They include the nonprofits Public Citizen, the Center for Biological Diversity, Conservation Law Foundation, Environmental Defense Fund and Sierra Club, which filed the third suit Friday in the U.S. Court of Appeals for the District of Columbia Circuit.

“Consumers need more fuel-efficient choices when considering new cars, and they deserve vehicles that get more miles per gallon and miles per dollar,” said Robert Weissman, Public Citizen’s co-president. “Trump’s lawless push to roll back key safeguards on fuel economy will pollute our air, and line the pockets of oil and auto CEOs.”

The rollback follows other efforts from the Trump administration that favor the fossil fuel industry and contribute to air pollution, such as the Environmental Protection Agency’s recent reversal of greenhouse gas regulations for power plants that burn coal or natural gas.

With fare increase, sticker shock comes for Metrolink riders

Many are surprised by how much it will cost as prices climb for the first time in 13 years.

By COLLEEN SHALBY

Tonia Jones was shocked to learn that Metrolink fares were going up. She’s taken the train regularly for the last seven years, often with her 12-year-old dog. It’s how she commutes between Montclair and downtown Los Angeles for her business and to visit family as she saves for a car while gas prices rise.

She wasn’t prepared for the hike but doesn’t have another option.

“We can’t afford that! How ridiculous,” Jones, 61, said while waiting for her train at Union Station. “I don’t know what to do — just get out of California when I can.”

As Metrolink faces budget shortfalls and service reductions, the regional commuter rail network is raising its ticket prices on Monday for the first time in 13 years by as much as 27%.

On Sunday, at Union Station, there was little visible notice to riders about the change. The welcome screen at the ticket kiosks noted a “fare adjustment,” with no further information, and no signage appeared anywhere near the main entrance or inside the train depot.

Many riders who regularly rely on the train have voiced their anger over the changes as one-way tickets go up by 14%; daily passes by 27%, from \$15 to \$19; and weekend passes by 20%, from \$10 to \$12.

Some were unaware of just how much it would cost them.

Gabriel Frias, 38, has taken Metrolink nearly every day for the last two decades to commute to work at a party rental business in Van Nuys and to visit his children on the weekends in Fontana. He was disappointed to learn just how much the fares would increase without any gains for riders, and he questioned the rationale.

“Everyone is struggling. For day-to-day commuters, this is another thing they have to worry about,” Frias said. “One-way tickets all the way up to the weekend tickets? That will affect a lot of people. ... It’s more money to fork out for the same ride.”

Adriana Rizzo of Californians for Electric Rail, which advocates for overhead-electric rail systems, is a regular transit rider who has raised concerns to the Metrolink board about recent decisions over service and ticket prices.

“These fare increases will not raise enough to fill Metrolink’s budget deficit,” she told The Times.

“Instead, riders will face a one-two punch of fare increases and service cuts, making Metrolink harder to ride just as Southern Californians are facing record gas prices.”

Metrolink is operated by the Southern California Regional Rail Authority, overseen by members from multiple transit authorities including those of L.A. and Orange counties. The agency reduced service this year and has proposed more cuts in recent board meetings.

“Metrolink has worked hard to keep fares affordable while the cost of operating and maintaining our regional rail system has continued to rise,” Metrolink Chief Executive Darren Kettle said in a recent statement. “These pricing adjustments are one step in a broader effort we are taking to responsibly address those pressures and support Metrolink’s long-term financial sustainability.”

The agency’s operator was recently sued by a former executive who was fired this year after raising concerns about train safety. He alleged that Metrolink has not properly maintained its parts, leading to multiple instances of mechanical failure that have endangered passengers and staff.

Board members at Metro, a major funder of Metrolink, have also criticized the agency and its leaders over service cuts and recently approved an audit of the system.

MARKETPLACE

JOBS · REAL ESTATE · MORE

latimes.com/placead
To place an ad call 1.800.234.4444

Los Angeles Times

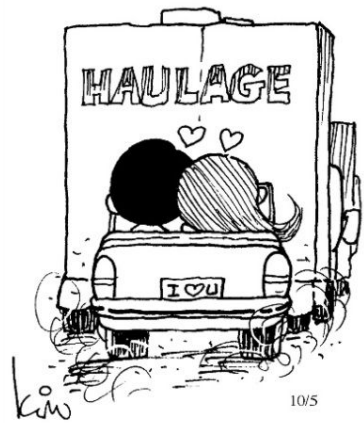
From brokers to buyers. In one place.

LA Times
Real Estate Classified

Advertise Today
(800) 234-4444



love is...



...happy together, even in traffic!

TM Reg. U.S. Pat. Off. — all rights reserved
© 2026 Minikim Holland B.V.

LEGAL NOTICES
1300

Legal Notices

SEEKING BIDS FOR IRS-VITA SUBCONTRACTOR
Latino Resource Organization, operator of the North Hollywood-Sun Valley FamilySource Center, is accepting proposals from nonprofit bidders to provide IRS-Volunteer Income Tax Assistance (VITA) services. Bid release: 10/02/2026. Bid Submission Deadline: 10/15/2026 at 3:00 p.m. Email info@latinoresource.org to request bid packet.

You're connected.
Los Angeles Times
latimes.com.

HOW TO PLACE AN AD

Self-service 24/7:
latimes.com/placead

Contact us by phone 24/7:
800-234-4444

ADVERTISING POLICIES
For Los Angeles Times advertising terms and conditions go to:
www.latimes.com/about/la-ads-terms-20181105-htmistory.html

LA Times Real Estate Classified
Los Angeles Times

Your way home.

Los Angeles Times
Real Estate Classified

More detailed listings, in all price ranges, leading to your new front door.

To advertise, call (800) 234-4444

Los Angeles Times

SUMMONS (CITACION JUDICIAL)

Case Number (Numero del Caso): 26LBCV01562

NOTICE TO DEFENDANT: (AVISO AL DEMANDADO):
JAVIER YORBA an individual; ALL PERSONS UNKNOWN, CLAIMING ANY LEGAL OR EQUITABLE RIGHT, TITLE, ESTATE, LIEN, OR INTEREST IN THE PROPERTY DESCRIBED IN THE COMPLAINT ADVERSE TO PLAINTIFF'S TITLE, OR ANY CLOUD ON PLAINTIFF'S TITLE THEREOF, AND DOES 1 through 20, inclusive

YOU ARE BEING SUED BY PLAINTIFF: (LO ESTÁ DEMANDANDO EL DEMANDANTE):
WILMINGTON SAVINGS FUND SOCIETY, FSB, NOT IN ITS INDIVIDUAL CAPACITY, BUT SOLELY AS TRUSTEE FOR RESIDENTIAL MORTGAGE AGGREGATION TRUST

NOTICE! You have been sued. The court may decide against you without your being heard unless you respond within 30 days. Read the information below.

You have 30 CALENDAR DAYS after this summons and legal papers are served on you to file a written response at this court and have a copy served on the plaintiff. A letter or phone call will not protect you. Your written response must be in proper legal form if you want the court to hear your case. There may be a court form that you can use for your response. You can find these court forms and more information at the California Courts Online Self-Help Center (www.courtinfo.ca.gov/selfhelp), your county law library, or the courthouse nearest you. If you cannot pay the filing fee, ask the court clerk for a fee waiver form. If you do not file your response on time, you may lose the case by default, and your wages, money, and property may be taken without further warning from the court.

There are other legal requirements. You may want to call an attorney right away. If you do not know an attorney, you may want to call an attorney referral service. If you cannot afford an attorney, you may be eligible for free legal services from a nonprofit legal services program. You can locate these nonprofit groups at the California Legal Services Web Site (www.lawhelpcalifornia.org), the California Courts Online Self-Help Center (www.courtinfo.ca.gov/selfhelp), or by contacting your local court or county bar association. NOTE: The court has a statutory lien for waived fees and costs on any settlement or arbitration award of \$10,000 or more in a civil case. The court's lien must be paid before the court will dismiss the case.

¡AVISO! Lo han demandado. Si no responde dentro de 30 días, la corte puede decidir en su contra sin escuchar su versión. Lea la información a continuación.

Tiene 30 DÍAS DE CALENDARIO después de que le entreguen esta citación y papeles legales para presentar una respuesta por escrito en esta corte y hacer que se entregue una copia al demandante. Una carta o una llamada telefónica no lo protegen. Su respuesta por escrito tiene que estar en formato legal correcto si desea que procesen su caso en la corte. Es posible que haya un formulario que usted pueda usar para su respuesta. Puede encontrar estos formularios de la corte y mas informacion en el Centro de Ayuda de las Cortes de California (www.sucorte.ca.gov), en la biblioteca de leyes de su condado o en la corte que le quede mas cerca. Si no puede pagar la cuota de presentacion, pida al secretario de la corte que le de un formulario de exencion de pago de cuotas. Si no presenta su respuesta a tiempo, puede perder el caso por incumplimiento y la corte le podra quitar su sueldo, dinero y bienes sin mas advertencia.

The name and address of the court is: (El nombre y direccion de la corte es):
Los Angeles County Superior Court
275 Magnolia
Long Beach, CA 90802

The name, address, and telephone number of plaintiff's attorney, or plaintiff without an attorney, is: (El nombre, la direccion y el numero de telefono del abogado del demandante, o del demandante que no tiene abogado, es):
Regina J. McClendon (SBN 184669); Meagan S. Tom (SBN 273489)
Troutman Pepper Locke LLP, Three Embarcadero Center, Suite 800
San Francisco, CA 94111
(415) 477-5700

Date: (Fecha) 07/02/2026

David W. Slayton, Executive Officer/Clerk of Court
Clerk
(Secretario)
Deputy
(Adjunto)

Don't let the phone stop ringing



Advertise with
LA Times
Classified

LA Times
Classified
(800) 234-4444

JUMBLE

Unscramble these Jumbles, one letter to each square, to form four ordinary words.

LYEAL
□ □ □ □ □

EUIST
□ □ □ □ □

TEFDEC
□ □ □ □ □

AHELXE
□ □ □ □ □

©2026 Tribune Content Agency, LLC
All Rights Reserved.

Print the answer here:

□ □ □ □ □

Saturday's Jumbles: STRUM OUNCE TRUDGE FONDUE
Answer: For the smart child, spotting the fifth letter of the alphabet was — “E-SEE” TO DO

THAT SCRAMBLED WORD GAME

By David L. Hoyt and Jeff Knurek



Now arrange the circled letters to form the surprise answer, as suggested by the above cartoon.

□ □ □ □ □

(Answers tomorrow)

servants who keep our communities moving.”

Culver City Mayor Freddy Puza said in a statement Friday, “We have lost a deeply valued member of our City Family to a senseless act of violence.” Puza announced that the city would suspend Culver CityBus service throughout the weekend and provide staff with crisis support as they grieve Rodriguez’s death.

“When services do resume, please be kind to our operators and transit team as they navigate this unimaginable tragedy,” Puza’s announcement ended.

The GoFundMe campaign for Rodriguez’s family has raised more than \$78,600 of its \$150,000 goal. The description for the fundraiser remembered Rodriguez for his “easygoing warmth,” along with his affinity for race cars, baking and “a good cup of coffee.”

“These are the everyday pieces of Bruce that his family and friends will carry with them,” the GoFundMe account said.

Rodriguez is survived by his parents, his wife, Sandy, their two sons and his sister-in-law.

Jennifer Vance, a fellow Culver CityBus driver who has worked at the agency for 11 years, helped organize Saturday’s memorial. In the moments before the attendees released their balloons, she encouraged everyone to say something loud about her missing friend and colleague.

“You can say, ‘I love you Bruce,’ or ‘I miss you Bruce,’ but please, say something,” she said.

And on the count of three, the people in the crowd released the balloons, which rose into the warm night sky along with the sound of dozens of voices shouting, in the hope that their messages somehow reach their lost friend and father.

Times staff writer Iris Kwok contributed to this report.

Bouquet fire grows near Santa Clarita amid heat wave

By Christopher Goffard and Susanne Rust

The Bouquet fire in Angeles National Forest grew overnight to 1,048 acres and is now 40% contained.

The Los Angeles County Sheriff's Department issued evacuation orders for the remote mountainous area northeast of Santa Clarita on Saturday afternoon.

John Miller, a forest spokesperson, said the canyon has several small cabins and some residents, and he estimates roughly 30 to 60 people are directly affected by the fire and the evacuations.

Come Monday, that number is likely to grow as commuter roads, such as Bouquet Canyon and San Francisco Canyon roads, remain closed.

"There will be a traffic impact if the road remains closed for an extended period of time," he said.

On Sunday afternoon,



KAYLA BARTKOWSKI Los Angeles Times

FIREFIGHTERS battle the blaze burning in Angeles National Forest on Sunday.

the fire activity had increased, said Miller, who was at the scene. He did not provide specific details but said between the "tankers and the helicopters they have kept it from the cabins."

Gov. Gavin Newsom pleaded with people on X to follow local evacuation orders and heed guidance from emergency officials.

County Supervisor Kathryn Barger expressed in a statement her appreciation for the firefighters and first responders at the scene "working this incident in extremely hot and difficult conditions."

The fire is blazing as temperatures soar across Southern California, reaching 15 to 20 degrees above normal. Temperatures were 107 degrees in some areas of the national forest Saturday. And although the mercury is forecast to drop a bit lower, forecasters are still anticipating very hot conditions ranging from the mid-90s to 100 degrees.

The heat wave is ex-

pected to linger until at least Thursday.

Miller said conditions Sunday morning had improved, but "things could get active. It's one of those things that you gotta just be ready for."

He said Santa Ana winds fueled the fire Saturday, pushing it in a southwesterly direction.

"If those winds diminish," he said, allowing for the typical ocean-driven winds, that "could cause the fire to get active in an area that it wasn't" on Saturday.

But as of Sunday morning, it was too early to tell.

He said the crews battling the fire have fared OK, despite the hot weather.

"Between the engines, the hand crews and the dozers, and with the helicopters supporting them ... they're trying to gain as much ground as they can," he said.

The wildfire started Saturday around 3 p.m. at Bouquet Canyon Road and Quarry Road. Its cause remains unknown.

Bass campaign accuses Raman of skipping Jewish heritage event

[**Campaigns**, from B1]

ple of mixed Asian and Pacific Island heritage, during which she said she wasn't feeling well.

Raman's team said she was still at City Hall during the Jewish Heritage Month event, but that she left council chambers due to her illness.

She felt better later that afternoon, the Raman camp said, allowing her to appear on Piker's show.

Paperman said she wasn't convinced. "It happened that you were sick for the multiple hours this was going on and you happened to get better to go on this psycho's stream?" said Paperman. "I don't believe that."

Piker, meanwhile, shot back at the mayor for using his name to try to dissuade voters from supporting Raman.

"Karen Bass is deploying the same nasty tactic that Donald Trump used recently at a press conference, wondering out loud why any Jewish person would vote for Democrats, due to my presence in the big tent," he told The Times in a text message.

Piker said he will vote for Raman, though he supported Bass against billion-

aire Rick Caruso in 2022.

"I was also a fan of [her] past work in Cuba," he told The Times. "Karen Bass used to be quite the radical."

Bass swings up in new poll

Bass will need to rely on undecided Republican and conservative voters to propel her to a mayoral victory, a new poll paid for by a group supporting her found.

The incumbent mayor is trailing Raman by 4 percentage points, 39% to 35%, with a quarter of the electorate still undecided, according to the initial results from an FM3 Research poll that was commissioned by the Central City Assn.'s PAC, an independent expenditure group supporting the mayor.

When the pollsters gave likely voters additional, critical information about both candidates, Bass shot up by 5 points and took a narrow lead over Raman, 40% to 39%, with 21% undecided, according to FM3.

"The undecided voters ... are disproportionately: Republicans, conservatives, 65+, homeowners, Democratic women over the age of 50 and those who do not hold a college degree," wrote the

research company in a polling memorandum.

The poll surveyed 809 likely L.A. voters from Sept. 21 to Sept. 28. It has a margin of error of 3.5 percentage points.

"The mayoral race remains a statistical tie," said Nella McOsker, the president of the Central City Assn. "Our poll demonstrates that some of the most reliable voting blocs swing to Bass once they fully learn both candidates' records."

A poll conducted between Sept. 15 and Sept. 20 by the UC Berkeley Institute of Governmental Studies, co-sponsored by The Times, found Raman was ahead 39% to 28%.

Raman allies talk trash

A woman walks out of her home carrying a full garbage bag, then starts venting about the high cost of trash pickup.

"Karen Bass has nearly bankrupted L.A., so the city doubled my trash fees. Isn't L.A. expensive enough?" the woman says angrily, before slamming the lid on a black trash bin.

That message is at the heart of a campaign video

created by Streets for All, a transportation advocacy group now spending about \$1.2 million to promote Raman and tear down Bass.

That ad is missing a key piece of information: Raman voted to hike those trash fees several times last year, even as two of her council colleagues spoke out against them.

"I was one of two no votes," said City Councilmember Monica Rodriguez, who is supporting Bass' reelection, in an interview. "She never once pushed back."

Rodriguez called the ad misleading, saying it implies that Raman was an opponent of the fee hikes.

Michael Schneider, who runs the Streets for All campaign committee, defended the 14-second spot, saying council members hiked the trash fees to make up for bad budget decisions made by the mayor — including her support for a \$2.6-billion upgrade of the Convention Center.

The council boosted the trash fee to \$55.95 per month last year for small apartment buildings, up from \$24.33. For single-family homes, the monthly fee was also hiked to \$55.95, up from \$36.32.

The city's budget advisors said the increases were needed in large part because the monthly fees had not been increased in 17 years. As a result, L.A.'s residential trash customers were not being charged the full cost of garbage pickup, leaving the city budget to cover the difference.

'Kick It in the Park' Olympic makeover

L.A.'s summer of 2026 will be remembered for stifling heat, innumerable Dodgers injuries and, especially, World Cup watch parties.

Teams, corporate sponsors and the city of Los Angeles welcomed in the world, producing large crowds and kumbaya moments — with fans of opposing teams partying side by side in (relative) peace and harmony.

Bass' "Kick It in the Park" events drew a total of 45,000 fans over the length of the quadrennial soccer tournament. A survey of about 2,000 of them registered overwhelming support for the free shindigs.

Paul Krekorian, executive director of the mayor's Office of Major Events, declared victory in a meeting with City Council members last week.

He also said that substantial planning is already underway to bring the city even more viewing parties and "activations" during the 2028 Olympics.

While the city hosted a maximum of three viewing parties a day during the World Cup, it plans to stage as many as 15 a day when the Olympics come to town.

A list has been drawn up of possible locations for the festivities — spread around every corner of the city and distant from Olympic venues to avoid overcrowding.

Among the possible viewing party locations: MacArthur Park, the Greek Theatre, Pan Pacific Park, Leimert Park Plaza, Koreatown, Penmar Recreation Center, Echo Park Lake, Angels Gate Park and the Watts Towers.

Given the welter of Olympic events, it will be a challenge to schedule the parties, whose centerpieces are usually big screen projections of the live events, with food and live performances often thrown in.

This article originally appeared in The Times' L.A. on the Record newsletter. To subscribe, go to latimes.com/newsletters.

El Niño brings strange sights to the Southland's coast

[**El Niño**, from B1]

tricky, she said, because animals often don't react to environmental shifts in straightforward ways.

This time, El Niño arrived amid a marine heat wave, which can make it harder to tease out what can be attributed to El Niño alone.

Despite those caveats, El Niño has some common effects.

Whoa, that shark doesn't belong here

The whale shark spotted swimming between Malibu and Santa Barbara Island is indicative of an El Niño hallmark. The warmer waters often invite tropical and subtropical species. Past visitors include different types of tuna that have delighted sport fishers, and open-ocean red crabs that can change the poop color of birds that feast on them. Different types of plankton can also show up.

This year's event might have been responsible for something unprecedented. In September, two olive ridley sea turtles laid eggs miles apart in Seal Beach and Huntington Beach. Those are the first-known sea turtle nests on the country's West Coast, as my colleague Corinne Purtill reported. Since the historic laying, the eggs have been moved to an aquarium in Long Beach for safekeeping.

Anderson said this could very well be the work of El Niño. "Things that are maybe coming up from Mexico may be kind of being pushed or moved around with currents that are pretty strong moving to the north," she explained.

On the West Coast, upwelling typically occurs in the spring and summer when winds push warm sur-

face water offshore, allowing deep, cold, nutrient-rich water to rise to the surface. Food becomes plentiful, making it an ideal time for seals, sea lions, seabirds and dolphins to give birth.

But El Niño can disrupt the winds, dampening upwelling and reducing the food supply.

"Adult animals can usually figure it out," said Dave Bader, chief operations and education officer for the Marine Mammal Care Center in San Pedro. "They can swim further. They can go out to find where the food is. The young animals just don't have that same physiological capacity, perhaps, or just not the long-term knowledge ... so they end up stranding in droves."

Bader worries history could repeat itself: Between 2013 and 2016, during another El Niño and ocean heat wave, thousands of California sea lion pups were found underfed and in distress.

The down-low on domoic acid

In recent weeks, dozens of sea lions suffering from domoic acid poisoning have turned up on beaches from Monterey County to Sonoma County — and some observers fear this is only the beginning. Domoic acid is a toxin produced by algae and typically sickens animals that feed on open-ocean fish.

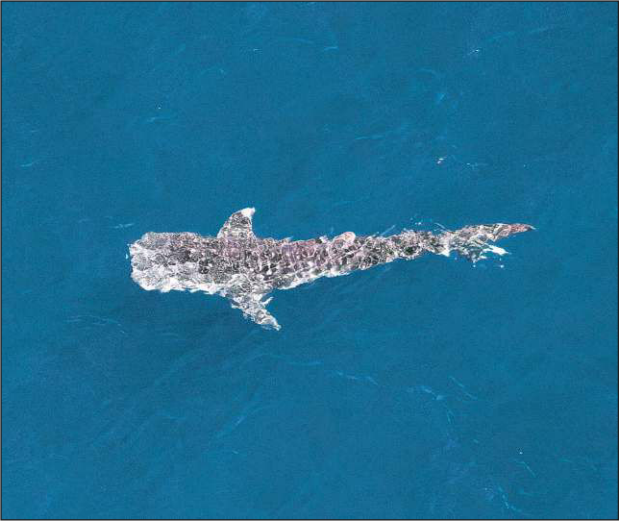
Scripps' Anderson, who studies harmful algal blooms, said such events do appear to be "more connected" to El Niño on the Central and Northern California coastline.

One possibility is that it's due to warmer waters, but it could be more complicated. "We know that the plankton that produce domoic acid



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

ANIMAL RESCUE volunteers wait for a chance to capture an injured sea lion in Malibu in mid-August.



CARL SBAROUNIS

COMMERCIAL fisherman Carl Sbarounis said he spotted this whale shark about 30 miles off the coast.

respond to stress if they don't get enough of the right kind of nutrients," and El Niño and marine heat waves can create that stress, she said.

Giant kelp thrives in cool, nutrient-rich waters, so it's perhaps not surprising that it fares poorly under the opposite conditions. Due to changing storm patterns, the kelp forests are also battered by more damaging winter swells, according to Scripps associate researcher Ed Parnell. When kelp doesn't do well, the animals that depend on it — such as rockfish — similarly suffer.

"I am greatly concerned that with continued ocean warming and the increased

likelihood of severe and possibly more frequent El Niños, much of Southern California's kelp canopy could disappear within my kids' lifetime," Parnell wrote in an online article.

The past is no longer the best teacher because years of sustained warming have changed the landscape, according to Anderson. We might not be able to glean much from, say, the monster El Niño of 1982.

"This is a totally different world and a totally different ecosystem now," she said.

This article originally appeared in The Times' Boiling Point newsletter. To subscribe, visit latimes.com/newsletters.

NFL EXTRA

RAMS 24, PHILADELPHIA 20



CHRIS SZAGOLA Associated Press

KYREN WILLIAMS scores one of his two fourth-quarter touchdowns as the Rams rally to beat a sputtering Eagles team on Sunday, evening their record at 2-2.

‘OUR GUYS FOUND A WAY’



MATT SLOCUM Associated Press

AFTER another slow start, Matthew Stafford and the Rams slid out of Philadelphia with a win.

For once, it’s not a Philly fiasco as Rams avoid past problems there to bounce back with a big victory

By GARY KLEIN

PHILADELPHIA — It’s rarely sunny in Philadelphia for Sean McVay and the Rams.

Before Sunday’s game against the Eagles, McVay was 1-6 against them, 1-4 at Lincoln Financial Field and 0-4 against Eagles coach Nick Sirianni.

The last time the Rams visited here, the Eagles blocked a field-goal attempt and returned it for a touchdown on the final play.

And for much of the game Sunday, gloom once again engulfed McVay and a team that opened the season as a heavy Super Bowl favorite.

But it finally lifted midway through the fourth quarter, with

quarterback Matthew Stafford leading two touchdown drives that gave the Rams a come-from-behind, 24-20 victory.

“A lot of gutsy efforts,” McVay said, “and I have a headache from hell right now.”

No doubt stress-induced. While McVay enjoyed watching Kyren Williams rush for two touchdowns and receiver Puka Nacua rush for another, the Rams had to overcome turnovers, penalties and special-teams miscues to improve to 2-2.

After sitting out two games because of a hip injury, Nacua caught nine passes for 125 yards, several during the final two scoring drives.

“I’m excited to get on this plane and get up out of here,” Nacua said. [See Rams, D3]

SEATTLE 30, CHARGERS 23

Chargers get close, then fumble the game away

Fourth-quarter surge falls short as L.A. drops to 0-4

By SAM FARMER

SEATTLE — In a game that looked lopsided for the better part of three quarters, the Chargers did enough Sunday to scare the defending Super Bowl champions.

Small victory, but at least it was something for the winless Chargers, who scored a touchdown and field goal in the fourth quarter before falling to the Seattle Seahawks, 30-23.

The visitors, who trailed by 21 in the third quarter, were behind by a touchdown when they took over at their 11 with 1:42 remaining. Three plays into that against-all-odds drive, the Seahawks stripped the ball from Justin Herbert, recovered the fumble and ran out the clock.

The Chargers dropped to 0-4, likely crossing the point of no re-



STEPH CHAMBERS Getty Images

JUSTIN HERBERT reacts after a fourth-quarter turnover. For much of the game, he looked lost.

turn. The last time the Chargers started 0-4 was 2017, their first season back in Los Angeles.

Only one team — the 1992 San Diego Chargers — made the playoffs after losing its first four games, and that Bobby Ross-coached squad won 11 of its final 12 games.

These Chargers have 13 games left, and identifying potential wins on the remaining schedule is a nearly impossible task.

Remember the thought that new offensive coordinator Mike McDaniel would unlock all the potential of Herbert? Almost sounds silly now, with the way the team has stumbled and bumbled its way through the first four games.

Previous little rhythm or continuity. Nowhere to go but up.

Sunday was the first time the Chargers finished within a touchdown of their opponent.

For much of the game, Herbert looked lost. His pass was intercepted on the first play from scrimmage and again late in the first half, when his throw landed right in the belly of linebacker Ernest Jones IV.

[See Chargers, D3]

SPORTS ON THE BACK: Dodgers have aces up their sleeve, Mirjam Swanson writes. D8



LATMG
The Next-Generation Media Platform

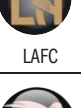
Low minimum.
Early access.

Invest now.



LATMG

PRO CALENDAR

	MON 5	TUE 6	WED 7	THU 8	FRI 9
 DODGERS		at Atlanta* 3 FS1	at Atlanta*^ 3 FS1		ATLANTA*^ 5 Fox
 RAMS	NEXT: OCT. 12 VS. BUFFALO, 5:15 P.M., ESPN				
 CHARGERS	NEXT: SUNDAY VS. DENVER, 1:05 P.M., CBS				
 KINGS		FLORIDA 7 ESPN			
 DUCKS			EDMONTON 7 KCOP, Prime		at Winnipeg 5 KCOP, Prime
 GALAXY	NEXT: SUNDAY AT ST. LOUIS, 4 P.M., APPLE TV				
 LAFC	NEXT: SATURDAY VS. VANCOUVER, 7:30 P.M., APPLE TV				
 ANGEL CITY	NEXT: OCT. 17 AT DENVER, 5:45 P.M., ION				

LAKERS: Today at Sacramento (preseason), 7 p.m., SpecSN, NBA TV
CLIPPERS: Saturday vs. Toronto in Vancouver (preseason), 3:30 p.m.
* NL Division Series ^ if necessary
Shade denotes home games. Times Pacific.

TODAY ON THE AIR

TIME	EVENT	TV; RADIO
BASEBALL: MLB PLAYOFFS		
2 p.m.	ALDS, Game 2, Chicago White Sox at Cleveland	TBS, TruTV, UniMas
5 p.m.	ALDS, Game 2, New York Yankees at Tampa Bay	TBS, TruTV, UniMas
BASKETBALL: NBA PRESEASON		
4 p.m.	Brooklyn at Charlotte	NBA
7 p.m.	Lakers at Golden State	SpecSN, NBA; 710, 980
HOCKEY		
4 p.m.	Philadelphia at Tampa Bay	NHL
PRO FOOTBALL		
5 p.m.	Atlanta at New Orleans	ESPN, ESPND
SOCCER		
9 a.m.	UEFA Nations League, Cyprus vs. Latvia	FS2
11:45 a.m.	UEFA Nations League, Italy vs. Turkey	FS2
11:45 a.m.	UEFA Nations League, Ukraine vs. Hungary	Fox Soccer
2 p.m.	CONCACAF Nations League, Cuba vs. St. Kitts	Fox Soccer
3 p.m.	CONCACAF Nations League, Martinique vs. El Salvador	FS2
5 p.m.	CONCACAF Nations League, Guatemala vs. Suriname	FS2
5 p.m.	CONCACAF Nations League, Bermuda vs. Barbados	Fox Soccer
7 p.m.	CONCACAF Nations League, Honduras vs. Jamaica	FS2, TUDN
TENNIS		
8 p.m.	ATP (Beijing, Tokyo), finals; WTA (Beijing) round of 16	Tennis

Kings still winless as Sharks record another OT win

By JOSH DUBOW

SAN JOSÉ — Igor Chernyshov scored his second goal of the game with 1:42 remaining in overtime, and the San José Sharks beat the Kings 5-4 on Saturday night for their second straight overtime win to open the season.

Adrian Kempe, Quinton Byfield, Erik Hauula and Artemi Panarin scored, but it wasn't enough to keep the Kings from falling to 0-1-1. Anton Forsberg made 20 saves.

The Kings rallied from two goals down in the third to tie the score and controlled play for most of the overtime. But San José came out on top when Chernyshov beat Forsberg on a one-timer off a pass from Macklin Celebrini, who has five assists in two games.

Tyler Toffoli, Kiefer Sherwood and Nolan Allan also scored for San José. Yaroslav Askarov made 31 saves.

Chernyshov gave San José a 4-2 lead early in the third when he scored on a breakaway, but the Kings responded. Hauula scored to make it a one-goal game, and Panarin got the equalizer with 5:01 remaining after a poor clearing attempt by Allan.

The Kings struck first when Kempe scored on a one-timer off a pass from Panarin on the power play in the first. The Sharks took control with three goals in the second, starting when Toffoli tapped in a perfect feed from rookie Ivar Stenberg on the power play.

The Kings got one back with 1.3 seconds left in the period when Byfield scored on the power play.

Dubow writes for the Associated Press.

NHL STANDINGS

Through Saturday

WESTERN CONFERENCE						
Pacific	W	L	OL	Pts	GF	GA
Edmonton	2	0	1	5	17	14
San Jose	2	0	0	4	9	7
Vancouver	2	1	0	4	17	15
DUCKS	1	0	0	2	4	3
Seattle	1	1	0	2	7	4
Vegas	1	1	0	2	8	6
KINGS	0	1	1	1	8	13
Calgary	0	2	0	0	2	10
Central	W	L	OL	Pts	GF	GA
Colorado	2	0	0	4	14	5
Utah	2	0	0	4	10	1
Minnesota	2	0	0	4	7	2
St. Louis	1	1	0	2	5	6
Nashville	1	1	0	2	3	4
Winnipeg	0	0	1	1	3	4
Dallas	0	2	0	0	1	6
Chicago	0	3	0	0	5	15
EASTERN CONFERENCE						
Metropolitan	W	L	OL	Pts	GF	GA
Pittsburgh	2	0	0	4	13	5
NY Rangers	2	1	0	4	7	4
Carolina	1	1	1	3	5	8
NY Islanders	1	1	0	2	7	2
Washington	1	1	0	2	6	5
Columbus	1	1	0	2	7	7
New Jersey	1	1	0	2	3	8
Philadelphia	0	1	2	2	4	13
Atlantic	W	L	OL	Pts	GF	GA
Boston	2	1	0	4	8	7
Montreal	1	0	1	3	8	8
Florida	1	0	1	3	4	4
Ottawa	1	0	0	2	3	2
Buffalo	1	1	0	2	7	9
Tampa Bay	1	1	0	2	4	6
Toronto	1	2	0	2	6	7
Detroit	0	1	0	0	0	2
Note: Overtime or shootout losses are worth one point.						

SATURDAY'S LATE SUMMARY									
SHARKS 5, KINGS 4 (OT)									
KINGS		1	2	2	0	—	4		
San Jose		0	3	1	1	—	5		
FIRST PERIOD: 1. KINGS, Kempe 1 (Clarke, Panarin), 15:50 (pp). Penalties —Doughty/KINGS (Cross Checking), 3:36. Allan, S.J. (Hooking), 14:53. Laferriere, KINGS (Roughing), 20:00.									
SECOND PERIOD: 2. S.J., Toffoli 1 (Stenberg, Celebrini), 1:48 (pp). 3. S.J., Sherwood 1, 9:52. 4. S.J., Allan 1 (Misa, Chernyshov), 12:32. 5. KINGS, Byfield 1 (Zucarella, Kempe), 19:58 (pp). Penalties —Celebrini, S.J. (Slashing), 19:24.									
THIRD PERIOD: 6. S.J., Chernyshov 1 (Trouba, Toffoli), 4:08. 7. KINGS, Hauila 1 (Clarke, Gustafsson), 10:21. 8. KINGS, Panarin 2 (Byfield), 15:00. Penalties —Graf, S.J. (Tripping), 7:42.									
OVERTIME: 9. S.J., Chernyshov 2 (Celebrini), 3:18. Penalties —None.									
SHOTS ON GOAL: KINGS 10-10-15-1-36. S.J. 6-9-8-2-25. Power-play Conversions—KINGS 2 of 3. S.J. 1 of 2.									
GOALIES: KINGS, Forsberg 0-0-1 (25 shots-20 saves). S.J., Askarov 2-0-0 (36-31). Att-17,435 (17,562). T-2:40. R—Michael Markovic, Chris Schlenker. L—Tommy Hughes, Travis Toomey.									



JOHN LOCHER Associated Press

RAIDERS receiver Jalen Nailor can't catch the ball under pressure from Chiefs cornerback Nohl Williams.

NFL ROUNDUP

Chiefs hold off surging Raiders

ASSOCIATED PRESS

Patrick Mahomes remained undefeated at Allegiant Stadium, passing for 225 yards and two touchdowns, and Kenneth Walker III rushed for 177 yards and two scores to lead the Chiefs to a 30-27 win over the Las Vegas Raiders on Sunday.

Walker's two-yard touchdown run with 3:21 left put the Chiefs (4-0) ahead for good at 23-19. It was set up by Tyquan Thornton's 55-yard reception on the previous play. Thornton, who had five catches for 111 yards and two touchdowns, suffered a gruesome-looking left leg injury on the play.

Kirk Cousins passed for 365 yards and two touchdowns for the Raiders in an end to his seven-game win streak that included the final four games last season with Atlanta. Brock Bowers, who played with an illness, caught six passes for 86 yards and a touchdown.

One of the NFL's early season surprises, the Raiders put up a strong fight.

at 49ers 24, Broncos 14: Brock Purdy threw two touchdown passes, and Christian McCaffrey ran for a score to lead undefeated San Francisco over Denver. Both teams struggled to

generate offense on a hot day in the Bay Area, but the 49ers took advantage of a fumbled punt return by Marvin Mims Jr. to set up a short touchdown drive in the third quarter.

at Vikings 15, Dolphins 10: Minnesota stayed undefeated with more dominance by its defense and five field goals from Will Reichard, sidestepping early passing game problems to secure a victory over winless Miami. T.J. Hockenson had a career-high-tying 13 receptions for 119 yards on 13 targets from Kyler Murray.

Colts 30, at Commanders 13: Jonathan Taylor rushed for two touchdowns, and quarterback Daniel Jones ran one in as Indianapolis beat Washington at Tottenham Hotspur Stadium in London. Marcus Mariota, who was starting in place of the injured Jayden Daniels, left the game after Washington's second drive because of a knee injury. Third-string rookie quarterback Athan Kaliakmanis was called into action.

Patriots 29, at Bills 26: Drake Maye threw three touchdown passes, including Efton Chism's one-handed catch with 1:50 remaining, and New England defeated Buffalo. Though Maye com-

mitted two more turnovers to give him nine this season, he rallied the Patriots to the victory with his 23-yard touchdown pass to Chism.

at Bears 23, Jets 12: Kyle Monangai rushed for 146 yards and two touchdowns, helping Chicago earn a third win. Devin Bush, Austin Booker and Dayo Odeyngbo each had a sack as Chicago limited the Jets to seven first downs and 157 yards overall. Minkah Fitzpatrick picked off a pass to end New York's NFL-record interception drought at 20 games.

Jaguars 22, Bengals 17: Trevor Lawrence passed for 227 yards and a touchdown, and Jacksonville's defense forced two critical turnovers during a win over Cincinnati. Joe Burrow passed for 428 yards for the Bengals, who lost All-Pro receiver Ja'Marr Chase to a concussion in the second quarter.

at Giants 36, Cardinals 24: Jameis Winston threw three touchdowns passes to offset a pair of interceptions, Deonte Banks had a pick-six in the final seconds, and New York won another not-so-pretty game, over Arizona. The Cardinals lost their third consecutive game. The NFL is looking into a sequence when line judge Jeff

Seaman was caught on camera cursing at Cardinals tight end Trey McBride. The interaction took place with less than five minutes left after officials did not call a pass interference or illegal contact penalty on the Jets' Dru Phillips, who made contact with McBride before the ball arrived from quarterback Jacoby Brissett.

Packers 17, at Buccaneers 14: Jordan Love threw two touchdown passes, and Green Bay overcame two fourth-quarter turnovers to keep Tampa Bay winless. Undrafted rookie Jalon Daniels threw two picks that led to 10 points in his first start.

at Ravens 24, Titans 18: Lamar Jackson sprained his left ankle when he was sacked at the end of the first half of Baltimore's win. The Ravens didn't score in the second half with Tyler Huntley at quarterback but still dropped Tennessee to 0-4.

Cowboys 34, at Texans 30: CeeDee Lamb had a career-high 17 catches for 189 yards, and his 12-yard touchdown reception with 40 seconds left lifted Dallas past winless Houston. Dallas trailed by four after a six-yard touchdown run by Woody Marks with about 2:30 to play. Dak Prescott then led the scoring drive.

THE DAY IN SPORTS

Sabalenka eliminated at China Open

WIRE REPORTS

Second-ranked **Aryna Sabalenka** was bundled out in the third round of the China Open in straight sets by Czechia's **Nikola Pietrangeli** on Sunday in Beijing.

The No. 34-ranked Pietrangeli defeated the four-time Grand Slam champion 6-4, 6-3 in just over an hour and a half, leaving the tournament without its two top seeds in the first week after world No. 1 **Elena Rybakina** was ousted Saturday.

Sabalenka, who was denied a three-peat at the U.S. Open last month by Rybakina, squandered five break points in the first set as her historic struggles in Beijing continued. The 28-year-old Belorussian has never progressed past the quarterfinals at the event.

Pietrangeli will next play 24-year-old **Sinja Kraus** of Austria, who earlier defeated **Dayana Yastremska** 6-1, 6-4.

Fifth-ranked **Mirra Andreescu** eased into the fourth round with a 6-4, 6-1 victory over **Polina Kudermetova**. This year's French Open winner fired six aces and took five of her seven break point opportunities to overwhelm her Uzbek opponent in just 68 minutes.

In the men's draw, **Novak Djokovic** maintained his perfect record at the tournament with a 4-6, 6-4, 6-4 victory over U.S. Open champion **Alexander Zverev** in the quarterfinals.

Djokovic is bidding to win his seventh China Open title and is 32-0 in Beijing, eclipsing **Rafael Nadal**'s 31-0 start at the French Open for the best start at a tour-level tournament in the Open era.

The Serb started slowly,

dropping his serve in the opening game of the match and eventually losing the first set but bounced back to take the next two to secure the win.

Djokovic will next face **Daniil Medvedev** in the semifinals.

Earlier, **Hubert Hurkacz** beat **Karen Khachanov** 7-6 (2), 6-2 and will face **Alex de Minaur**, who beat **Andrey Rublev** 1-6, 6-2, 6-3, in the other semifinal.

Sullivan makes USMNT history

Cavan Sullivan became the youngest player to score a goal in U.S. men's national team history and fellow teenager **Julian Hall** added another goal and the Americans cruised to a 3-0 victory over Mexico on Saturday night in an international friendly in Glendale, Ariz.

At 17 years, 5 days old, Sullivan scored his stunning goal in the 62nd minute, intercepting a sloppy pass from Mexico goalkeeper

José Rangel and then lofting a long shot over the goalkeeper's head into the net for a 2-0 lead.

"This is what you dream of," Sullivan said. "I've manifested this not just these past couple days, but my whole life. The celebration—every bit of it. This is a special moment for me and my family..."

Adrian Meronk pulled ahead on the mistakes of **Casey Jarvis** to win the Dunhill Links Championship by two shots with a four-under 68 at St. Andrews, giving the 33-year-old from Poland a full card on the European tour. ... **Austin Smotherman** responded with a string of birdies each time someone caught him Saturday in the Utah Championship, making one last birdie on the 18th hole for a six-under 65 and a one-shot lead over **Doug Ghim** going into the final round. ... **Jeenno Thitikul** of Thailand took a three-stroke lead on a windy Saturday in the LOTTE Championship in a bid for her fourth LPGA Tour victory of the season. Thitikul had three straight birdies to

start the back nine in Honolulu en route to a five-under 67.

Max Verstappen took his first victory of an often-frustrating year at the Formula 1 Bahrain Grand Prix in Malaysia as a power unit problem for **George Russell** handed a huge title boost to **Kimi Antonelli**.

Verstappen was leading Antonelli and Russell with five laps to go when Russell suddenly pulled over in his Mercedes. The retirement allowed Antonelli to further stretch his lead over teammate Russell from 66 points to 84.

San Antonio Spurs forward **Tobias Harris** will miss the preseason and is questionable for the start of the regular season after suffering a strained left calf during training camp.

UCLA women's basketball forward **Lena Bilic** will miss the season with a torn anterior cruciate ligament suffered in practice, the team said. Bilic averaged 3.0 points and 1.4 rebounds in 33 games last season.

NWSL STANDINGS

Through Sunday afternoon

	W	L	D	Pts	GF	GA
Gotham FC	16	4	7	55	35	21
San Diego	16	8	3	51	40	28
Washington	14	8	4	46	36	24
Utah Royals FC	14	9	4	46	44	35
Kansas City	13	9	5	44	48	38
ANGEL CITY	12	8	7	43	45	29
Portland	12	8	7	43	45	39
North Carolina	13	11	3	42	50	39
Seattle	12	11	4	40	33	32
Denver Summit FC	9	9	8	35	42	37
Orlando	10	14	3	33	36	43
Houston	8	12	6	30	32	36
Boston Legacy FC	8	14	5	29	36	46
Bay City	7	15	5	26	28	42
Louisville	7	17	3	24	36	52
Chicago	5	19	2	17	15	60

—WIRE REPORTS

NFL STANDINGS

Through Sunday afternoon

NATIONAL CONFERENCE						
West	W	L	T	Pct.	PF	PA
San Francisco	4	0	0	1.000	122	64
Seattle	3	1	0	.750	105	73
RAMS	2	2	0	.500	85	83
Arizona	1	3	0	.250	87	117
North	W	L	T	Pct.	PF	PA
Minnesota	4	0	0	1.000	86	51
Chicago	3	1	0	.750	112	65
Detroit	2	1	0	.667	93	95
Green Bay	2	2	0	.500	73	105
South	W	L	T	Pct.	PF	PA
Carolina	1	2	0	.333	89	83
New Orleans	1	2	0	.333	81	83
Atlanta	1	2	0	.333	51	68
Tampa Bay	0	4	0	.000	76	96
East	W	L	T	Pct.	PF	PA
N.Y. Giants	3	1	0	.750	82	79
Philadelphia	2	2	0	.500	75	93
Dallas	2	2	0	.500	122	112
Washington	1	3	0	.250	88	122

AMERICAN CONFERENCE						
West	W	L	T	Pct.	PF	PA
Kansas City	4	0	0	1.000	118	77
Las Vegas	3	1	0	.750	115	84
Denver	2	2	0	.500	74	94
CHARGERS	0	4	0	.000	67	106
North	W	L	T	Pct.	PF	PA
Cleveland	3	1	0	.750	81	95
Baltimore	3	1	0	.750	116	96
Pittsburgh	2	2	0	.500	77	87
Cincinnati	2	2	0	.500	97	85
South	W	L	T	Pct.	PF	PA
Jacksonville	3	1	0	.750	104	53
Indianapolis	2	2	0	.500	102	104
Tennessee	0	4	0	.000	55	83
Houston	0	4	0	.000	84	109
East	W	L	T	Pct.	PF	PA
Buffalo	3	1	0	.750	127	107
New England	2	2	0	.500	65	77
N.Y. Jets	1	3	0	.250	76	84
Miami	0	4	0	.000	46	101

WEEK 4

SUNDAY'S RESULTS

RAMS 24, Philadelphia 20
Seattle 30, CHARGERS 23
Indianapolis 30, Washington 13
N.Y. Giants 36, Arizona 24
Dallas 34, Houston 30
Green Bay 17, Tampa Bay 14
Jacksonville 22, Cincinnati 17
Chicago 23, N.Y. Jets 12
New England 29, Buffalo 26
Baltimore 24, Tennessee 18
Minnesota 15, Miami 10
San Francisco 24, Denver 14
Kansas City 30, Las Vegas 27
Detroit at Carolina, late

TONIGHT'S GAME

Atlanta at New Orleans, 5:15 p.m.

WEEK 5

THURSDAY'S GAME

Tampa Bay at Dallas, 5:15 p.m.

SUNDAY'S GAMES

Denver at CHARGERS, 1:05 p.m.
Philadelphia vs Jacksonville at London, 6:30 a.m.
Chicago at Green Bay, 10 a.m.
Cincinnati at Miami, 10 a.m.
Cleveland at N.Y. Jets, 10 a.m.
Houston at Tennessee, 10 a.m.
Indianapolis at Pittsburgh, 10 a.m.
Las Vegas at New England, 10 a.m.
Minnesota at New Orleans, 10 a.m.
N.Y. Giants at Washington, 10 a.m.
Detroit at Arizona, 1:25 p.m.
San Francisco at Seattle, 1:25 p.m.
Baltimore at Atlanta, 5:20 p.m.

MONDAY'S GAME

Buffalo at Rams, 5:15 p.m.
Open: Kansas City, Carolina

SEAHAWKS 30, CHARGERS 23

CHARGERS3 3 7 10-23
Seattle7 13 10 0-30

First Quarter

CHARGERS — FG Dicker 40, 11:54.
Sea — Wilson 21 pass from Damold (Myers kick), 9:53.

Second Quarter

Sea — Shaheed 28 run (kick failed), 6:12.
Sea — Wilson 8 run (Myers kick), :43.

CHARGERS — FG Dicker 39, :30.

Third Quarter

Sea — Horton 6 pass from Damold (Myers kick), 10:23.
CHARGERS — Vidal 9 pass from J.Herbert (Dicker kick), 4:53.

Sea — FG Myers 35, 1:19.

Fourth Quarter

CHARGERS — Hampton 2 run (Dicker kick), 7:49.
CHARGERS — FG Dicker 36, 2:14.

TEAM STATISTICS	LAC	SEA
First downs.....	20	19
Total Net Yards.....	301	286
Rushes-yards.....	32-147	33-138
Passing.....	154	148
Punt Returns.....	2-0	2-12
Kickoff Returns.....	5-140	3-83
Interceptions Ret.....	1-4	2-20
Comp-Att-Int.....	19-32-2	13-22-1
Sacked-Yards Lost.....	4-35	3-20
Punts.....	5-44.0	7-42.571
Fumbles-Lost.....	2-2	2-0
Penalties-Yards.....	16-130	14-150
Time of Possession.....	30:59	29:01

INDIVIDUAL LEADERS
RUSHING: CHARGERS, Hampton 9-45, J.Herbert 6-40, Mitchell 10-39, Vidal 5-25, Gadsden 1-2, Johnston 1 (minus 4); SEATTLE, Wilson 21-81, Shaheed 2-33, Holani 7-18, Damold 3-6.
PASSING: CHARGERS, J.Herbert 19-31-2-189, T.Harris 0-1-0-0, SEATTLE, Damold 13-22-1-168.
RECEIVING: CHARGERS, Gadsden 5-36, Mitchell 5-24, T.Harris 3-60, Vidal 2-11, Hampton 2-8, Johnston 1-44, Davis 1-6, SEATTLE, Smith-Nijigba 5-76, Wilson 3-39, Shaheed 1-20, Kupp 1-13, Barber 1-12, Horton 1-6, Holani 1-2.
FIELD GOALS MISSED: None.



MATT SLOCUM Associated Press

PUKA Nacua returned after missing two games and ran for a touchdown, above, and caught nine passes for 125 yards, both season highs.

Rams get over the hump in Philadelphia

[**Rams**, from D1]
“Hopefully, they have some Philly cheesesteaks for us.”

The Rams had mostly had their fill of Philadelphia after losing an NFC divisional game here in 2024 and last year’s debacle that ended with the blocked field goal and touchdown.

“We obviously haven’t found a way to get it done here,” McVay said, “and our guys found a way today.”

The Rams can thank their defense.

The Eagles were without receiver DeVonta Smith and left tackle Lane Johnson, and star running back Saquon Barkley left the game in the first quarter after suffering a hamstring injury.

The Eagles were 0 for 12 on third downs. They converted only one of four fourth downs and managed just 172 yards.

“When it was the time for us to make a play, the defense stepped up,” said edge rusher Byron Young, who had 2 ½ of the Rams’ four sacks, “and we had to do what we do.”

Despite their elation over Sunday’s victory, the Rams have plenty to fix.

Stafford was great down the stretch but otherwise did not look like the reigning NFL most valuable player. He completed 32 of 51 passes for 317 yards with two interceptions.

The Rams, historically one of the league’s least-penalized teams under McVay, had 13 penalties for 91 yards in last Sunday’s 30-26 defeat by the Denver Broncos. On Sunday, they were flagged eight times for 100 yards.

“Any way you could shoot yourself in the foot — we were doing it on the offensive side of the ball,” Stafford said.

Special teams also con-



EMILEE CHINN Getty Images

ALEX Bachman, the Rams’ new return man, dives for extra yards in the first half.

tinued to be a problem. The Rams gave up a long punt return that set up a touchdown, and usually reliable kicker Harrison Mevis missed a 48-yard field-goal attempt.

But the defense kept the Rams within striking distance.

“You’d like to see [us] play as a team where you go and score, and then hold ’em, score and hold ’em and score,” receiver Davante Adams said. “But sometimes that’s not how it plays out.”

“[The defense] did their thing to put us in a position to win it, and we went down there and finished the job.”

The Rams trailed, 20-10, at halftime, as the Eagles turned two interceptions into 10 points, and Jalen Hurts tossed two touchdown passes to receiver Darius Cooper.

After Mevis missed, it got uglier.

Near the end of the third

quarter, it finally looked like the Rams’ defense would be rewarded for a good play: It stopped Hurts on a fourth-down tush push, giving the offense a first down at the Eagles’ 38-yard line.

But Nacua’s penalty for an illegal block stymied the possession, and Stafford’s fourth-down pass for tight end Tyler Higbee fell incomplete.

McVay rallied the offense on the sideline.

“He said, ‘Make things go. Wipe it. Get to the next play,’” Higbee said.

Stafford said McVay was “trying to put some belief” in the team.

“I think we had it,” Stafford said, “but it was great to hear from him.”

The defense came up big again, stopping the Eagles on downs at the Rams’ two-yard line.

On came Stafford, who ranks fourth all time in fourth-quarter comebacks.

“We call it the Mamba period,” said Williams, who rushed for 80 yards in 15 carries and had 10 receptions for 67 yards. “We knew we had to get things done. ... Matthew, man, he got us all together. He said ‘Let’s freakin’ do it’ and we did the dang thing.”

Stafford engineered a nine-play, 98-yard drive that Williams finished with a one-yard touchdown run to cut the deficit to 20-17 with less than four minutes left.

Stafford got the ball back with 2:55 left at the Rams’ 21-yard line. He connected with Nacua three times and Higbee once before Williams scored on a seven-yard run with 1:10 remaining.

The play included Williams’ trademark second and third efforts.

“I wasn’t looking at any defender,” Williams said. “I wasn’t looking at any blocks. I was just having that smell, that nose for the end zone.”

RAMS 24, PHILADELPHIA 20

RAMS3 7 0 14-24
Philadelphia3 17 0 0-20

First Quarter

Philadelphia — FG Elliott 29, 8:38.
RAMS — FG Mevis 40, 2:08.

Second Quarter

Philadelphia — FG Elliott 56, 10:56.
Philadelphia — Cooper 18 pass from Hurts (Elliott kick), 5:44.

RAMS — Nacua 2 run (Mevis kick), 1:55.
Philadelphia — Cooper 10 pass from Hurts (Elliott kick), :03.

Fourth Quarter

RAMS — Williams 1 run (Mevis kick), 3:59.
RAMS — Williams 7 run (Mevis kick), 1:10.

TEAM STATISTICS	LAR	PHI
First downs.....	26	12
Total Net Yards.....	414	172
Rushes-yards.....	25-106	27-104
Passing.....	308	68
Punt Returns.....	4-30	3-59
Kickoff Returns.....	4-89	3-65
Interceptions Ret.....	0-0	2-46
Comp-Att-Int.....	32-51-2	12-27-0
Sacked-Yards Lost.....	1-8	4-25
Punts.....	4-49.75	6-48.833
Fumbles-Lost.....	0-0	2-0
Penalties-Yards.....	8-100	10-58
Time of Possession.....	32:00	28:00

INDIVIDUAL LEADERS
RUSHING: RAMS, Williams 16-80, Corum 5-14, Stafford 3-10, Nacua 1-2, PHILADELPHIA, Bigsby 14-55, Shipley 6-23, Hurts 5-18, Barkley 2-8.
PASSING: RAMS, Stafford 32-51-2-316, PHILADELPHIA, Hurts 12-27-0-93.
RECEIVING: RAMS, Williams 10-66, Nacua 9-125, Higbee 5-67, Adams 4-32, Atwell 1-8, Corum 1-7, Mumphfield 1-7, Whittington 1-4, PHILADELPHIA, Cooper 3-33, Lemon 3-27, Wicks 3-18, Fritz 2-13, Barkley 1-2.
FIELD GOALS MISSED: RAMS, Mevis 48.

Next up: Josh Allen and the 3-1 Buffalo Bills, a 29-26 loser Sunday against the New England Patriots.

The Rams will go into the game a .500 team riding the high of a comeback victory rather than trying to get out of a 1-3 hole.

At some point, the Rams will welcome back edge rusher Myles Garrett, defensive lineman Aaron Donald, who sat out because of a sore back, and tight end Terrence Ferguson, who like Garrett is an injured reserve. They are still more than capable of becoming the team that was hyped throughout the offseason.

So Sunday’s victory — rather than another loss in Philadelphia — could pay dividends.

“Hopefully,” Stafford said, “it was really important come later in the year.”

Winless Chargers’ fourth-quarter comeback falls short

[**Chargers**, from D1]

Injuries didn’t help. All-Pro safety Derwin James Jr. was deactivated by the Chargers because of a hamstring injury, and the team subsequently lost No. 1 receiver Ladd McConkey (foot) and right tackle Joe Alt (neck) for the second half. In the fourth quarter, left tackle Rashawn Slater lay for several moments on the turf and was examined by medical staff before rising to his feet and walking gingerly to the sideline with an ankle injury.

Herbert took a beating. He was sacked four times, and the Seahawks were flagged twice for roughing the passer. He had three turnovers. His toughness was not in question, though, not after some of those crushing hits.

At least last season the Chargers could point to a specific positional breakdown. Their offensive line was a disaster. This year, nothing is working well — although the defense did turn in a gem for three quarters in the Week 3 loss at Buffalo, including five takeaways.

It has been a disastrous and unfamiliar start for Chargers coach Jim Harbaugh, who before this season had never lost his first two games, either in college



LINDSEY WASSON Associated Press

CHARGERS running back Kimani Vidal (28) scores a touchdown in the second half of L.A.’s 30-23 defeat.

or the pros.

As unpleasant as his job might be at the moment, Harbaugh is ostensibly safe. He’s signed for two more

seasons, and the Chargers would owe him more than \$30 million were they to part ways with him. Cutting loose McDaniel would be expen-

sive, too, and there’s no clear successor waiting in the wings.

There’s little respite to be found in the Chargers’ up-

coming games. They play host to Denver next Sunday, then are at Kansas City, and play the Rams after a week off. Then, the Chargers have

a home game against Houston — also surprisingly winless — then play at Baltimore, where the 3-1 Ravens are coached by former Chargers defensive coordinator Jesse Minter.

The Seahawks, defending Super Bowl champions, got a collective whiff of smelling salts before Sunday’s game, having suffered an embarrassing loss at Washington a week earlier. They weren’t about to lose back-to-back games for the first time since 2024.

They were far from perfect, however. After the Seahawks picked off Herbert on the first play from scrimmage, the Chargers returned the favor on Seattle’s first play, intercepting a Sam Damold pass. That set up a field goal drive and a fleeting 3-0 lead by the visitors.

According to Elias Sports Bureau, the Chargers-Seahawks game marked the first since 1978 — as far back as the stats go — that began with consecutive interceptions.

The advantage didn’t last long. The Seahawks pulled away as the second half wore on, scoring three unanswered touchdowns and tearing through the heart of the Chargers’ defense, sometimes scarcely touched.

MLB REPORT

Chourio's heroics give Brewers a 2-0 lead

WIRE REPORTS

Jackson Chourio hit a two-run single off hard-throwing **Mason Miller** with two outs in the ninth inning, and the Milwaukee Brewers rallied past the San Diego Padres for the second time in 20 hours, a 4-3 victory Sunday for a 2-0 lead in the National League Division Series.

Miller entered with a 3-2 lead, trying for his first six-out save since 2024. He retired the side in order in the eighth, but after a leadoff groundout in the ninth, he issued his first career postseason walk to **Christian Yelich** and **Sal Frelick**.

Andrew Vaughn flied out, and pinch-hitter **Gary Sánchez** walked on a full count.

A night after sparking Milwaukee's comeback with a tying, two-run homer in the third inning, Chourio lined a 101.3-mph fastball up the middle and past second baseman **Jake Cronenworth**'s attempt for a diving, backhand stop. The ball bounced into center field as Yelich ran across the plate. Frelick slid in headfirst, easily beating center fielder **Jackson Merrill**'s throw.

San Diego, which entered the postseason with 20 wins in its last 23 games, has back-to-back losses for the first time since Sept. 1-2. The Padres will try to keep their season alive Tuesday in San Diego.

Brewers take opener after strange play

William Contreras hit a tiebreaking homer in the seventh inning, and the Brewers hung on to beat San Diego 3-2 in their opener Saturday night, after a potential



KAYLA WOLF Associated Press

JACKSON CHOURIO is doused by Brewers teammates after his walk-off single in the ninth.

go-ahead homer by the Padres' **Ty France** hit the American Family Field roof and landed in Chourio's glove for an out.

San Diego had a runner on first with one out in the ninth inning when France hit a towering fly ball that struck a cable on the roof before Chourio caught it in fair territory on the warning track in left.

Under the stadium's ground rules, any batted ball striking the roof or one of its cables in fair territory is a fair ball that can be caught for an out, so Chourio's catch retired France. The Padres unsuccessfully

challenged that France's drive was a foul ball.

"We joked about it at the umpire meeting today about what would happen if the ball hit the roof. And it was unlikely, but it happened," San Diego manager **Craig Stammen** said. "Unfortunately, a bad break for us. Looked like it was a possible home run. Just didn't go our way."

France's drive left his bat at 105.3 mph with a 49-degree launch angle. It was caught 325 feet from home plate.

Milwaukee manager **Pat Mur-**

phy thought the ball would have hooked foul if it didn't ricochet off the roof.

"It was going to be a foul ball, for sure. I'm standing right on that line," Murphy said. "A hitter that talented, they would have liked to have that hitter back up there with another strike."

Merrill then lined out to right to end the game.

Brewers ace **Jacob deGrom**'s first playoff start lasted just four innings because the Padres continually fouled off his pitches.

The Brewers still won after five relievers combined to pitch five scoreless innings — with the assist from the American Family Field roof.

Rasmussen's no-hit bid leads Rays past Yankees

Drew Rasmussen walked into the interview room while Tampa Bay Rays manager **Kevin Cash** was showering him with praise.

"That's the nicest you've ever been about me," Rasmussen said after greeting Cash.

The powerful right-hander deserved all the superlatives.

Rasmussen didn't give up a hit until there were two outs in the eighth inning. **Jonathan Aranda** homered off **Gerrit Cole**, and the Rays beat the visiting New York Yankees 1-0 in their American League Division Series opener Saturday night.

"He was dominant before the break," Cash said about Rasmussen. "He's elite all season long. He's really done that since he's been a Tampa Bay Ray, coming over here, and his contributions. Feels like he continues to get better."

Rasmussen retired 15 consecutive batters before **Austin Wells** doubled with two outs in the eighth, ripping a line drive just inside the right-field line on an inside sinker.

Wells tried for a triple but was easily thrown out on a relay from right fielder **Victor Mesa Jr.** to shortstop **Taylor Walls** to third baseman **Junior Caminero**. Wells ran through a stop sign from third base coach **Luis Rojas**, who raised both arms before Wells rounded second.



Photographs by ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

PITCHER Tarik Skubal gave up just one run and two hits, walked two and struck out seven Saturday in the Dodgers' 5-3 win over the Braves in Game 1 of the NLDS.

Dodgers' eyes on even bigger prize than Braves

[**Swanson**, from D8] would line him up to potentially pitch Game 2 in the NLCS and, if necessary, Game 6 against the Milwaukee Brewers or San Diego Padres. (Or, if you really want to plan ahead — and the Dodgers with their leaky bullpen absolutely should not — for Game 1 of the World Series.)

"That just sets up the rotation and Yamamoto better looking forward," manager Dave Roberts explained before Saturday's game.

"Not discounting this series, because you've got to win this series first, but you start from the fact that they're all going to pitch — the three [Skubal, Snell and Yamamoto] are going to pitch for sure ... and then what sets them up going forward."

It feels like a faux pas, to be that forward-thinking, and to be saying the quiet part out loud!

"If you can kind of line it up in such a way to give guys ample rest, it puts you in a better position for more options down the road," Roberts said. "That's kind of some of the math we had."

It adds up. And for these Dodgers — whose fourth starter, Tyler Glasnow, was a key cog in last year's World Series-winning rotation — it's a fair assessment.

Though it's nice of Roberts to pay enough lip service that he's not totally discounting the best-of-five series they're in.

Predictably on Saturday,



TYLER GLASNOW, hiding from the heat Saturday, is the Dodgers' fourth starting pitcher, after Skubal, Blake Snell and Yoshinobu Yamamoto, their top ace whom they are saving for Game 3.

Skubal, who previously had a 2.04 ERA, a 0.73 WHIP and 56 strikeouts in 39⅓ playoff innings for the Detroit Tigers, brought his own October heat.

The 29-year-old from Kingman,

Ariz., gave up just one run and two hits, walked two and struck out seven — giving him 64 in the postseason, the second most in his first seven postseason appearances behind only Bob Gibson (74), per

MLB's Sarah Langs.

Skubal retired 15 consecutive batters, hit 101 on the radar gun in the second inning and didn't have a three-ball count until the fifth inning.

"We knew," Braves manager Walt Weiss said, "it was going to be a rough ride."

But Weiss did not know, immediately after Saturday's loss, when he'd be able to deploy his sole ace, 37-year-old Chris Sale, the 10-time All-Star who just pitched in the Braves' wild-card closeout game.

"To me it's not that big a deal when he pitches," Weiss said. "The Dodgers can't win it in two."

A true statement and a matter of fact: The Dodgers can't win in two, but they're not shy about expecting to win.

"It's prudent to kind of map out potentially how they could line up," Roberts said Friday. "And that's just doing your due diligence."

"We are very fortunate because we have four guys essentially that you could really kind of pick through to figure out what's the best way to deploy all four starters, that's the exercise. But it starts with having four talented guys."

Andrew Friedman, the Dodgers' president of baseball operations, revealed in the notion that his club actually might be disproving the rule that you can never have enough pitching — at least when it comes to their elite quartet of starters.

And that, Friedman said, "is very impactful for quality of life."

And the Dodgers aren't afraid to say it.

‘I’ve been coming to games my whole life, and this is easily the hottest game I’ve ever been to.’

— NICOLAS GONZALEZ, 38, of Culver City



Photographs by GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

A FAN TRIES to keep cool in the triple-digit temperatures during Game 1 of the NLDS between the Dodgers and the Braves. Some of the seats were too hot to sit in.

‘Feels like we’re flying too close to the sun’

Whew! Fans and players endure one of the hottest days ever (103 degrees) at Dodger Stadium.

BY KEVIN BAXTER

It was so hot at Dodger Stadium on Saturday ...

How hot was it?

It was so hot that a team that averaged nearly 50,000 fans for occasionally meaningless regular-season games beat the Atlanta Braves 5-3 in its first postseason game before thousands of empty seats — some of which were literally too hot to sit in.

It was so hot that the Dodgers set up pallets of bottled water near the gates and anyone brave enough to enter the stadium was given a plastic 16-ounce Dasini bottle. Gatorade also set up a cooling tent under the right-field pavilion.

It was so hot that Nicolas Gonzalez, a fan sitting in the shade of the reserved level, saw a stadium attendant, overcome by heat, stretched out before the game had even started.

She wasn't the only one. By the later innings, other fans on the reserved level were reportedly seek-

ing medical attention on the concourse.

The Dodgers declined to comment.

So how hot was it?

The game started 45 minutes after the National Weather Service issued an extreme heat warning, cautioning against “extremely dangerous heat conditions” as the temperature reached 100 degrees at first pitch. By the third inning, the temperature reading atop the left-field scoreboard peaked at 103 degrees, matching the highest first-pitch temperature at 64-year-old Dodger Stadium.

“I’ve been coming to games my whole life, and this is easily the hottest game I’ve ever been to,” said Gonzalez, 38, of Culver City. “Having a game in these conditions feels like we’re flying too close to the sun, both literally and figuratively.”

Around him, fans tried to cool themselves by waving makeshift fans. It didn't work.

But the weather affected not only how the game was watched, but how it was played too. The cloudless skies made every pop-up an adventure and the warm, dense air reduced drag, allowing batted balls to travel farther. As a result, the teams combined for five homers, accounting for all eight runs.

“That’s probably one of the hottest games that we’ve ever had here. And so shout-out to the Dodger fans; they were amazing,” said Max Muncy, who hit one of those five homers.

“My feet were hot. *Really* hot.”

The Dodgers wound up with an early afternoon game in the middle of a historic heat wave because MLB and the TV networks — in this case Fox and TBS — set conditional start times for the four Division Series games before the teams and matchups were known. When the San Diego Padres eliminated the Chicago Cubs in the wild-card round, Saturday’s early NL game went to the Dodgers.

Left-hander Tarik Skubal, who gave up just a run on two hits in six innings to get the win in his Dodger postseason debut, said he didn't really notice the heat until he came out of the game.

“I walked back into the dugout, and I asked — I forget who, I think it was [Blake] Snell — I was like, ‘Has it been this hot all game?’ It’s amazing what your brain can do in certain circumstances and moments,” he said.

“I actually didn't think it was horrible when I was pitching.”

But then Skubal pitched in much hotter conditions as a kid growing up in northern Arizo-

na.

“I played a Little League game in 127 [degrees]. Lake Havasu,” he said. “[Saturday’s] up there with as hot a baseball game that you can play in.

“Every team’s playing in it, right? They’re playing in the same conditions we are. It shouldn't really impact how you are mentally or how it’s going to impact how you pitch. Just go out there and play baseball and try to drink water. That’s really it.”

At least Skubal got to drink his water in the relative cool of the dugout between innings. Umpire Roberto Ortiz, wearing 10 pounds of protective gear and a black-and-gray uniform, got no such relief. He had to stand behind the plate for 2 hours, 44 minutes and all 290

pitches, one of which smoked him in the seventh inning.

That’s why his five fellow umpires made a point of patting him on the back or shoulder before jogging to their positions for the first pitch.

“He stayed tough,” Dodgers catcher Will Smith said of Ortiz. “I’m sure he’ll rehydrate and be ready for tomorrow.”

Speaking of Sunday, the Dodgers, Braves and the umpires will all get some relief for Game 2. At first pitch Sunday afternoon the Weather Channel forecasted a temperature of just 97 degrees.

“The dark silver lining,” Gonzalez, the heat-weary fan said in a nod to global warming, “is this might be the coolest October of the rest of our lives.”



FANS WAVING fans were a common sight. The weather affected not only the way the game was watched, but how it was played too. The cloudless skies made every pop-up an adventure.

MLB PLAYOFFS DIVISION SERIES

NATIONAL LEAGUE

Best-of-five series

DODGERS vs. Atlanta

Dodgers lead, 1-0

Game 1: Dodgers 5, Atlanta 3

Game 2: Sunday at Dodgers, late

Game 3: Tuesday at Atlanta, 3 p.m.

Game 4: Wednesday at Atlanta, 3 p.m.*

Game 5: Friday at Dodgers, 5 p.m.*

TV: Games 2-4 on FS1, Game 5 on Fox

Milwaukee vs. San Diego

Brewers lead, 2-0

Game 1: Milwaukee 3, San Diego 2

Game 2: Milwaukee 4, San Diego 3

Game 3: Tuesday at San Diego, 6:30 p.m.

Game 4: Wed. at San Diego, 7 p.m.*

Game 5: Friday at Milwaukee, 1:30 p.m.*

TV: FS1

AMERICAN LEAGUE

Best-of-five series

Chicago White Sox at Cleveland

White Sox lead, 1-0

Game 1: Chicago 3, Cleveland 0

Game 2: Today at Cleveland, 2 p.m.

Game 3: Wednesday at Chicago, 1 p.m.

Game 4: Thursday at Chicago, 2 p.m.*

Game 5: Saturday at Cleveland, 2 p.m.*

TV: TBS/HBO Max

Tampa Bay vs. New York

Rays lead, 1-0

Game 1: Tampa Bay 1, New York 0

Game 2: Today at Tampa Bay, 5 p.m.

Game 3: Wednesday at New York, 5 p.m.

Game 4: Thursday at New York, 5 p.m.*

Game 5: Saturday at Tampa Bay, 5 p.m.*

TV: TBS, HBO Max

*-if necessary

Times p.m. PDT unless noted



CLIFF WELCH Icon Sportswire

THE RAYS' Drew Rasmussen took a no-hitter into the eighth inning on Saturday.

SATURDAY'S NLCS GAME 1 MILWAUKEE 3, SAN DIEGO 2												
San Diego	AB	R	H	BI	Avg.	Milwaukee	AB	R	H	BI	Avg.	
Tatis rf 2b	5	0	1	0	.200	Chourio lf	4	1	1	2	.250	
Harris lf	4	0	2	0	.500	Turang 2b	3	0	0	0	.000	
Machado 3b	4	0	2	0	.500	Contreras c	3	1	1	1	.333	
France 1b	4	0	1	0	.250	Baers 1b	3	0	2	0	.667	
Merrill cf	5	0	0	0	.000	Yelich dh	3	0	1	0	.333	
Bogaerts ss	3	1	1	0	.333	a-Vaughn dh	1	0	1	0	1.000	
Salas c	3	1	1	0	.333	Pratt ss	4	0	0	0	.000	
b-Andujar	1	0	0	0	.000	Lara rf	3	0	0	0	.000	
1-Taylor rf	0	0	0	0	---	Mitchell cf	3	1	1	0	.333	
Campanuso dh	3	0	1	1	.333	Ortiz 3b	4	0	0	0	.000	
2-Bowen dh	0	0	0	0	---	Totals	31	3	7	3		
Cronenworth 2b	3	0	0	0	.000							
c-Hays	1	0	0	0	.000							
Fermin c	0	0	0	0	---							
Totals	36	2	9	2								
San Diego					.020	000	000	-2	9	1		
Milwaukee					.002	000	000	10x	-3	7	0	
a-singled for Yelich in the 7th. b-pinch hit for Salas in the 8th. c-flied out for Cronenworth in the 8th.												
Walks—San Diego 4: Harris 1, Machado 1, Bogaerts 1, Campanuso 1. Milwaukee 4: Turang 1, Contreras 1, Lara 1, Mitchell 1.												
Strikeouts—San Diego 9: Tatis 2, Machado 1, France 1, Merrill 2, Salas 1, Cronenworth 2. Milwaukee 6: Turang 1, Pratt 2, Mitchell 1, Ortiz 2.												
E—Rodriguez (1).												
LOB—San Diego 12. Milwaukee 9. 2B—Machado (1). HR—Chourio (1), off Ray; Contreras (1), off Morjono. RBIs—Campanuso (1), Cronenworth (1), Chourio 2 (2), Contreras (1), SB—Turang (1), Mitchell (1), CS—Harris (1).												
Runners left in scoring position—San Diego 8 (France, Machado 2, Merrill 4, Tatis); Milwaukee 5 (Chourio, Ortiz, Pratt 3). RISP—San Diego 1 for 9; Milwaukee 2 for 9. Runners moved up—Tatis, Hays, Ortiz.												
GDP—Campanuso. DP—Milwaukee 1 (Pratt, Turang, Baers).												
San Diego	IP	H	R	ER	BB	SO	NP	ERA				
Ray	2	2	2	2	1	45	6.75					
Rodriguez	1	0	0	0	1	2	19	0.00				
Matsu	1	0	0	0	1	1	15	0.00				
Adam	1	0	0	0	1	0	16	0.00				
Morjono, L, 0-1	2	3	1	1	0	2	31	4.50				
Milwaukee	IP	H	R	ER	BB	SO	NP	ERA				
Misiorowski	4	2	2	1	6	88	4.50					
Senzatela	2	0	0	0	1	11	0.00					
Ashby	1	0	0	0	1	23	0.00					
Unibe	2	0	0	0	0	16	0.00					
Hall, W, 1-0	1	0	0	0	2	20	0.00					
Megill, S, 1-1	1	0	0	0	2	17	0.00					
Inherited runners scored—Rodriguez 3-0, Ashby 2-0, Hall 3-0, Megill 2-0.												
WP—Misiorowski (Bauers), Unibe (France).												
HBP—Matsuoka, Ashby.												
ABS Challenge—Misiorowski (Ball-Confirmed); Misiorowski (Ball-Overturned to Strike); Senzatela (Ball-Overturned to Strike); Ashby (Ball-Overturned to Strike); Hall (Ball-Confirmed).												
U—Nick Mahoney, Lance Barrett, Alfonso Marquez, Nic Lentz												
T—3:28. Tickets sold—42,843 (41,700).												

SATURDAY'S ALDS GAME 1 TAMPA BAY 1, N.Y. YANKEES 0

New York	AB	R	H	BI	Avg.	Tampa Bay	AB	R	H	BI	Avg.
Rice dh	3	0	0	0	.000	Diaz dh	4	0	1	0	.250
Bellinger lf	4	0	0	0	.000	Acosta 1b	4	1	1	1	.250
Garcia 1b	3	0	0	0	.000	Campanero 3b	2	0	0	0	.000
Jones rf	3	0	0	0	.000	1-Mateo	0	0	0	---	
Lombard ss	3	0	0	0	.000	Williamson 3b	0	0	0	---	
Chisholm 2b	2	0	0	0	.000	Hicks c	3	0	1	0	.333
Grisham cf	3	0	0	0	.000	Simpson lf	4	0	0	0	.000
A-Wells c	3	0	1	0	.333	Mesa rf	3	0	1	0	.333
McMahon 3b	2	0	0	0	.000	DeLuca cf	3	0	0	0	.000
a-Stanton	1	0	0	0	.000	Palacios 2b	3	0	1	0	.333
Totals	27	0	1	0		Walls ss	3	0	0	0	.000
						Totals	29	1	5	1	
New York					.000	000	000	000	-0	1	0
Tampa Bay					.001	000	000	00x	-1	5	0

a-pinch hit for McMahon in the 9th. 1-ran for Campanero in the 8th.

Walks—New York 2: Rice 1, Chisholm 1. Tampa Bay 3: Campanero 2, Hicks 1.

Strikeouts—New York 12: Rice 2, Bellinger 2, Jones 2, Lombard 1, Chisholm 1, Grisham 2, A-Wells 1. Tampa Bay 5: Campanero 1, Simpson 1, Mesa 1, DeLuca 1, Walls 1. **LOB**—New York 2, Tampa Bay 7. **2B**—A-Wells (1), Palacios (1), Hicks (1). **HR**—Acosta (1), off Cole. **RBIs**—Acosta (1). **SB**—Chisholm (1).

Runners left in scoring position—New York 1 (Grisham). Tampa Bay 4 (Simpson 3, Walls). **RISP**—New York 0 for 1; Tampa Bay 0 for 5.

New York

IP	H	R	ER	BB	SO	NP	ERA
Cole, L, 0-1	5	1	1	1	5	82	1.80
Weathers	1	0	0	0	0	9	0.00
Blackburn	1	0	0	0	1	25	0.00
Headrick	1	0	0	1	0	12	0.00

Tampa Bay

IP	H	R	ER	BB	SO	NP	ERA
Rasmussen, W, 1-0	8	1	0	2	10	101	0.00
Baker, S, 1-1	1	0	0	0	2	14	0.00

Inherited runners scored—Headrick 1-0. **U**—Shane Livingsgarer, Jeremie Rehak, Dan Bellino, Ben May T-2:30. **Tickets sold**—40,542 (25,025).

WNBA REPORT

Golden State on top after Game 1

WIRE REPORTS

Gabby Williams had 25 points, 11 rebounds and five assists and **Kiah Stokes** added 14 rebounds and three blocked shots as the Golden State Valkyries took Game 1 of the WNBA semifinals by beating the defending champion Las Vegas Aces 71-60 on Sunday.

A’ja Wilson scored 24 points while **Chelsea Gray** contributed 16 points for Las Vegas, which lost guard **Jewell Loyd** to a left leg injury early in the third quarter. The team said she was being evaluated.

Golden State coach **Natalie Nakase** was well enough to coach after she went down on the sideline near Golden State’s bench Friday night in a 77-73 comeback win to clinch the first-round series against Dallas. She was examined by a doctor during the day off Saturday.

It was a defensive, low-scoring game in which neither team shot particularly well — the Valkyries 37.7% to 33.9% for Las Vegas.

Janelle Salaun received a rousing ovation when she entered the game for the Valkyries with 2:25 left in the first quarter after being named WNBA sixth player of the year before the game.

Las Vegas forward **Stephanie Talbot** missed the game because of a left leg injury.

Defense carries Dream over Liberty

Jordin Canada scored 20 of her 25 points in the second half and had five steals to help the Atlanta Dream beat the New York Liberty 92-82 in the opener of their semifinal series.

DeWanna Bonner added 23 points and helped fill the void when **Allisha Gray** went down with a left hand injury in the second quarter. Atlanta once again played stellar defense, scoring 32 points off 21 forced turnovers, including 16 in a dominant third quarter. The 32 points off turnovers tied an all-time WNBA playoff record.

“Everybody stepped up, and that’s what we need,” Canada said. “Next-man up mentality. I just tried to do what I do best.”

Gray’s injury was the key moment of an even first half. Neither team led by more than six points in a half that had 14 lead changes. New York went into the locker room with a slim 40-37 advantage. But Atlanta outscored New York 32-15 in the third quarter, seizing control with relentless defensive pressure.

The win marked Atlanta’s first victory in the semifinal round since 2018, and left it as the only undefeated team remaining in the postseason. The Dream are also on an eight-game winning streak dating back to the regular season.



COLIN HUBBARD Associated Press

THE DREAM’S Rhyné Howard, left, faces the Liberty’s Pauline Astier. WNBA PLAYOFFS

SEMIFINALS

Best-of-five series

4 Atlanta vs. 8 New York
Dream lead, 1-0

Gm 1	Atlanta 92, New York 82
Gm 2	Wed. at Atlanta, 4:30, ESPN
Gm 3	Fri. at New York, 4:30, ESPN2
Gm 4	Sunday at New York, TBD, ABC*
Gm 5	Oct. 14 at Atlanta, TBD, ESPN*

3 Las Vegas vs. 2 Golden State
Valkyries lead, 1-0

Gm 1	Golden State 71, Las Vegas 60
Gm 2	Wed. at Gold. St., 6:30, NBCSN
Gm 3	Fri. at Las Vegas, 6:30, NBCSN
Gm 4	Sunday at L.V., TBD, NBC*
Gm 5	Oct. 14 at Golden State, TBD, NBCSN*

* if necessary
All times PDT, p.m. except noted



Photographs by RONALDO BOLAÑOS Los Angeles Times

DEFENSIVE TACKLE Jahkeem Stewart dives to finish his 48-yard fumble return. He later joked that he reached 22 mph on the scamper.

Riley and Trojans get bounce-back win

[USC, from D8] mistake, one missed opportunity, one penalty after another brought them to this point, despite the fact that the Huskies actually struggled to move the ball against USC’s defense.

For most of Saturday, it looked like that unit took a step forward after the previous two weeks, when both Rutgers and Oregon marched on the Trojans. Through one half, USC held Washington to 44 passing yards. Through three quarters, Washington was averaging fewer than six yards per play.

“The bounce back was huge for us,” freshman defensive end Luke Wafle said.

USC’s defense nearly came apart in the fourth quarter, though, at the worst possible time. Washington hadn’t converted a third down until its final drive, when Williams converted a third-and-11 pass, then hit a fourth-and-two bomb for 43 yards. The Huskies got as close as the USC 12-yard line before the Trojans finally shut the door.

“We had to dig deep for this one,” Riley said. “Especially as sloppy as we played.”

USC (5-1, 2-1) did try something a little different on defense, with coordinator Gary Patterson calling the game from the press box instead of the sideline. Riley said the decision was akin to “trying to just move the chess pieces to get everyone in the right position.” He also added that Patterson’s former staff at Texas Christian had a lot more familiarity with his scheme, and thus he handled things differently with that staff.

But the communication issues of past weeks appeared less of a problem on defense. The real concerns came on offense, where the Trojans uncharacteristically sputtered. Jayden Maiava was 21 for 34 for 245 yards with a touchdown and an interception.

Judging by the box score alone, you’d be hard-pressed



LUKE WAFLE closes in on Washington quarterback Demond Williams Jr., who was sacked five times as the Trojans’ defense held despite struggling late.

to understand how USC could nearly have squandered a game in which it piled up more yards (360 to 319) and had the ball for far longer (34:58 to 25:02) and dominated on third down.

“We’re gonna fix it,” Stewart said. “No team comes out perfect. It takes time.”

After a disappointing few weeks on the defensive end, USC actually opened the game by forcing Washington (3-2, 0-2) into back-to-back three-and-outs.

But the Trojans managed a measly three points from those stops. Their first drive stalled in the red zone. The next one started from the one-yard line after wide-out Terrell Anderson muffed a punt.

Washington took advantage of the field position on its next drive. Faced with fourth and seven in USC territory, Williams slipped past pressure and scampered to a first down. It was the first

sign of life from the Huskies’ offense, which found the end zone on a trick play four plays later.

Then, USC gave the ball right back. On the run, Maiava launched a pass off his back foot under heavy pressure. It fell well short of its target and was picked off.

USC’s defense held strong, forcing a third three-and-out in the Huskies’ first four drives. And its offense finally held up its end of the bargain, with Waymond Jordan punching in an eight-yard touchdown.

Washington continued to struggle moving the ball, but mistakes from USC helped its cause. An illegal formation penalty wiped away a deep Trojans touchdown pass to Kayden Dixon-Wyatt. Then on the ensuing possession, Wafle grabbed Williams’ face mask as he pulled him down for a sack.

USC had more penalty yards (50) than Washington

had passing yards (44) in the first half. And those penalties gave the Huskies life at the end of the half, as they drove the length of the field and scored again on a one-yard run.

“We felt like we were out-playing them,” Riley said. “We just couldn’t get out of our own way a little bit. That’s probably going to be a defining thing for this team going forward, how much we can do that.”

With a chance to regroup, the Trojans tripped over themselves coming out of halftime too. An unsportsmanlike penalty killed their opening drive. Then, Washington tight end Decker DeGraaf caught a pass and took off down the sideline, the former Glendora High standout running through two feeble-arm tackles on the way to an inexplicable 42-yard touchdown.

After that, the chants to fire Riley rang out from the

SATURDAY’S LATE SUMMARY				
NO. 18 USC 25, WASHINGTON 21				
Washington	7	7	7	0-21
USC	3	7	12	3-25
First Quarter				
USC—FG Chittenden 26, 8:35.				
WASH—Naone 5 pass from Roebuck (Robles kick), 1:46.				
Second Quarter				
USC—Jordan 8 run (Chittenden kick), 9:58.				
WASH—Eldridge 1 run (Robles kick), 1:50.				
Third Quarter				
WASH—DeGraaf 42 pass from D.Williams (Robles kick), 13:30.				
USC—Hines 10 pass from Maiava (run failed), 6:30.				
USC—Stewart 48 fumble return (run failed), 4:40.				
Fourth Quarter				
USC—FG Chittenden 39, 9:36.				
Attendance—59,136.				
STATISTICS				
TEAM	WASH	USC		
First downs	15	21		
Total Net Yards	319	360		
Rushes-yards	33-116	35-115		
Passing	203	245		
Punt Returns	2-18	4-25		
Kickoff Returns	1-25	0-0		
Interceptions Ret.	1-0	0-0		
Comp-Att-Int.	16-27-0	21-34-1		
Sacked-Yards Lost	5-18	1-9		
Punts	6-51.667	5-49.8		
Fumbles-Lost	1-1	1-0		
Penalties-Yards	10-74	9-84		
Time of Possession	25:02	34:58		
Individual Leaders				
RUSHING: Washington, Bonner 19-89, D.Williams 13-26, Eldridge 1-1. USC Ki.Miller 18-81, Jordan 11-36, Alston 1-8, (Team) 1-(minus 2), Maiava 3-(minus 3), Dixon-Wyatt 1-(minus 5).				
PASSING: Washington, D.Williams 15-26-0-198, Roebuck 1-1-0-5. USC, Maiava 21-34-1-245.				
RECEIVING: Washington, Lawson 5-82, Roebuck 5-30, Naone 3-40, DeGraaf 2-49, Bonner 1-2. USC, Hines 5-51, Z.Williams 4-78, Wormley 3-39, Feaster 3-26, Tabaraci 2-33, Ki.Miller 1-12, Ashcraft 1-9, Tupou 1-0, Jordan 1-(minus 3).				
MISSED FIELD GOALS—None.				

student section. But the Trojans’ offense mounted a 13-play scoring drive in response. Tanook Hines tore the ball away from a Washington defender in the end zone for a 10-yard score.

Less than two minutes later, Stewart scooped up the fumble and took off. His 48-yard return completed a 12-point swing for the Trojans.

“To overcome all that and still win shows me some of the guts and toughness and culture in this room right here,” Riley said. “We could’ve folded.”

Still, USC couldn’t put Washington away. Down to their last drive, the Huskies converted on third and 11 and two fourth downs to drive deep into Trojans territory late.

But Kameryn Crawford pulled Williams down for a sack — the Trojans’ fifth of the game — and the defense held. And USC, at the end of a long, brutal week, could breathe a sigh of relief.

COLLEGE FOOTBALL REPORT

Colorado State assistant fired after exiting game

WIRE REPORTS

Talk about getting run out of the building.

Not long after the start of what turned into a 56-26 loss to Oregon State on Saturday in Fort Collins, Colorado State defensive coordinator **Tyson Summers** was nowhere to be found.

When the game finally ended, Rams coach **Jim Mora** said Summers was, in fact, no longer with the team.

“That is a permanent move that was made following tonight’s game,” Mora said.

Mora, in his first year with the Rams, said he had relieved his assistant of his play-calling duties in the first half, though telling him to leave the sideline “wasn’t anything that I would ever consider.”

“He made the decision on his own to leave the field,” Mora said, “and he is no longer with the program.”

The latest defensive debacle came a week after a 59-45 loss to Texas San Antonio. Colorado State (2-3) has allowed 193 points over five games, the fifth most of the 138 schools in the Football Bowl Subdivision.

The Rams allowed 653 yards against the Beavers and have given up 1,195 yards over the last two weeks.

Summers, who has held jobs at Florida, Georgia and Colorado among others over a 20-plus-year career, served as the interim head coach last season for the final five games after **Jay Norvell** was let go. Mora kept him on staff after he was brought on board from UConn to turn around the Rams.

Missouri takes big leap in Top 25

Missouri made a big jump to No. 14 in the Associated Press Top 25 on Sunday after its rout of Florida while the Gators dropped eight spots to No. 16 and were re-

placed by Louisiana State in the top 10.

Texas will go into Saturday’s Red River rivalry game against Oklahoma as the No. 1 team for the fourth straight week. The rest of the top five stood pat with Georgia, Notre Dame, Miami and Ohio State following the Longhorns.

USC fell one spot, to No. 19, after a win over Washington. UCLA was idle but moved up two spots to No. 21.

Late Saturday games

No. 4 Miami routed Clemson 41-13 to seize sole possession of first place in the Atlantic Coast Conference as **Darian Mensah** threw for 227 yards and a touchdown and had a 34-yard scoring run. ... No. 6 Indiana beat Rutgers 47-15 for its 21st straight victory behind **Turbo Richard**, who ran for 204 yards and a touchdown. It is the longest winning streak since Washington

won 21 straight from 2022 to 2024. ... Brigham Young running back **LJ Martin** left early from the No. 10 Cougars’ 17-10 win at Texas Christian after suffering an apparent lower leg injury. Martin, who came in averaging 109.3 yards rushing per game, had only two carries for 16 yards. ... **Sam Leavitt** threw for 173 yards and three touchdowns and No. 11 Louisiana State beat McNeese State 63-14, racking up 731 yards of total offense — the second-most in one game in school history. ... No. 12 Texas Tech romped to a 29-7 win over mistake-prone Colorado as linebacker **John Curry** picked off a pass in the end zone for an easy touchdown, one of four interceptions by the Red Raiders. ... **Maddux Madsen** was 17-of-21 passing for 244 yards and two touchdowns and No. 22 Boise State beat Utah State 37-18 in the inaugural game as a member of the Pac-12 Conference for both teams.

College football AP Top 25

School	W/L	Pts	Pvs
1. Texas (61)	4-0	1737	1
2. Georgia (6)	5-0	1647	2
3. Notre Dame (5)	5-0	1532	3
4. Miami (2)	5-0	1524	4
5. Ohio State	4-1	1490	5
6. Alabama	5-0	1460	7
7. Indiana (1)	5-0	1380	6
8. BYU	4-0	1144	10
9. Ole Miss	3-1	1095	9
10. LSU	4-1	1087	11
11. Texas Tech	5-0	1062	12
12. Utah	4-0	996	13
13. Oregon	3-1	831	15
14. Missouri	4-1	755	25
15. Tennessee	4-1	746	17
16. Florida	4-1	691	8
17. Mississippi State	4-1	487	16
18. Oklahoma State	3-1	477	19
19. USC	5-1	439	18
20. Iowa	4-1	367	14
21. UCLA	4-0	287	23
22. Houston	4-1	279	20
23. Boise State	4-1	271	22
24. SMU	4-1	167	21
25. Pittsburgh	5-0	162	NR

Others receiving votes: Kentucky 160, Wake Forest 142, Wisconsin 88, Duke 83, Northwestern 59, Nebraska 48, Minnesota 19, Arizona 19, James Madison 12, North Dakota State 7.

NO. 21 UCLA AT NO. 13 OREGON

SATURDAY AT AUTZEN STADIUM, 12:30 P.M. | **TV:** CBS

A RECEIVER WHO LOVES BEING A GIVER

At 17, UCLA’s Semaj Morgan started a foundation to help his Detroit community

BY CONNOR DULLINGER

It never has been about the glory for Semaj Morgan. Not the touchdowns. Not the name, image and license deals. And not even the 2024 national championship he won with Michigan.

For the UCLA wide receiver, all of that plays second fiddle to giving back to his community in Detroit and touching the lives of the people around him through the Semaj J. Morgan Foundation — an initiative he started when he was 17 years old.

“My foundation is definitely the best thing that I do. It’s great being a football player, but being able to give back and show people that I really care for others and not just about football and money, I want to be able to pour back into the people that support me and show me love,” Morgan said. “A lot of people don’t get to wake up every day and know that there’s going to be food around. A lot of people in the city of Detroit don’t even know if they’re going to eat at all.”

Morgan decided he wanted to start the foundation when he handed out toys with the Dream Team Male Mentoring group, telling his dad, Semaj T. Morgan, that community service was his calling. But at 17, he was too young to have his name on the paperwork, so his parents opened the foundation for him.

Since the foundation’s launch in February 2023, Morgan has hosted turkey drives, during which he gives away 2,000 turkeys, 2,000 food bags and 1,000 hot meals along with hats, coats, scarves and gloves, in an effort to tackle the health and food gaps in his community.

Morgan also has spearheaded back-to-school giveaways, handing out backpacks and supplies to children.

“We don’t do it just to do it. We do it because we’re trying to close the educational gap that our kids in Detroit suffer from,” Morgan’s father said.

“When you have a kid that’s going to school with the same notebooks and pens and highlighters and erasers that their counter-



RONALDO BOLAÑOS Los Angeles Times

UCLA wideout Semaj Morgan hauls in a catch against San Diego State safety Jelani McLaughlin on Sept. 12.

parts have, now they have more confidence when they go to school.”

Morgan received a grant from the Ballmer Group, founded by Clippers owner Steve Ballmer and his wife, for the foundation’s DiscoverWorks Summer program. The initiative serves 250 families, giving students the opportunity to get their test scores up in the morning and go on field trips in the afternoon, alongside other enrichment activities such as robotics and mentoring.

But the endeavor closest to Morgan’s heart is the foundation’s Mother’s Day and Father’s Day events.

“These are mothers and fathers who lost their sons to gun violence. Semaj is their son, and he takes his NIL money, and he takes them to dinner, buys them gifts as if their son was here,” Morgan’s father said. “These are parents that a lot of these children’s murders have not been solved, so this is a way for us to bless these parents, let them know that they’re not forgotten. There’s never a dry eye in the room.”

The events — which started out with 10 moms and five dads and are up to 35 moms and 20 dads — are particularly special to Morgan, who was friends with some of the sons of the parents involved. Morgan said that seeing the parents and hearing their testimonies puts everything in his life into perspective.

While Morgan is humble about the effect his foundation has had on the people around him, others are taking notice.

Morgan was recognized on the Michigan House floor by state Sens. John DaMoose and Rosemary Bayer for the community service that he’s led in Detroit.

And during the 2024-25 academic year, Morgan was nominated for the inaugural Big Ten Jackie Robinson Community & Impact Award by his previous school, Michigan, for his philanthropic work.

“He understands his mission and call in life, and that’s to bless other people. He’s not about him; he’s about other people, and it’s very rare that you see individuals at such a young age understand their mission and cause in life,” Morgan’s father said.

“Football is one thing, but when he’s giving out turkeys, food bags, hats and coats, he has a bigger smile than getting in the end zone because he understands

these people need help.”

Morgan’s desire to help others was inspired by Curtis Blackwell — Morgan’s travel football coach and president of Sound Mind Sound Body Sports Academy. Morgan’s father said Blackwell always urged players to give back to others.

Blackwell, who coached Arizona Cardinals cornerback Will Johnson, Buffalo Bills cornerback Maxwell Hairston and former Michigan safety Makari Paige alongside Morgan, stresses education before football and places an equal emphasis on academics, athletics and life skills.

And because Michigan does not get the same high school football exposure as Texas, Florida or California, Blackwell was keen on getting his players on college visits, leading to Morgan re-

ceiving more than 25 offers — a direct result of the travel the team made to raise players’ exposure.

“Growing up in a single-parent home, I was fortunate to get a scholarship to college, and it was because of my coaches. And had it not been for my coaches, I don’t know where I would be,” Blackwell said. “If we as coaches are the best people to really influence young people, they will listen to their coach more than their mom, their teacher. And so if we can get the coaches to be the teachers off the field, we could really change their attitude.”

Blackwell was astounded that Morgan was the pupil who took the program’s mission the furthest, surpassing the efforts of NFL players and affecting people well before he’s turned 21.

“You don’t have to wait till you get to the NFL to make an impact. You don’t have to wait till you retire to give back. You can do something every step along the way, and that’s what we teach to our kids — lift as you climb,” Blackwell said. “Semaj took that and ran with it. He has a really big heart and he’s a person that is a giver, not a taker. He’s going to give you the shirt off his back.”

Morgan earned his bachelor’s degree at Michigan and is working on his master’s degree at UCLA while playing football and running his foundation from the West Coast. But he may miss his first foundation event when UCLA travels to Ann Arbor to play his former school in November, although coach Bob Chesney already gave him permission to stay in Michigan after the team leaves.

Morgan’s greatest achievement that weekend may not involve the scoreboard at the Big House.

“I might not have done the best on the field last year, but being able to come home knowing that I’m touching people’s lives, that’s the biggest thing for me,” Morgan said. “To do this at such a young age, and grow so rapidly and touch so many lives, it’s great for me. After football, I want to continue to give back to people. I eventually want to be able to start football programs.”



ERIC SONDHEIMER Los Angeles Times

HART HIGH football coach Jake Goossen-Brown talks to his players on the field.

These dilemmas are always at play in high school sports

From playing time to parent involvement, divisive questions are arising on daily basis.

BY ERIC SONDHEIMER

There are so many ethical dilemmas and tough calls in high school sports that earning a teaching credential or gaining life experiences from participating in sports won’t always provide a clear path for how to proceed.

And when you bring in rules and regulations set forth by the California Interscholastic Federation, the state’s governing body for high school sports, everyone has an opinion or complaint — especially when there is a perception of inconsistency in how punishments for rule

violations are assessed.

It really comes down to how coaches hold themselves accountable and what a principal believes in supporting. For example, some principals have dismissed coaches for using profanity. Others do nothing.

Here are some of the questions administrators, coaches, parents and players now face:

If cheating is wrong, how come so many cheat?

Should a player who transfers and has superior talent immediately get to start over a player who has been busting his butt in the program for three years?

How do you figure out when it’s OK to share playing time at quarterback if you have two good players or even three?

When is it OK for a parent to ask about their son’s

or daughter’s playing time, if ever?

How important is winning games compared to team grade-point average?

What is the most appropriate punishment for showing up late to practice?

What is a legitimate excuse for missing practice?

When should a coach allow players to wear whatever shoes they want compared to having one universal shoe and color?

Why are coaches allowed to use profanity but players can’t?

Should benching a player for receiving a technical foul be automatic?

Should a player be immediately removed for committing a personal foul in football?

How much consideration should be given to the parent with money versus the parent with no money?

How much acting is required to pull off a pregame or halftime speech to inspire your players?

How can you teach teamwork and unselfishness for the team but lay low and suddenly go silent when the top player doesn’t follow the example away from the team?

When a parent offers to become an assistant coach, what instructions and guidelines must be imposed to prevent other parents complaining about “daddy ball?”

When is yelling at an official ever appropriate?

Why is it OK to recruit players, then complain when someone else recruits your players?

For years, baseball coaches have broken rules by holding batting practice before playoff games, resulting in teams forfeiting and

coaches learning ignorance of a rule is no excuse. That leads to, how can a coach receive only a two-game suspension from his district for playing three ineligible players during an out-of-state football game while claiming he didn’t know the ineligible players couldn’t play outside of California when he’s been coaching for more than 10 years?

Any coach who says “I don’t want to know” where a transfer lives to escape accountability might want to start realizing an entire program can go down when they abdicate responsibility.

Finally, many claim whatever they are doing “is for the kids,” but when is it time for an adult to enter the room and explain the end doesn’t justify the means?

As someone who has seen virtually every kind of

behavior, both good and bad, from 50 years of covering high school sports, I can say I don’t have all the answers to many of the questions posed. But when it comes to education-based high school sports, everyone has a responsibility to follow high ethical standards so that maybe a little bit might rub off on their players and help them navigate their coming real-life decisions from a position of strength and confidence.

PREP FOOTBALL

SATURDAY’S RESULTS
CITY SECTION
East Valley League
Arleta 27, North Hollywood 24
SOUTHERN SECTION
8-MAN
Tri-Valley League
Thacher 13, Flintridge Prep 12
Nonleague
California Lutheran 68, ACE 24
INTERSECTIONAL
Orcutt Academy 0, Cate 0

THE TIMES’ PREP FOOTBALL RANKINGS

By Eric Sondheimer

Rk.	School (W-L)	Result	Next game (last week’s ranking)
1	SANTA MARGARITA (6-0)	def. Mater Dei, 14-7	vs. Servite at Saddleback College, Friday (1)
2	ST. JOHN BOSCO (5-1)	def. JSerra, 40-14	vs. Orange Lutheran, Friday (2)
3	SIERRA CANYON (6-0)	def. Loyola, 41-0	at Gardena Serra, Friday (3)
4	CORONA CENTENNIAL (3-3)	def. Vista Murrieta, 65-14	vs. Murrieta Valley, Friday (4)
5	MATER DEI (4-2)	lost to Santa Margarita, 14-7	at JSerra, Friday (5)
6	MISSION VIEJO (4-1)	def. Huntington Beach Edison, 42-14	at Yorba Linda, Thursday (6)
7	ORANGE LUTHERAN (4-2)	def. Servite, 56-21	at St. John Bosco, Friday (7)
8	LOS CLEMENTE (6-0)	def. Yorba Linda, 28-0	at Los Alamitos, Friday (8)
9	PALOS VERDES (6-0)	def. Long Beach Millikan, 42-7	vs. Inglewood, Friday (10)
10	JSERRA (4-2)	lost to St. John Bosco, 40-14	vs. Mater Dei, Friday (11)
11	SERVITE (3-3)	lost to Orange Lutheran, 56-21	at Santa Margarita, Friday (12)
12	CORONA DEL MAR (6-0)	def. Villa Park, 24-10	vs. Tustin, Friday (13)
13	BISHOP AMAT (5-1)	def. Gardena Serra, 27-26	vs. Chaminade, Friday (14)
14	LA SERNA (5-1)	def. Warren, 27-3	vs. La Mirada, Friday (15)
15	CREAN LUTHERAN (4-2)	def. Tustin, 21-7	vs. Capistrano Valley, Friday (16)
16	CARSON (5-1)	def. Gardena, 57-0	at Banning, Friday (17)
17	OXNARD PACIFICA (5-1)	def. Oaks Christian, 38-17	at Newbury Park, Friday (18)
18	CHAMINADE (5-1)	lost to Sherman Oaks Notre Dame, 28-21	at Bishop Amat, Friday (9)
19	GARDENA SERRA (3-3)	lost to Bishop Amat, 27-26	vs. Sierra Canyon, Friday (19)
20	HUNTINGTON BEACH (6-0)	def. El Modena, 24-21	at Dana Hills, Friday (22)
21	SAN JACINTO (6-0)	def. Temescal Canyon, 49-0	vs. Tahquitz, Friday (24)
22	ORANGE (6-0)	def. El Dorado, 42-14	vs. Segerstrom, Friday (25)
23	SHERMAN OAKS NOTRE DAME (6-0)	def. Chaminade 28-21	at Loyola, Friday (NR)
24	CAPISTRANO VALLEY (6-0)	def. La Habra, 42-20	at Crean Lutheran, Friday (NR)
25	YORBA LINDA (4-2)	lost to San Clemente, 28-0	vs. Mission Viejo, Thursday (23)

SPORTS

MONDAY, OCTOBER 5, 2026 :: LATIMES.COM/SPORTS



Photographs by RONALDO BOLAÑOS Los Angeles Times

JAHKEEM STEWART grabs a fumble before rumbling for a 48-yard touchdown to help USC beat Washington 25-21 Saturday night at the Coliseum.

Keeping their eye on the ball

As fans call for Riley’s dismissal, Trojans pull out much-needed comeback win

BY RYAN KARTJE

The knives already were out. The boos already were ringing.

At the end of an already brutal week at USC, during which the nation was ready to dance on the graves of the Trojans and their coach, it seemed for much of Saturday that any last shreds of faith in coach Lincoln Riley might melt away in the beating Southern California sun. Not only had the aftermath of their Oregon loss gone as poorly as possible, but now the Trojans were tripping over themselves again, trailing Washington, a middling Big Ten team down to its fourth-string running back, and a chant began to rise above the fray in the Coliseum, from the USC student section.

“FIRE LINCOLN!” they roared.

That refrain had been heard



LINCOLN RILEY, watching a field goal late in the game, faced heavy scrutiny all week.

only in hushed tones until this past week. But Saturday, before the Trojans pulled away with a 25-21 victory, it felt as if their embattled coach stood at the edge of a certain Rubicon, one he may not return from with one wrong step.

That tension still hung thick over the Coliseum until late in the third quarter, when linebacker Elijah Newby came roaring around the edge toward Washington quarterback Demond Williams Jr. Newby swatted the ball out of Williams’ right hand, and defensive tackle Jahkeem Stewart scooped it up. He sprinted 48 yards on a sore foot for a go-ahead score — and joked afterward that he hit 22 mph on his scoring scamper.

Just two minutes earlier, the Trojans had been down 21-10, and it wasn’t hard to envision how their season could continue spiraling from there. One

[See USC, D6]

NL DIVISION SERIES :: DODGERS VS. BRAVES

GAME 3: TUESDAY AT ATLANTA, 3 P.M. PDT TV: FS1



ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

BRINGING THE HEAT

Dodgers starter Blake Snell delivers against the Atlanta Braves in the first inning of Game 2 of the National League Division Series at Dodger Stadium. It was his first start of this postseason. The game ended after this edition’s deadline. For coverage, visit latimes.com/sports or visit our e-newspaper.

Voices MIRJAM SWANSON COLUMNIST

With aces up their sleeve, Dodgers have room to talk

The Dodgers are better than you. They’re smarter than you. They’re richer and deeper and more popular than you. You know it, they know it, there’s no point pretending otherwise.

So, yes, they went into the National League Division Series looking past the threadbare Atlanta Braves and thinking about the National League Championship Series.

Who does that? In the playoffs?

Your two-time World Series champions with the world’s best starting pitching rotation and, after Saturday’s opening win, a 1-0 series lead, that’s who.

The way the Dodgers did the math, it made sense to save their ace of aces, Yoshinobu Yamamoto — who last postseason went 5-1, had an earned-run average of 1.45 and 33 strikeouts in six appearances and won the World Series most valuable player award — for Game 3 of the NLDS.

Not for the tone-setting Game 1 and, potentially, Game 5 on regular rest.

But Game 3.

Because to the Dodgers, that’s not even much of a calculated risk. It was a math problem specific to them, before they beat the Atlanta Braves 5-3 in Game 1 in 100-degree heat Saturday afternoon.

They figured they’d be able to throw two consecutive left-handers at the lefty-averse Braves lineup, starting Saturday with recently acquired two-time Cy Young winner Tarik Skubal, followed Sunday by Blake Snell, also a two-time Cy Young winner.

Additionally, this way they could have Yamamoto pitch Tuesday on the road, where his ERA is 1.77 instead of at home, where it’s 3.13. And where he’s given up 14 home runs compared with six on the road, where he’s made four fewer starts.

But mostly the Dodgers’ calculus was that having Yamamoto pitch Game 3

[See Swanson, D4]

Los Angeles Times

PLAYOFFS EXTRA

A TIMES E-NEWSPAPER EXCLUSIVE :: MONDAY, OCTOBER 5, 2026

A

3

LA

2

NLDS

SERIES TIED 1-1

W: LEE
L: BUBIC
S: IGLESIAS

GAME 3: AT ATLANTA
TUESDAY, 3 P.M. PDT TV: FS1



JOSUE De Paula walks off the field after the rookie popped out to end Game 2, while Braves closer Raisel Iglesias celebrates with Drake Baldwin after getting the save. GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

DODGERS FIT TO BE TIED

They waste chance to seize control of NLDS, head to Atlanta to face Sale in Game 3

BY MADDIE LEE

Michael Harris II shouldn't have been 90 feet away from scoring the go-ahead run in the first place.

But the Atlanta star was, after Dodgers left fielder Teoscar Hernández took a bad route to his line-drive triple. Then, to make matters worse, left-hander Kris Bubic lost control of a sweeper. It flew high and outside, off the end of catcher Will Smith's glove and to the edge of the grass behind home plate.

Harris scored standing up. And the Dodgers handed the lead back to the Braves.

The Dodgers had every advantage heading into Game 2 of the National League Division Series on Sunday night at Dodger Stadium. In a 3-2 loss to even the series, they gave away every edge they had.

"The advantage for us is we have an opportunity to not let their pitching staff come up for air," manager Dave Roberts said last week, when asked about how taxed the Braves' pitching staff was coming out of their wild-card series. "... We have an opportunity to really expose them if we take the right at-bats and the right approach."

Braves left-hander Ray Kerr, who excelled as a long reliever down the stretch, served as the opener in their second straight bullpen game and third of the post-season. And for the second straight day, the Dodgers failed to score against the Braves' opener or even run up his pitch count to get him out of the game early.

The Dodgers managed just two hits off Kerr, each to open an inning. Freddie Freeman lined a single into right field to kick off the second inning. And Miguel Rojas sent a double into the left-field corner to begin the third.

The Dodgers stranded both.

The failure to bring in Rojas was especially egregious. Tommy Edman immediately popped up a bunt. Then Mookie Betts drew a four-pitch walk, the Dodgers' only other baserunner before Kerr handed over the ball with two outs in the third inning. Shohei Ohtani came up with two on and popped up a high cutter on a full count. He



BLAKE SNELL didn't make it out of the fourth, throwing 90 pitches and walking five. For Atlanta, opposing another two-time Cy Young winner with a bullpen game, it was a big win. ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

was the last batter Kerr faced.

So, the Dodgers' offense let the Braves come up for air. And Dodgers left-hander Blake Snell's short start forfeited their pitching advantage.

His first inning could have been a bigger blow. With one out, Snell gave up a single to Ronald Acuña Jr. and walked Matt Olson and Ozzie Albies to load the bases. He escaped with just one run scored,

on a grounder up the middle from Mauricio Dubón. Betts made a diving stop at short but had no chance at throwing out Dubón.

Snell then struck out Sean Murphy to end the inning, finishing the

at-bat with three straight curveballs for strikes.

The one-run deficit could be erased. But the damage on Snell's pitch count, up to 27 in that inning, was done.

Snell surrendered just one more hit, but when he issued his fifth walk with two outs in the fourth inning, his pitch count was up to 90. Roberts strode from the dugout to pull him. Snell had lasted just one inning longer than the Braves' opener.

In the bottom half of the inning, Freeman, who was optimistic that he could shake off his September slump over the bye week, tied the score with a homer. But in the fifth, the Dodgers handed the lead right back to the Braves.

With two outs, in an 0-and-2 count, Bubic got Harris to chase an outside sweeper moving away from him. Harris leaned over to get his bat to it and sent a line drive into the left field corner.

Hernández took a circuitous route to the ball, trying to cut it off and then having to adjust back when it became clear he was too shallow. He missed the ball by only inches, and it caromed off the wall, allowing Harris to reach third base, in position to score on a wild pitch.

The Braves expanded their lead in the seventh inning against hard-throwing right-hander Edgardo Henriquez, who gave up a single to Olson and an RBI double to Harris.

Then right-hander Roki Sasaki got himself into a bases-loaded situation in the eighth, with Acuña at the plate, but got out of it with a double play. Sasaki then retired the side in order in the ninth.

By contrast, the Dodgers' offense barely threatened in the late innings.

The Braves relievers retired 15 of the last 16 batters they faced to end the game, with Max Muncy's solo home run in the ninth the only exception.

Rookie Josue De Paula made his postseason debut as a pinch-hitter with two outs in the ninth. He popped up in foul territory to end the game.

Next, the series heads to Atlanta for two games, with Braves All-Star Chris Sale set to start Game 3 against Yoshinobu Yamamoto.

NLDS GAME 2: ATLANTA 3, DODGERS 2



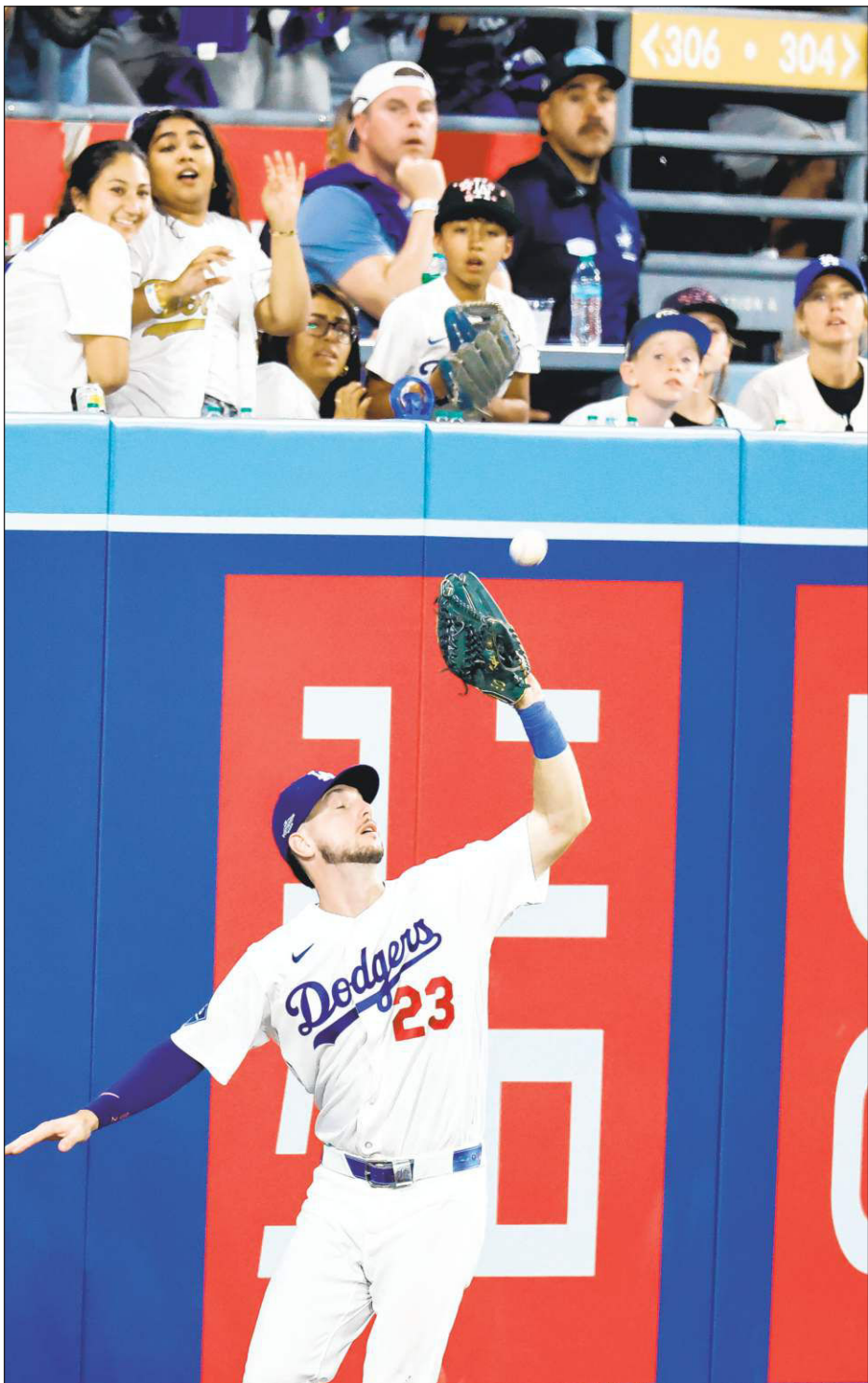
ATLANTA'S Ronald Acuña Jr. slides past the tag of Dodgers shortstop Mookie Betts to steal second base during the first inning of Game 2 of the NLDS.



DODGERS first baseman Freddie Freeman, left, greets Miguel Rojas after hitting a solo home run that tied the score at 1-1 in the fourth inning.



DODGERS designated hitter Shohei Ohtani strikes out in the seventh inning. The best-of-five series is tied at a game apiece and will resume Tuesday in Atlanta.



AS EXPECTANT fans watch, right fielder Kyle Tucker catches a ball on the warning track hit by Braves catcher Drake Baldwin in the sixth inning.



DODGERS reliever Edgardo Henriquez wipes his brow after giving up an RBI double to the Braves' Michael Harris II, who earlier had hit a triple and scored.



BRAVES fans wearing outfits supporting the University of Georgia snack in the stands in the third inning. Both teams finished with six hits and no errors.

ENTERTAINMENT

MONDAY, OCTOBER 5, 2026 :: LATIMES.COM/ENTERTAINMENT



BRIAN FEINZIMER For The Times

“THE SECOND I see people gather is the second I feel rested. It is so spiritual for me,” says JIJI’s Jazz Club creator Tida Norasingh, seen at L.A.’s Slow Jamz Gallery.

Voices
MARY McNAMARA
CULTURE CRITIC

Ellison’s message:
It’s my empire

Naming his merger Skydance, he deems two Hollywood studios sub-brands.

What a surprise. David Ellison has decided to name the Frankenstudio media company created by the merger of Paramount Skydance and Warner Bros. Discovery simply Skydance.

And why not? “Massive Debt Funding Media” doesn’t really roll off the tongue (though “Ultra Leveraged” has a nice ring); “Ellison and Dad” is a bit too on the nose; and “Skydance” is, after all, the name he chose for the one company out of those four that he built rather than bought.

Skydance is a poetic term with “Star Wars” overtones and perhaps unintentional symbolism. Before the aviation-loving Ellison claimed it, “sky dance” referred to the aerial mating of certain birds, most famously the American woodcock, also known as the timberdoodle or (I’m not making this up) the bogsucker.

(“Timberdoodle Media,” now that’s a splendid name, and “Bogsucker Productions” could work as well.)

In his attempts to acquire Warner Bros. Discovery, [See Ellison, E6]

Beloved figure on, off screen

The late Dennis Haskins, best known as “Saved by the Bell’s” Mr. Belding, was a karaoke star. E2

The perfect trio for a wild tale

The campy “Verity” finally gets a movie adaptation of Colleen Hoover’s juicy novels right. Review, E3

Comics E4-5
Puzzles E5

A POP-UP JAZZ CLUB IN SYNC WITH L.A.

The ex-tattoo artist behind JIJI’s believes that jazz belongs to everyone, and that gathering is an act of resistance

By MARY CARREON

The crowd at El Cid is writhing and dripping in sweat. If not for the jazz onstage, the scene looks like it’s meant for a sold-out show headlined by a DJ with a cult following. Instead, everyone in the main room is dancing under a glistening disco ball to the syncopations of Riva, a three-piece comprised of a psychedelic saxophonist, drummer and keyboardist. They engulf the floor of the Silver Lake nightclub in an electric surge of high-energy jazz fused with an array of other genres, including jazz-house and bossa nova, luring people to dance and howl after every solo. It’s a standard party for JIJI’s Jazz Club, a roving pop-up series that hosts live jazz in warehouses, wine bars, speakeasies, cafes and other community-oriented spaces across L.A.

JIJI’s founder, Tida Norasingh, curates jazz nights six times per month, filling a necessary music void in L.A.’s cultural firmament. She discovered this dearth after moving back home to Southern California in 2020 from New York, where she lived for three years and built a lifestyle around regularly consuming jazz in stoop sessions, open jams and pop-ups. Jazz was financially accessible, the culture was alive

and shows were abundant. But it wasn’t the same in L.A.

“I had a really hard time finding jazz in L.A. after moving back,” she says. “Everyone I asked couldn’t tell me where the good ‘spots’ were and the places everyone pointed me to felt very out-of-touch.”

By “out-of-touch” Norasingh means expensive and boujee. The crowds were mostly lifeless, largely because the majority of jazz venues in L.A. are seated only, and attendees remained silent even after a mesmerizing solo. Venues require a two-drink minimum and shows are expensive to attend. So in 2024, she stopped looking for the music and culture she wanted to be part of and started building it.

“It felt like [a lot of these spaces were] stuck in time, and there’s charm to that,” she says. “However, I realized that if those environments exist already, and the thing I was looking for didn’t, then I would just have to make the club I wanted to attend.”

Norasingh, who was a full-time tattoo artist then, hosted the first iteration of JIJI’s Jazz Club in a small studio she was running in the Arts District. JIJI’s didn’t have an Instagram yet, nor were there fliers for the first show. The name “JIJI’s” [See JIJI’s, E6]



BEN BLACKALL Starz

CUMMING plays Leo, a gay bar owner in Manchester, England.

Review

ROBERT LLOYD
TELEVISION CRITIC

Much to say about the here and now

Alan Cumming is phenomenal in ‘Tip Toe,’ a Starz series about homophobia.

“Tip Toe,” a fine new drama from Russell T Davies that premiered Friday on Starz, begins at the end, with Leo Struther (Alan Cumming, phenomenally good), a gay Manchester bar owner, hanging dead from a streetlight outside his house, as a woman screams and his neighbor Clive Goss (David Morrissey) stands breathing heavily on his porch. Then, as so many series do nowadays, it goes back in time — 10 days here — to tell the tale that got them there.

And so you are prepared from the beginning for tragedy, though not everything that happens in its five episodes will be tragic — some of what we see will be sweet and even celebratory — and one might forget for a moment where this is all heading, and even believe that what we’ve already seen will turn out differently.

The series sets off in a comparatively light mood. Chasing a one-night stand who’s stolen his laptop, Leo finds he’s locked himself out of his house, and, dressed only in his underwear, goes next door to ask if he can [See ‘Tip Toe,’ E2]

Asco’s call to action resonates

A documentary on PBS highlights the trailblazing art group and a new generation.

By LAURA ZORNOSA

Multidisciplinary artist rafa esparza was maybe 19 and in the break room of the now-defunct Orchard Supply Hardware in Pasadena when he first found out about the revolutionary art group Asco. It was the early 2000s, and he was working full-time while going to school part-time at East Los Angeles College. He’d bring his homework to his job, and an older colleague, Ignacio, took interest in the books he was reading — mostly about Chicana/o studies and art.

Ignacio grew up in East [See ‘Asco,’ E3]



Asa Nisi Masa Films

A STILL from San Cha’s “Luna,” one of the new No-Movies featured in “Asco.”

Singing praises of one of ‘the Dimples’ crew

Dennis Haskins was beloved at the Burbank karaoke bar that closed in 2015.

By LAURA ZORNOSA

Actor Dennis Haskins was a staple at the now-shuttered Dimples karaoke bar in Burbank — so much so that many patrons thought he owned it. He didn’t, but regulars, karaoke lovers and fans have fond memories of him there.

Haskins — best known for playing Principal Richard Belding on the classic ’90s teen sitcom “Saved by the Bell” — died Sept. 27 after an eight-year battle with Parkinson’s disease, among other health issues. Then came an outpouring of recollections, anecdotes and tributes, from all corners of the internet.

“The people, just on social media, that have had a brush with Dennis — a picture, a story — the amount of people, it seems like it’s physically impossible to have interacted and had an experience with so many different people,” said Dale Wade Davis, a former regular at the venue.

Dimples, billed as “America’s first karaoke bar,” closed in 2015 after 33 years. In a tribute to the beloved bar, The Times’ Chad Garland wrote in 2014:

It’s a place where even celebrities can be regular people, said Dennis Haskins, who is perhaps best known as Mr. Belding, the principal of Bayside High in TV’s “Saved by the Bell.” He said he’s been coming to the bar for 14 years. “It’s my Cheers,” Haskins said, referring to the fictional Boston bar from the 1980s sitcom. “I’m like Norm.”

The Times spoke with former Dimples-goers about their memories of Haskins. Responses have been edited for length and clarity.

Dale Wade Davis

57; movie producer / former sports anchor and actor; splits time between Texas and Studio City

We would meet there usually every Wednesday, and I didn’t know who Dennis was. I was familiar with “Saved by the Bell,” but I didn’t really watch it. So Dennis was just Dennis to me initially. But I saw how people treated him and the reaction he had on people. He was always very gregarious. It’s a cliché: He lit up a room, but he really was everybody’s best friend.

We called him “America’s principal.” He loved that, though he didn’t live in the past. He was a dreamer; he was looking forward. He was like a young actor, excited about the next gig. He was not living in the past, as much as he enjoyed being Mr. Belding.

I had had a kidney transplant from Phillip Palmer, who’s the morning anchor at ABC7, and it was a really big story back in 2007. Like, it was on “Good Morning America,” CNN, just the whole thing. Dennis was always right there. He was at the hospital for my surgery. My friends did [a benefit] and he showed up to that.

After this, I wanted to do something to give back and so I created a celebrity poker tournament. Dennis was the first celebrity that really was just excited about it and really showed up. By the end, Jack Black showed up every year, we had A-listers. But Dennis was the one that really helped me get that off the ground initially.

Did he have a favorite song to sing?

He did sing Sinatra a lot. I would say that was his staple.

Larry Bagby

52; actor/musician; grew up in Thousand Oaks
Bagby was in “A Kicking Weasel,” the third episode of “Saved by the Bell: The New Class.”

Dennis was awesome. We just hit it off; we both love music. I was doing some original recordings. I had a song called “Bus Driver” that I wanted some kids, my nieces, to sing on, and my family. And Dennis came into the studio and sang on it as well. He just did some backup vocals for me, which was so cool. He drove all the way out to Simi Valley. He’s just always up for a good time.

I was the MC at a show I did at the Hotel Cafe and he took time to write notes. I found this paper of notes that he had written for me about my band. Because I think he managed some bands before he did his acting thing. He just gave me great notes, as an entertainer, like, “Keep it moving, don’t talk too much, have the band playing music always.”

He was the kind of guy that showed up when you most needed.

Did he have a favorite song to sing?

“Great Balls of Fire,” I want to say, was maybe one. I feel like he did “Johnny B. Goode.” We probably sang that together a few times too. I feel like he really liked the Beatles. We all loved the Beatles.

Ryan Adam Wells

41; singer-songwriter; used to live in L.A., now resides in Houston

When we started going there, I had never seen “Saved by the Bell.” I didn’t grow up with it. I was a “Boy Meets World” kid. ... But I was there with my friend

Leo’s bar, Spit and Polish, sits on Canal Street in Manchester’s long-established “gay village.” It’s a safe space for his employees and regulars, including Zee (Iz Hesketh), who’s been sleeping hidden in the bar, frightened of new flatmates since coming out as a trans woman, and Melba (Paul Rhys, brilliant), a former drag performer who holds down the end of the bar like Norm from “Cheers” and carries a torch for Leo.

Things will go generally downhill from here, in a narrative of escalating misunderstanding — not in the sense of an innocent mistake, of simply getting the wrong end of the stick (though that’s part of it), but as a contemporary habit of mind, blinkered, closed to facts but open to conspiracies. Clive, a consumer of social media disinformation, believes that AIDS and COVID are fake; he lives in fear.

Directed by Peter Hoar, it’s a rough watch, yet beautifully wrought and delicately performed, inspiring and depressing, hopeless and hopeful by turns Davies



GARY NULL NBCUniversal

DENNIS Haskins played the earnest Principal Richard Belding on the teen sitcom “Saved by the Bell.”



SCOTT DUDELSON Getty Images

THE ACTOR was a regular at the now-closed Dimples karaoke bar, where he liked to sing Sinatra.

Loren, and he pointed it out to me, and he recognized him from the show. And I absolutely did not.

I had already said hello to the guy and shook his hand because we were waiting for a drink at the bar, and he’s really nice. And then my friend Heath — we had lunch with him the next day — he goes, “Oh yeah, Dennis is there every single day. He’s always there. That’s a Los Angeles fixture. It’s like running into Ron Jeremy on Hollywood Boulevard.”

Loren and I were talking last night, trying to remember what songs he would always do. We both remembered “Sweet Caroline,” but then the most common thing he would do is duets. He would duet with the staff at Dimples.

The two songs we were able to remember for sure hearing were “I Got You Babe” by Sonny & Cher and “Picture” by Kid Rock and Sheryl Crow. The reason we remembered “Picture” is because there’s cuss words in there, and I remember Loren being like, “Oh, Mr. Belding! Oh my!”

Scott Groves

47; former loan officer in the Burbank area

This guy was just a stellar human being, man. He would talk to anybody. He kind of embraced his type-casting as Principal Belding, and was just always nice to people, always buying people a drink, just a jovial, happy, relatable guy.

I probably went to Dimples 30 times in my 20s, which would have been in the 2000s, and I’m pretty sure he was there like 28 out of the 30 times, just singing and having a good time and socializing with people.

Did he have a favorite song to sing?

He was game for pretty much anything. You could ask him to do the male singing part or the female singing part of Meat Loaf’s “Paradise by the Dashboard Light,” or you could ask him to sing some ’80s love song or some ’90s rock ballad.

Kevin Centazzo

55; consignment store owner and former writer-actor; lived in Burbank’s Cabrini Villas, now resides in Bristol, R.I.

Mr. Belding — Dennis — was a regular there. And when he was there, he was a regular guy. We knew who he was, of course. And if you wanted to do a duet with him, he’d be happy to do it. And if he got his chance, his go-to song every time was “Play That Funky Music.” And he gave it everything he had. He really got into it. He really loved it. That was *his* song. If someone else did it, and didn’t know it was his song, he’d be upset that somebody took his song.

When he passed away, I got a pang of sadness. He was a principal to every kid in whatever decade it was, the ’80s, ’90s. And when I met him, he was just one of the Dimples’ crew.

DENNIS HASKINS, 1950 – 2026

Known as ‘Saved by the Bell’s’ Principal Belding

The actor’s character in the 1990s high school sitcom was a popular figure.

By EMILY ST. MARTIN

Dennis Haskins, an actor known best for playing Principal Richard Belding on the 1990s high school sitcom “Saved by the Bell,” died Sept. 27. He was 75.

Haskins’ friend and longtime caretaker, Kimberly Snow, confirmed the actor’s death. A cause of death is unknown, but Haskins had quietly battled Parkinson’s disease and was candid about other health issues. According to Snow, the actor died around 11 p.m. in a Burbank assisted living facility.

Snow, a former manager of Burbank’s since-shuttered Dimples Karaoke, shared the news of the actor’s death on Instagram, writing that Haskins was a staple at the joint, so much so that many of the patrons thought he owned it.

“A lot of people thought he owned it, but he didn’t,” the tribute read. “He just loved the place and its people. He enjoyed singing for people, meeting them, and taking selfies with his fans. Dimples closed down about 11 years ago, and people still associate him with his beloved ‘second home.’ He was known to most as Mr. Belding from Saved by the Bell, but to us, he was much more than that.

“About eight years ago, he became ill,” the post continued. “He had been silent about his fight with Parkinson’s, among other health concerns, because he did not want the attention. He did not want to have to tell people. He would say, ‘What do I even say?’ So I respected his wishes and stayed quiet, and I helped him through his journey into

the next chapter of his life.

“Late last night, that journey ended for him. He is now at peace and is probably entertaining the people in the sky. Just know that if you tried to reach out to him in the last few years, I did read your messages to him, and you were heard.”

Haskins played the earnest and beloved Mr. Belding across the “Saved by the Bell” franchise for 12 years, from 1988 to 2000. As recently as 2015, he reprised the role for a sketch on “The Tonight Show Starring Jimmy Fallon,” alongside Bayside High School alums Mark-Paul Gosselaar, Elizabeth Berkley, Mario Lopez and Tiffani Thiessen.

Haskins was born in Chattanooga, Tenn., on Nov. 18, 1950, to parents Dennis Button Haskins IV and Veneta Marilyn Yarbrough. One of three boys, he attended Notre Dame High School in Chattanooga and the University of Tennessee at Chattanooga.

He ultimately made his way to Los Angeles where he broke into acting, with his first on-screen gig playing a workman in “Archie Bunker’s Place” in 1981. He acted regularly through the ’80s, landing parts in television shows “Magnum P.I.” and “The Dukes of Hazzard” before finding his way to the part that would make him America’s favorite principal.

He played Mr. Belding across seven different series, including, “Good Morning, Miss Bliss,” “Saved by the Bell,” “Saved by the Bell: The College Years,” “Saved by the Bell: The New Class,” “The Rerun Show,” “Robot Chicken” and “Victorious.”

“It’s a tragic loss,” Jay Schachter, head of film and television for Stewart Talent in New York City, said in a statement to NBC. “Everyone loved Mr. Belding and those of us who got to know Dennis, loved him even more. He was a great person, and he loved, I mean absolutely LOVED his fans.”



RODIN ECKENROTH Getty Images

A CLASS ACT

Dennis Haskins, pictured in 2018, played Mr. Belding across seven different series.

A beautifully wrought and delicately performed drama

[“**Tip Toe**,” from E1]
borrow a phone to call his friend Stephanie (Elizabeth Berrington) to bring him a spare key; here we meet the Goss family, Clive, an out-of-work electrician; his wife, Marie (Pooky Quesnel), who doesn’t like Clive; 16-year-old son George (Jackson Connor), gay and closeted; and 25-year-old son Saul (Joseph Evans), an easygoing hunk who lives at home, secretly makes money on OnlyFans and accepts everyone for who they are. Leo and the Gosses have been living amicably at arm’s length for 14 years, though their lives are about to become closely entwined, with disastrous results.

In an act of something like willful, somewhat disturbing friendliness, or a desire not to have to deal with Leo the next time he’s locked out, Clive makes a copy of Leo’s key and installs a lock box by his door. (By the Chekov’s gun rule, a key copied in Episode 1 is bound to be turned in a lock in whatever later act Davies deems advantageous.) Then, Leo gives Clive work at his bar.

Leo’s bar, Spit and Polish, sits on Canal Street in Manchester’s long-established “gay village.” It’s a safe space for his employees and regulars, including Zee (Iz Hesketh), who’s been sleeping hidden in the bar, frightened of new flatmates since coming out as a trans woman, and Melba (Paul Rhys, brilliant), a former drag performer who holds down the end of the bar like Norm from “Cheers” and carries a torch for Leo.

Things will go generally downhill from here, in a narrative of escalating misunderstanding — not in the sense of an innocent mistake, of simply getting the wrong end of the stick (though that’s part of it), but as a contemporary habit of mind, blinkered, closed to facts but open to conspiracies. Clive, a consumer of social media disinformation, believes that AIDS and COVID are fake; he lives in fear.

Directed by Peter Hoar, it’s a rough watch, yet beautifully wrought and delicately performed, inspiring and depressing, hopeless and hopeful by turns Davies



JAMES STACK Starz

ACTORS Shakeel Kimotho, Iz Hesketh, Alan Cumming and Luyanda Unati Lewis-Nyawo in “Tip Toe,” a new limited series drama from Russell T Davies on Starz.

has points to make — hanging your protagonist is not subtle — but his dialogue carries a lot of weight lightly; and long conversations ebb and flow and rise and fall like

compressed playlets. If there is something schematic about the arc, the characters within it, Clive as much as Leo, are completely human. They stand for

something bigger than themselves, but they also stand for themselves.

Davies brought gay life in its infinite variety to television with the 1999 series

“Queer as Folk” (also set on Canal Street) and gender fluidity to “Doctor Who,” the series he revived in 2005 and returned to in 2023. (The Tardis is currently in limbo.) His “Cucumber,” about middle-age gay men, and “Banana,” about young LGBTQ+ people, are also set in Manchester, where Davies has lived since the late 1980s.

“Tip Toe” has been crafted for an age of surging homophobia and anti-gay violence.

“The president of America has given these men permission to attack us,” says Melba, as he sits with Leo late one night by the canal. The series’ dark prophet, he gives it its title.

“It’s a storm, it’s a tide, it’s a great big tsunami. We’re in the middle of it right now ... If you’d asked me in 1996 what do you think 2026 will be like, I’d have said ‘glory days’ ... But they tricked us didn’t they? They let us all come out, so now we’re standing in the open ready for them to shoot us down. I used to walk into a room and just go, ‘Ta-da!’ Now I tiptoe, just in case.”

Review KATIE WALSH

‘Verity’ gives its trio of actors roles to bite into

Adapting Colleen Hoover’s books to the screen has been tricky. This film gets it right.

Did director Michael Showalter just nail the Colleen Hoover adaptation? The third major movie version of the blockbuster author’s work hits the big screen with “Verity” and things are starting to lock into place. Much darker and more twisty than the weepy trauma dumps “It Ends With Us” or “Reminders of Him,” “Verity” is high camp with a wink, a hair toss and just enough bite to draw blood.

The screenplay is adapted by Nick Antosca, known for tawdry television melodramas (“The Act,” “Cape Fear”). His script is remarkably faithful to the book, just condensed for efficiency. It helps that Hoover’s novel, with shades of “Jane Eyre” and “Rebecca,” is full of wild turns and insane details and really only needs a movie-star makeover to work as a film: a few nips, tucks and a flashy exterior.

Showalter and Antosca

take the bones and juicy bits of Hoover’s book and make it more elegant, refined and contemporary, but keep all the craziness that viewers crave. The film opens with a graphic car accident that results in struggling writer Lowen Ashleigh (Dakota Johnson) covered in gore. When a stranger comes to her aid, one man’s death becomes another couple’s portentous meet-cute, as Lowen encounters Jeremy (Josh Hartnett) for the first time.

The pair are about to find themselves in a complex psychosexual throuple with Jeremy’s wife, Verity (Anne Hathaway), a mega-successful novelist and genuine celebrity. Verity can’t finish her book series for mysterious reasons, so Jeremy hires Lowen to do so for her. When she arrives at their imposing Vermont mansion to go through Verity’s notes, Lowen discovers that Verity’s a vegetable: completely physically and mentally indisposed after a car accident. Still, she looms large in Lowen’s imagination, especially when she finds a secret autobiography in which Verity reveals her darkest secrets.

The guileless Lowen gob-



ANNE Hathaway stars as Verity and Josh Hartnett as her husband, Jeremy, in Michael Showalter’s film.

‘Verity’

Rated: R, for sexual content, some nudity, language, violence and bloody images

Running time: 1 hour, 54 minutes

Playing: In wide release

bles it up, spinning an elaborate fantasy about the woman Verity was before the accident. In Lowen’s overactive imagination, Hathaway plays a Hitchcockian femme

fatale always wearing her signature color, red. This juicy role — a female psychopath-bad-mommy-sex-kitten-genius — is almost too easy for the Oscar winner.

Showalter and Antosca draw out the “Persona”-esque qualities of the story as Lowen, while finding herself drawn to Jeremy, becomes absolutely obsessed with Verity, or the idea of her. Does she want to be Verity or sleep with her? She definitely wants to inhabit Verity’s luxe life, moving into her office, wearing her clothes,

mothering her son, seducing her husband. But there are also haunting clues that the catatonic wife down the hall isn’t as helpless as she looks.

Showalter has assembled the perfect trio of actors for the material, because all three have a knowingness about the way they play the duality of their characters. Hathaway is arch and expressive, doing subtle things with her eyes and voice that no one else can. Her more actressy qualities juxtapose Johnson’s dry, sardonic demeanor, which she alternates with whispery seduction. Hartnett plays the hapless man well but his naivety could be concealing something more sinister, as it did in the M. Night Shyamalan thriller “Trap.” All three are able to pivot easily between likable and not, which is key for the shifting alliances in “Verity.”

It’s all sumptuous to look at, from the movie-star faces to the weird but fascinating interiors of the Vermont mansion, all warm wood and stone accents. The plot exists on twists, but if there’s anything missing from “Verity,” it’s the backstory that might inform Verity’s calculated machinations or

Lowen’s striving to fill her personal void.

One wouldn’t expect Showalter, who has roots in comedy as a founding member of “The State,” to be working in the realm of campy Sirkian melodrama, but he’s become a versatile director over the years and no doubt his working relationship with Hathaway from the 2024 romance adaptation “The Idea of You” helped. Comedy directors (see also Paul Feig of “The Housemaid”) tend to do well in this genre, because they can nail the intentionally funny bits. Everyone here is in on the joke, but Showalter could have pushed it even further.

Still, of the Colleen Hoover adaptations so far, “Verity” is easily the best and most stylish of them all. It plays with sophisticated themes of writing, truth and trust: the complicated nature of the versions of ourselves we put on the page. The unmoored truth is never resolved here, leaving us with the lesson that the only thing certain is uncertainty. Verity? Hardly.

Walsh is a Tribune News Service film critic.

‘Asco: Without Permission’ heralds a new generation

[‘Asco,’ from E1] L.A., and showed esparza a big manila envelope stuffed with incredible sketches and drawings by Glugio “Gronk” Nicandro. Gronk, a friend of Ignacio, was one of the founding members of Asco, which roared to life as an unapologetically Chicano organization in the early 1970s and was made up of East L.A. natives including Patssi Valdez, Harry Gamboa Jr. and Willie Herrón.

Esparza is now among two generations of L.A. Chicano and Mexican artists who have passed the torch that Asco used to blaze its groundbreaking trail. The story of the art group and its descendants, also including Maria Maea and San Cha, is featured in the new documentary, “Asco: Without Permission.” Executive produced by Gael García Bernal and Diego Luna, the film premiered last year at SXSW and arrived on TV for the first time last Friday as part of PBS SoCal’s “Voices” series (it’s also on PBS.org and the PBS app).

A movement begins

When Asco first coalesced, Gamboa went to Los Angeles County Museum of Art and noticed a striking absence of Chicano pieces. In the film, he recounts how, after his concerns were dismissed by a higher-up at LACMA, Asco decided to take matters into its own hands.

The group came back later that evening and tagged the building with their names (“Spray Paint LACMA,” 1972), effectively reclaiming the entire museum as a work of Chicano art.

Asco’s work remained in relative obscurity — living in local mythology through storytellers like Ignacio — for decades. Then in 2011, LACMA’s views evolved and the museum gave Asco its first major retrospective, “Elite of the Obscure.” Documentary writer and director Travis Gutiérrez Senger came across press coverage of the retrospective and felt immediately drawn to the group, connected “on almost a cellular level.”

But it wasn’t until Trump’s first run for presidency and subsequent election, when his language around Latinos and immigrants dangerously sharpened, that Gutiérrez Senger knew in his gut that he needed to make this film now.

What set Asco apart was the fact that it was an art group, not a singular artist, working in tandem to react to social and political realities, including the 1968 East L.A. walkouts, the 1970 Chicano Moratorium, the Vietnam War, police brutality and gang violence.

“I would have never done the film if it wasn’t a collective,” Gutiérrez Senger said. “The thing about art history — and in literature and film — we often canonize individuals. When I saw Asco and it was a group, and they’re [on] the cover of Artforum

or at the Whitney ... that to me was really, really captivating. And, I thought, also very constructive.

“This isn’t just a group; this is a metaphor for how we mobilize and change,” Gutiérrez Senger remembers thinking.

Asco was a fecund ecosystem, as is the close-knit community of contemporary artists following in its footsteps. The documentary recounts the history of the original group while heeding its call to action by collaborating with next-gen artists to carry the tradition forward. In 2023, Gutiérrez Senger curated a pop-up exhibition — featured in the film — alongside Pilar Tompkins Rivas, “Asco and the Next Gen: An Inter-Generational Celebration of Latinx Art.” “Asco and the Next Gen” included esparza, Maria Maea, San Cha, Ruben Ulises Rodriguez Montoya, Guadalupe Rosales, Gabriela Ruiz and Dorian Wood.

“When you’re deeply collaborating with folks, and you’re in each other’s mediums and you’re sharing thoughts, and you’re thinking together, conceptualizing together, birthing a project together from scratch, you really have to step beside yourself, and understand that this is something that you’re co-creating,” esparza said. “Versus, I think art teaches us to center the single voice, the singular author of an artwork. And my experience of life, of art-making, has been the complete opposite: I think that we’re constantly reflecting each other.”

Esparza’s contribution to that 2023 pop-up was called “Corpo RanfLA: Terra Cruiser” and was originally staged outside the fairgrounds of Art Basel Miami a year before. The L.A. version took place in the parking lot of an Arts District strip mall. Esparza bounced. He lay in a prone position, arms extended, body ensconced in gold and green lowrider armature, adhered to a blue bike frame, rocking on a 25-cent mechanical ride mechanism. The early connections esparza had with Asco resonated deeply in his relationship to art-making.

“They’re guerrilla, not asking for permission, just doing what they wanted to do with the help of their collective efforts,” esparza said. “That’s an ethos that’s very present in my own performance work, and it’s something that I hold very dear to me. It’s something that I always want to protect, in terms of how the art industry so powerfully commodifies everything you make as artists. I feel like performance still holds this power to really resist that, depending on how we will it into being.”

Asco also had an interest in film. The art group members didn’t see themselves — or Chicanos or Latinos — represented in Hollywood, so they did it themselves, subverting a movie into a



MARIA Maea is among the artists featured in Travis Gutiérrez Senger’s new doc.



MAEA is the Being in “Pasado/Futuro,” her No-Movie project with “Asco” director Gutiérrez Senger.

single still photograph that became its own story; an implied narrative. These, featured in the documentary, were called No-Movies.

‘Infinity’ on film

In addition to the “Asco and the Next Gen” pop-up exhibition, Gutiérrez Senger and the filmmaking team invited multidisciplinary artist Maria Maea, San Cha, musician Fabi Reyna and Mexico City-based Ruben Ulises Rodriguez Montoya to create new No-Movies, also featured in the film, in response to Asco’s

original No-Movies.

Maea first learned about Asco through esparza too. He’s a mentor of sorts to her (they’re part of the same “interlocked brown community,” she says), and they were making adobe bricks together on the banks of the L.A. River for esparza’s 2017 Whitney Biennial installation when he told her the story about the hardware store and the manila envelope.

“They had a finite amount of resources, and they took this cinematic film lens or film camera film and

shot these stills,” Maea said. “I think for me, it was so beautiful to see the infinity that could happen in front of it, the story that could happen behind it. It felt like we were just seeing this snapshot of a beautiful cinematic moment.”

The documentary’s new No-Movies are slightly longer, but still snippets of less than five minutes.

The main character of Maea’s “Pasado/Futuro” No-Movie, the Being, sprang from the show “L.A. Fonts,” in artist Alfonso Gonzalez Jr.’s backyard. (“Pasado/Futuro” also includes a group of kids working in a garage, meant to emulate Asco’s own garage origins — and to represent the *next* next gen.

Its cast includes Maea’s younger sister, Ariel-Evelia Tuilaepa Diaz. The Being is alien, mystical and magical, a migrant finding her way in a new world. (Maea often works with palm weaving, incorporated here, and palms have their own migration story to L.A.)

“Something that really intrigued me was their sci-fi aspect of this film,” Maea said of Asco. “Like, they lived in a real world where they were experiencing the Chicano Moratorium, they’re experiencing vi-

olence in the streets, and they were also experiencing ... the news projected back at them, that *they* were the issue,” stranger-than-fiction scenarios they synthesized into sometimes-futuristic or dystopian work.

Composer and performer San Cha’s No-Movie, “Luna,” made together with the musician Fabi Reyna, began as a song San Cha had written for a friend who had died; she had had a dream of him on the moon. In collaboration with Gutiérrez Senger, the No-Movie evolved into a piece about a lover, played by Reyna. Now, “Luna” is tender and otherworldly, drenched in the high drama and glamour that San Cha so loves.

San Cha was born in San José, then moved to San Francisco, where she was taken in by the Bay Area drag scene — specifically by her drag mother Per Sia, who’s still there. (San Cha recently relocated to Amsterdam.)

“She is from South-Central, but she studied art, visual art,” San Cha said. “She was a photographer, and she really got into the drag scene, and she was super familiar with Asco. We would do these processions in the Mission, from the Mission to the Castro ... and she would always mention Asco in these moments.”

That’s likely because Asco’s early performances, as the art historian and curator C. Ondine Chavoya points out in the film, emphasized procession, mobility, mobilization and occupation, marking sites of political violence.

Once San Cha moved to L.A., she found community quickly too. She met Maea — with whom she made a video, “Coatlucue,” for the Music Center’s For the Love of L.A. program — and later lived with esparza.

“We can’t really perform in a vacuum,” San Cha said. “I can’t imagine doing this by myself, ever.... When I moved to L.A., there’s someone for everything. ... And that way I didn’t feel the need to do everything alone. And even though in L.A. it was a little more professional, there’s so many people that are just like family.”

When Gutiérrez Senger first started making this film, he thought that it — and Asco itself — was about saying “f— you” to the systems and institutions and racism that give us *asco*. (“Asco” means nausea or disgust in Spanish.)

“But at the end of the project, I started looking at the work and myself and the artists I had made the film with, and just seeing this incredible beauty and love,” he said.

“And I realized that the power of Asco’s work is ultimately about self-love, and that when you feel that — and you can feel almost a collective sense of self-love as brown people — it gives you incredible potential and strength.”

COMICS

LA CUCARACHA By Lalo Alcaraz



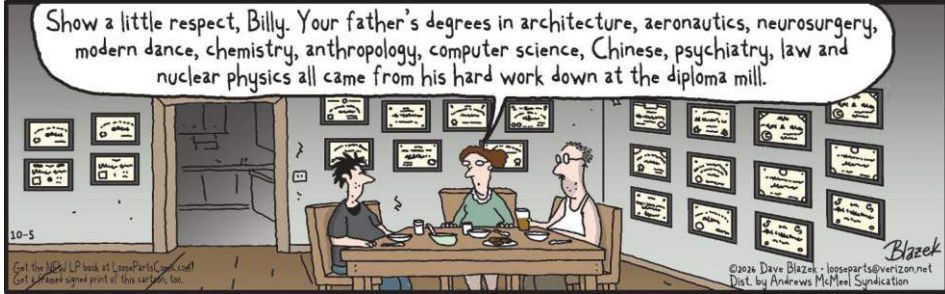
CRABGRASS By Tauhid Bondia



CURTIS By Ray Billingsley



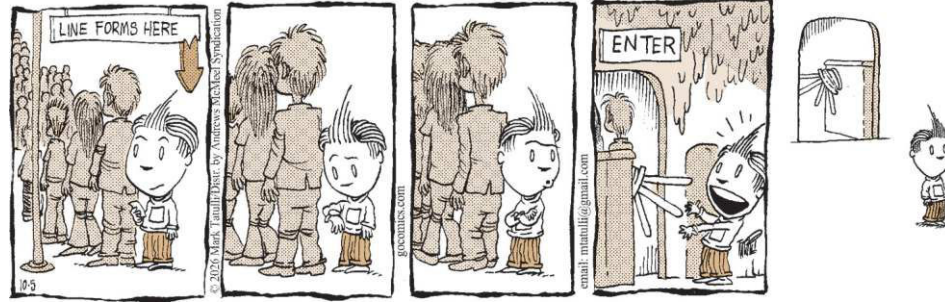
LOOSE PARTS By Dave Blazek



PEARLS BEFORE SWINE By Stephan Pastis



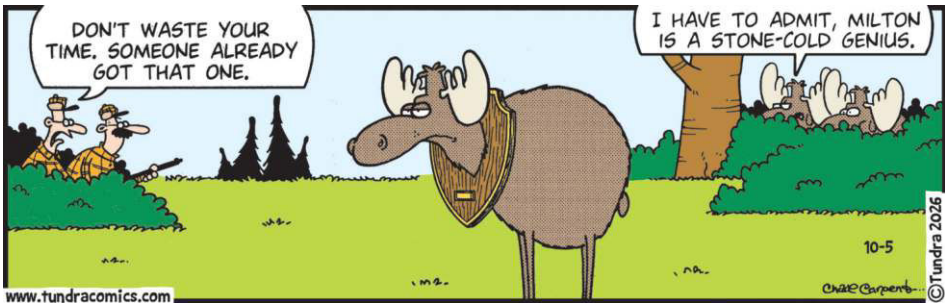
LIO By Mark Tatulli



ZITS By Jerry Scott & Jim Borgman



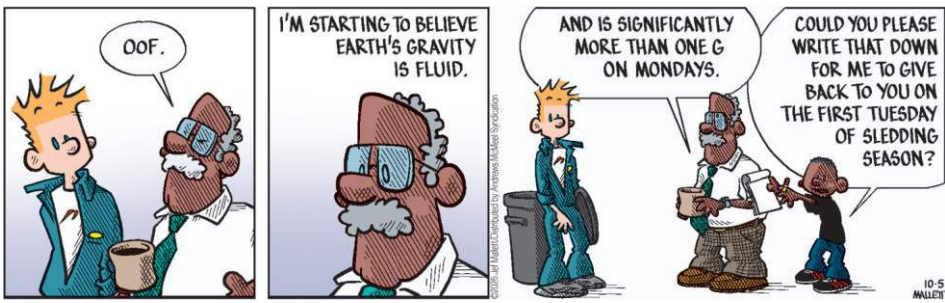
TUNDRA By Chad Carpenter



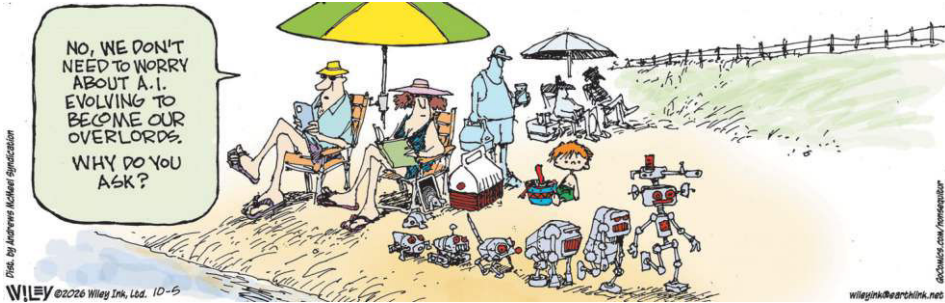
SIX CHIX By Isabella Bannerman



FRAZZ By Jef Mallett



NON SEQUITUR By Wiley



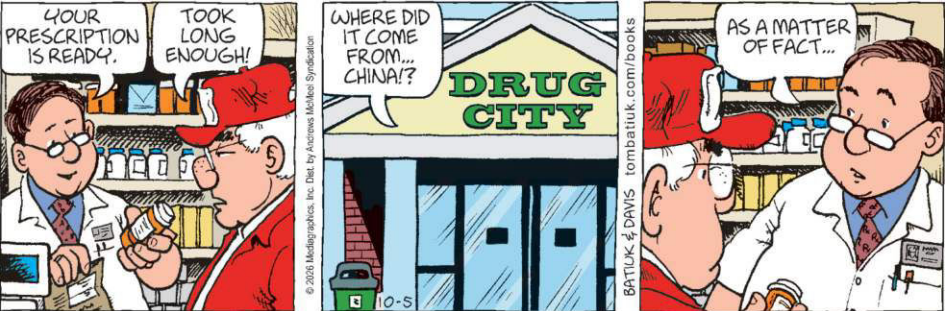
PICKLES By Brian Crane



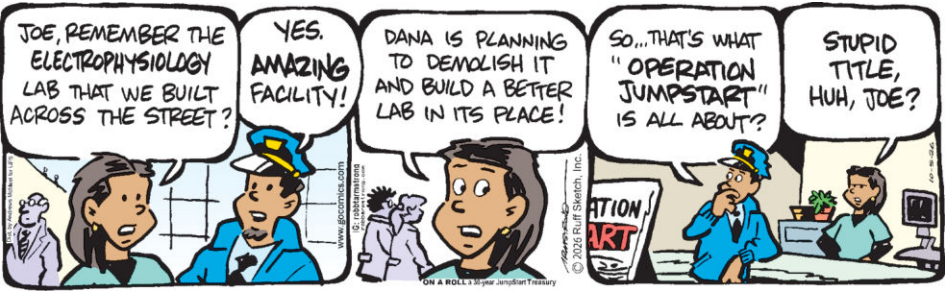
BABY BLUES By Jerry Scott & Rick Kirkman



CRANKSHAFT By Tom Batiuk & Chuck Ayers



JUMP START By Robb Armstrong



MACANUDO By Liniers



BLONDIE By Dean Young & John Marshall



BETWEEN FRIENDS By Sandra Bell-Lundy



BIZARRO By Wayno and Piraro



DRABBLE By Kevin Fagan



MUTTS By Patrick McDonnell

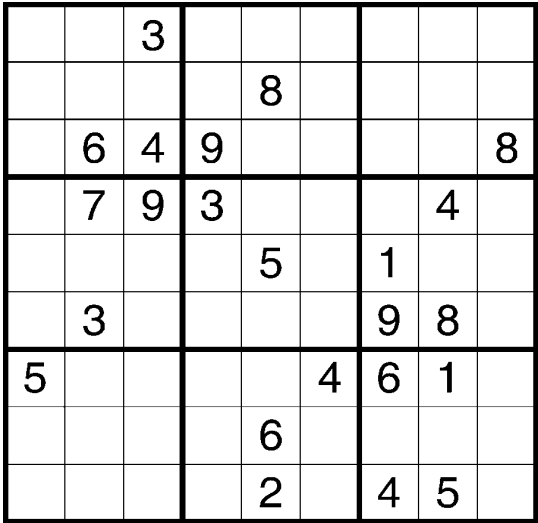


PEANUTS By Charles M. Schulz



COMICS

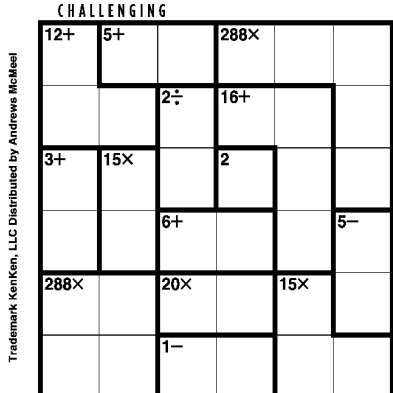
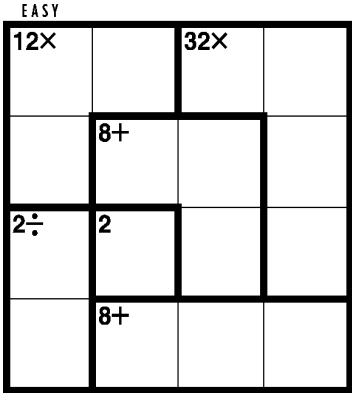
SUDOKU



©2026 The Mepham Group. Distributed by Tribune Content Agency. All rights reserved. Complete the grid so each row, column and 3-by-3 box contains every digit from 1 to 9 (or 1 to 6 for the smaller grid). For strategies on how to solve Sudoku, visit www.sudoku.org.uk.

KENKEN

Every box will contain a number; numbers depend on the size of the grid. For a 6x6 puzzle, use Nos. 1-6. Do not repeat a number in any row or column. The numbers in each heavily outlined set of squares must combine to produce the target number found in the top left corner of the cage using the mathematical operation indicated. A number can be repeated within a cage as long as it is not in the same row or column.



HOROSCOPE

By HOLIDAY MATHIS

Aries (March 21-April 19). An idea can just be fun and doesn't have to save anyone. Take the pressure off and dream a little.

Taurus (April 20-May 20). Love doesn't always have to be about duty. Feeling like you're always "on duty" around someone might be a sign that the distribution of work is lopsided.

Gemini (May 21-June 21). You can avoid problems by listening better or being curious about where other people are coming from.

Cancer (June 22-July 22). When you're having trouble motivating yourself, make the plans smaller.

Leo (July 23-Aug. 22). There's an amount of distance that tends to work best for the relationship, which you'll find through trial and error.

Virgo (Aug. 23-Sept. 22). People will say it can't be

done, but you are already doing it. But keep this quiet until you've worked out how to present it.

Libra (Sept. 23-Oct. 23). It has always been OK for you to know your own strength and beauty, though you have often been discouraged from letting others know that you know.

Scorpio (Oct. 24-Nov. 21). Movement begets movement. Any small change will put a more significant change in motion.

Sagittarius (Nov. 22-Dec. 21). You'll offer relief to someone in their moment of suffering, no questions asked.

Capricorn (Dec. 22-Jan. 19). Your task list has reached an overwhelming length. Start passing it around. You might be surprised who has been wanting to help you.

Aquarius (Jan. 20-Feb. 18). There are at least a thousand routes to the destination you have planned, yours

being as valid as any.

Pisces (Feb. 19-March 20). You really are doing what you most want to do, even when you're doing a tedious piece of work.

Today's birthday (Oct. 5). In your Year of the Key Guest, people invite you into rooms where important things are happening, and you'll be a part of what's decided or created there. You will drill down on a special interest, resulting in special bonds, rare experiences and a project that pays you well. More highlights: You'll transform a place where you spend a lot of time. You'll embark on adventures with a small group. The money and justice you've had coming find their way to you. Gemini and Cancer adore you. Your lucky numbers are: 4, 16, 8, 21 and 50.

Mathis writes her column for Creators Syndicate Inc. The horoscope should be read for entertainment.

CROSSWORD

Edited By Patti Varol
By Amanda Cook

- ACROSS**
- 1 Tiny trims
 - 6 "Tar" Oscar nominee Blanchett
 - 10 Jar topper
 - 13 Art studio stand
 - 14 Chocolate-flavored latte
 - 15 Fuss
 - 16 Playful back-and-forth
 - 18 Church seating
 - 19 Messy person
 - 20 Word with ocean or eye
 - 21 Skim through
 - 22 Wear away
 - 24 Sprawling property
 - 26 Workstation option since the 1980s
 - 30 Rainbow maker
 - 31 Attempted
 - 32 Bath rug
 - 33 Old hoops org.
 - 36 Genetic material
 - 37 Polo shirt, e.g.
 - 40 Power strip switch
 - 42 Not exactly, informally
 - 44 Ticket pickup location
 - 49 Battery terminals
 - 50 Punchiness
 - 51 See 58-Across
 - 52 Crown for a prom queen
 - 54 Wanes
 - 58 With 51-Across, dance accessory for Fred Astaire
 - 59 Time off that may coincide with a new calendar year, or what can be found in 16-, 26-, and 44-Across
 - 61 Connecticut Ivy Leaguer
 - 62 Derive
 - 63 Possibly dangerous
 - 64 Cozy burrow
 - 65 Composer Stravinsky
 - 66 River mammal
- DOWN**
- 1 Does some alterations
 - 2 Place for cuticle oil
 - 3 Analogy words
 - 4 Spots where dogs may sit, lie down, and roll over
 - 5 Clever
 - 6 Meet over coffee, perhaps
 - 7 Entr'__



BRIDGE

By FRANK STEWART

"If at first you don't succeed, rummage through the wastebasket in a desperate attempt to find the instructions." — Cy the Cynic

The problem some players have as declarer is that if at first they don't succeed, that's the end of it all. Against today's 3NT, West led the queen of hearts, and South took the ace and wanted the next eight tricks. He took the A-Q of spades and led a third spade to his king. A 3-3 break would have seen him home, but West pitched a club.

Declarer next led a club to dummy's ace and a club to his jack. Alas, West produced the queen, and the defense took four hearts and the 10 of spades Down two.

South didn't succeed at first — or at second. He should have tried playing third. After the spades fail to break, South should take the A-K of diamonds. (He has eight diamonds and seven clubs, so the queen of diamonds is more likely to fall.)

When West's queen appears, South makes an over-trick. If instead East-West played low, South would finesse in clubs.

You hold: ♠ A Q 4 ♥ 4 2 ♦ A 7 3 2 ♣ A 6 4 2. You open one diamond, and your partner bids one spade. The opponents pass. Now what?

Answer: To bid two clubs next would be an error. You would suggest a two-suited hand when your actual hand is balanced, and your partner would correctly return to two diamonds with a weak responding hand and 5-4-2-2

pattern. Raise to two spades. Like some players, I would have preferred to open one club.

South dealer
N-S vulnerable

NORTH
♠ A Q 4
♥ 4 2
♦ A 7 3 2
♣ A 6 4 2

WEST
♠ J 9
♥ Q J 10 6 5
♦ Q 8
♣ Q 10 8 5

EAST
♠ 10 8 5 3
♥ K 9 8 7
♦ 10 9 5
♣ 9 7

SOUTH
♠ K 7 6 2
♥ A 3
♦ K J 6 4
♣ K J 3

SOUTH 1 NT
WEST Pass
NORTH 3 NT
EAST All Pass

Opening lead — ♥ Q

Tribune Content Agency

ASKING ERIC

Dear Eric: I have been divorced for 39 years. I am 70 years old. Sporadically I pursue dates through apps.

Recently the men who I have reached out to and communicated with will immediately start informing me what they like to do to women and or what they like done to them sexually.

That would be fine in a week or two and/or after a couple dates, but within 24 hours of messaging, I just think it's too much too soon. I know it has always been said that men think of sex a lot more than women. However, I just find it surprising that at their ages, their mind is still approaching the topic so soon. Please advise if I am overreacting.

DATING DILEMMA

Dear Dating: You are not overreacting at all. For some people, these kinds of conversations early in a dating app conversation would be no problem. But they do pose a problem for you and that's important. You don't have to change your ways or engage in conversations that make you uncomfortable.

If you encounter a man who does this and you decide you want to give him another chance, you can always tell him, "This line of conversation has gotten too intimate for now. Can we reset?" Ideally, he would recognize where he went wrong

and course correct.

But the fact that these men are jumping right to sex talk without any indication on your end that's welcome indicates they just might not be matches. You might also look into apps that place a few more steps between matching and conversation.

Dear Eric: My husband is one of three brothers and a sister. Their mother died when they were young. When their dad died, the youngest brother professed the need for us all to stay in touch.

This brother and his wife live 15 minutes from the other brothers, but they never reach out. They attend some family gatherings but never suggest a get-together or even call to check in.

When their sister died, there were two memorials. They attended the first one but ghosted everyone for the second one. Emails and text messages were sent in advance. The messages were "read." My husband even called his brother that day with no answer. No call back.

Recently we decided to get together for lunch. We texted them and again the message was "read," but we got no response.

We had to learn of a death in the wife's family by reading it in the local newspaper and of her hospitalization from her social media post. I understand privacy when

you're sick, but a brief message would have been appreciated. Instead, we see a social media post saying, "As most of you know I spent my birthday in the hospital. ..."

I'm offended by their disrespect for the family. My feelings are hurt for their sister and her kids.

The brothers brush it off so why am I upset? Am I unjustified?

SISTER-IN-LAW

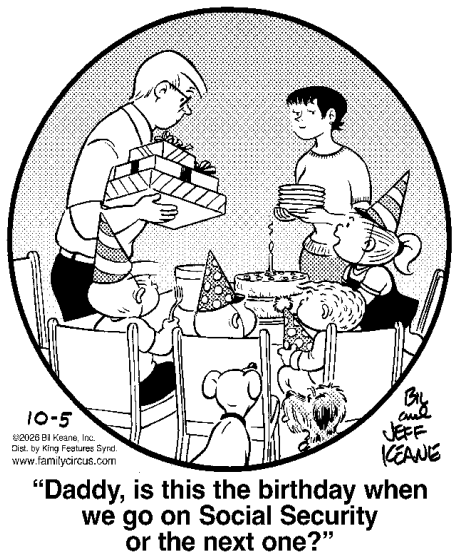
Dear Sister-in-Law: You're part of this family, too, so you're not totally off base. But it does seem that your husband and his brothers have reached a point of accepting their youngest sibling's style of communication and ability to show up (or lack thereof).

There isn't a way for the brother to go back and attend the second memorial, so while your feelings are hurt on behalf of the sister's kids, it may be best to redirect your energies to showing up for them wherever they are in their grieving process.

You may be justified in being upset with your brother-in-law and his wife, and you could say something to them if you want. But your time may be better spent cultivating relationships with the people who do show up for the family.

Email questions to eric@askingeric.com.

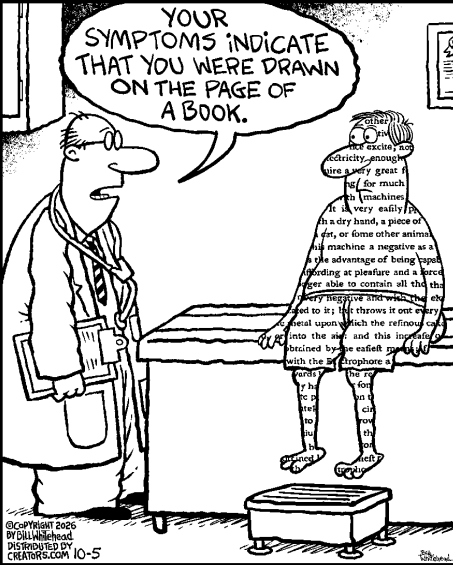
FAMILY CIRCUS By Bil Keane



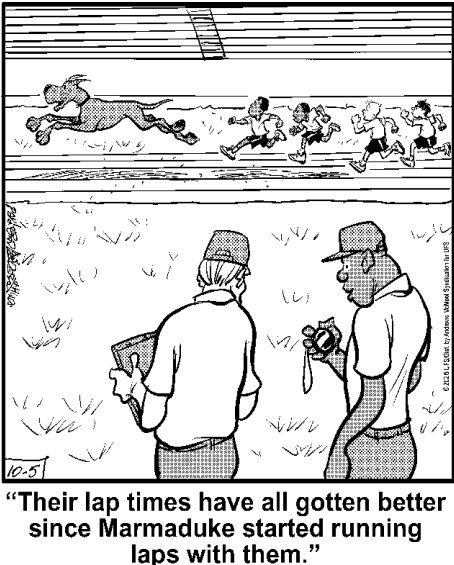
DENNIS THE MENACE By Hank Ketcham



FREE RANGE By Bill Whitehead



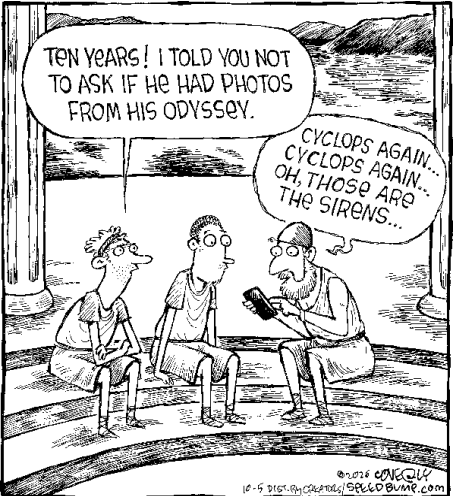
MARMADUKE By Brad & Paul Anderson



BLISS By Harry Bliss



SPEED BUMP By Dave Coverly



A jazz club roves in L.A.

[**JJJJ's**, from E1] Jazz Club” — an homage to her cat and Hayao Miyazaki’s animated film “Kiki’s Delivery Service” — hadn’t even been conceived yet. She only told her friends about the event she was throwing, but word traveled and her studio was packed.

“I cleared out everything in the tattoo studio,” she says, showing us a video of that first event. “You can still see my stencils in the background! I rented a U-Haul and put all of my stuff in it for the night. I changed the room into a stage and invited a bunch of friends, and made tea and dim sum for an open jam.”

The first event was such a success, she decided to do it again the following month. Attendance grew with each subsequent show, and eventually nearly 200 people thirsty for jazz consistently showed up to her tattoo studio for music. “I was like, ‘Oh my God, my security deposit!’”

JJJJ’s officially outgrew the studio and moved to a now-defunct venue known as the Resident. But, even in a bigger location, JJJJ’s quickly started pulling in around 500 people.

Norasingh continued tattooing while throwing out-of-pocket jazz shows on the side. But the success of the events ushered in a momentum shift. As a spiritual person, Norasingh waited for the right moon phase and began pouring into her journal, essentially writing down incantations, to manifest a future aligned with the person she felt she was becoming.

“I just started writing down that I give permission to the universe to take away the things that are keeping me distracted versus focus,” she tells us. “I wrote down that I want to live in my truth and that I am built to carry the weight of the work I need to do and that I am built to survive both the negatives and positives that come with life ... and then the next day my [tattoo] machine got stolen out of my car after doing a tattoo pop-up and accidentally leaving it in there. I never do that!”

She says tattooing was her only means of income at the time. “I didn’t panic. I was like, ‘Well, I guess I’ll just give everything I got to JJJJ’s.’”

When she talks about JJJJ’s, Norasingh, whose voluminous black curls and infectious smile command attention, describes it less as a business than as a spiritual vocation. It isn’t about the money, she says. It’s about gathering as an act of resistance in honor of a genre that has carried resistance from its inception.

“JJJJ’s is not necessarily



Photographs by BRIAN FEINZIMER For The Times

DeVAUGHN Durham and Gengis Don at “Can’t Cancel Jazz” presented by JJJJ’s Jazz Club in August after L.A. Jazz Festival was canceled.

profitable at the moment,” she says. “But I get so much in return for it that, when thinking in terms of a business standard, it’s an investment for the future. For me, I see live music and gatherings as an act of protest. I’m more than willing to not only give my money, but also to give my internal resources, my energy, my sleep. The second I see people gather is the second I feel rested. It is so spiritual for me.”

It’s this passion that spurred her into action when the ambitious and highly anticipated L.A. Jazz Festival fell through in mid-August, leaving dozens of jazz artists — including local acts and legends — with nowhere to perform and out the money they were promised. The team behind JJJJ’s Jazz Club rallied to do what it always does: Fill a void. JJJJ’s collaborated with eight stranded artists and musicians to host a pop-up show, giving them a venue to perform and giving the city back a jazz experience that was ripped out from under it.

“When news dropped that the L.A. Jazz Fest was canceled, my heart broke,” Norasingh says. “I love this city. ... My heart hurt for the musicians that were proud to be [part of] something that was supposed to be somewhat historic. It was a no-questions-asked decision to do something for some of those affected.”

The idea came from Gengis Don, an L.A.-based drummer/artist, previous JJJJ’s performer and friend of Norasingh. In collaboration with him, Cass from Fresh Sounds and JJJJ’s Jazz Club, the event came together the way it did because of the hands willing to help.

The instinct to create a space for people to gather, even in the aftermath of another event collapsing, is what Norasingh means by the word “club” in JJJJ’s Jazz



TIDA Norasingh’s JJJJ’S worked with artists and musicians to host a show after the fest was canceled.

Club. It refers to a group, community or culture people belong to — not just a static venue people file into for an event. JJJJ’s, in effect, is a vehicle for third spaces, or social environments separate from home, work or school, that have sharply declined over the last decade. According to a 2024 American Enterprise Institute survey, more than 1 in 5 Americans live in communities with no access to the 10 most common types of public or commercial gathering spaces. And the ones that remain are increasingly either too expensive for the average American or are designed to discourage lingering to create more turnover and, thus, profits.

“It’s expensive to be alive,” she says. “It’s expensive to even just walk outside and breathe. The world is already so complicated and we go through so much. And I think complicating the act of gathering are the pressures of money and capitalism and social standards.”

A few other pop-up jazz events exist around L.A. these days. It makes sense considering JJJJ’s Jazz Club exists within the greater context of what musicians and promoters keep referring to as L.A.’s “jazz renaissance.” And while the city’s jazz history runs deep, the scene largely faded once other genres, like R&B and rock ’n’ roll, took over many



TRAMISHA Vaughn and LaShawnda Wallace cheer on performers at pop-up show “Can’t Cancel Jazz.”



GENGIS Don introduces performers at the “Can’t Cancel Jazz” show at the Slow Jamz Gallery in L.A.

decades ago. Now, however, there seem to be more accessible jazz shows in the city than at any other time in recent history. The question of competition comes up in conversation with Norasingh, but she’s quick to squash it.

“Someone asked me the other day if I see this other third space as competition,” she says, “and I was like, ‘well, no. That’s just more resource for gathering.’ That’s more resource for whatever this is. I don’t own the idea of a third space. I don’t coin the ‘open jams.’ I can only control the way I carry my brand.”

And Norasingh has big plans for the future of her brand. But calling it a

“brand” feels reductive. Like Miyazaki, Norasingh is world building. Recently the club posted a lineup of October events just in time for black cat season, including a sip and paint night, album listening parties and a “JJJJ’s Halloween Jazz Mass.” On top of JJJJ’s Jazz Club, there’s JJJJ’s Film Club, JJJJ’s Jazz Lounge — a slow jamz spin off — and soon there will be JJJJ’s Jazz Journal, the project’s newspaper.

“JJJJ’s is centered around jazz,” she says. “But once you step into the world, you realize that we’re also highlighting film and analog media and we encourage people to read books and just consume art that shapes who you are.”

Name of Ellison’s new megastudio sends a message

[**Ellison**, from E1] Ellison has engaged in some high-flying ... well, courtship might not be the right term for the dizzying mix of cajoling and threats he employed to get the deal done, and it does not seem fair to the American woodcock. I’m no expert, but I don’t think their mating rituals involve using the New York Times to plead their case or, when that doesn’t work, threatening to move en masse to Tennessee.

For those inexplicably hoping for ParaBros, Skydance seems a bit of a let-down, especially considering all the trouble Ellison went to. It’s been quite a show, the various razzle-dazzle versus strong arm tactics (not to mention the Middle Eastern money) he mobilized to turn two of Hollywood’s preeminent founding studios into ingredients in sub-brand stew that also includes CNN, HBO Max, CBS, DC Comics, Nickelodeon, MTV and Food Network.

Overseeing such a diverse mix is too big a job for one person so Ellison added yet another flavor by drafting Ynon Kreiz as co-chief executive. Kreiz was previously chairman and chief



ALBERTO PEZZALI Associated Press

WITH THE name Skydance, David Ellison is making a swath of Hollywood his.

executive of Mattel, where he facilitated the toy company’s big Hollywood push with “Barbie,” “Masters of the Universe” and the upcoming Hot Wheels movie. (Polly Pocket, now in development at Reese Witherspoon’s Sunshine Produc-

tions, should be preparing for her close-up.)

By sticking with Skydance, Ellison is not just making a large swath of Hollywood indisputably his own, he’s showing remarkable confidence in a name that first came to many peo-

ple’s attention in 2019 when he hired John Lasseter.

Six months after Walt Disney Co. ended its relationship with the then-chief creative officer of Pixar and Disney Animation Studios following an investigation into multiple accusations of

sexual harassment and workplace misconduct, Ellison hired him to oversee Skydance Animation.

Unsurprisingly, this led to all manner of protest, within and outside the company. When Emma Thompson learned of Lasseter joining Skydance, she withdrew from its highly anticipated upcoming animated film “Luck.” In a stinging letter she sent to the company at the time (and allowed The Times to make public), she wrote: “It feels very odd to me that you and your company would consider hiring someone with Mr. Lasseter’s pattern of misconduct given the present climate in which people with the kind of power that you have can reasonably be expected to step up to the plate.”

Lasseter was not Skydance’s only controversial hire. After merging with Paramount, the company made deals with or hired multiple men, including Brett Ratner, Max Landis and Jeff Shell, who had been accused of sexual harassment and/or misconduct.

Shell was made president of Paramount less than three years after losing his job as NBCUniversal chief

executive following the disclosure of an “inappropriate relationship” with an NBC employee. He stepped down from Paramount in April after a months-long legal battle with a Las Vegas gambler and self-described “fixer” who claimed that Shell had reneged on a deal to develop a series in exchange for free crisis control.

Now, of course, all of that is ancient history. Now Paramount is merely a sub-brand and Hollywood is less concerned with whom Skydance hired as it is with whom, and how many, Skydance will fire.

Also how the CNN/CBS oversight committee Ellison agreed to create as part of the settlement with 12 states is going to work. And what will happen if Skydance does not release 30 new films each year, which Ellison has promised to do as part of the settlement deal. And how expensive the new Skydance streaming bundles are going to be. And if, perhaps, in some language “Skydance” translates to “the end of the entertainment industry as we know it.”

Most important, is it too late for the American woodcock to sue?